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GOVT. OF ODISHA 25001/1415/2627

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER , RURAL WORKS CIRCLE: KENDUJHAR
email: se_nerwkjr@rediffmail.com

eProcurement Notice for Road, Building & Bridge Works
Bid Identification No. NCB-22 / RWCKJR / 2026-27
No. 5618 // Date : 27.10.26 //

1. Name of the work :- Construction of Road Works under MMSY (Mission PoWaR), Bridge Works under Setu Bandhan Yojana & Building Works in the District of Kendujhar
2. No. of work :- 07 (Seven) Nos
3. Estimated Cost :- As per Annexure in NIT.
4. Class of Contractor (Eligible) :- As per Annexure in NIT.
5. Period of Completion :- As per Annexure in NIT.
6. Other details

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No	Availability of tender On-line for bidding From	To	Last Date & Time of seeking Tender Clarification	Date & Time of Opening of Tender in O/O C.C.E., R.W. Circle, Kendujhar Technical Bid	Financial Bid
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Kendujhar	NCB-22 / RWCKJR / 2026-27	Dt.04.11.26 at 11.00 A.M.	Dt.18.11.26 up to 5.00 P.M.	Dt.17.11.26 up to 5.00 P.M.	Dt.19.11.26 at 11.00 A.M.	Will be intimated later

* Further details can be seen from the website: **www.tendersorissa.gov.in**

Chief Engineer,
R.W. Circle, Kendujhar

OIPR - 25001/251717/1/26-27/0024

SHREE SAIBABA SANSTHAN TRUST, SHIRDI.
Post. Shirdi, Tal. Rahata, Dist. Ahilyanagar,
Pin - 423109 Phone No. (02423) 258500, 258989
E mail: electrical.dept@sai.org.in.
Website: www.sai.org.in

Shree Saibaba Sansthan Trust, Shirdi Invites online e-tenders from eligible contractors / suppliers / firms / manufactures for "THE DESIGN. ENGINEERING, SUPPLY, ERECTION, INSTALLATION, TESTING & COMMISSIONING FOR 1900 KWP GRID CONNECTED GROUND MOUNTED SOLAR PV PROJECT WITH 5 YEARS O&M AT SHREE SAIBABA SANSTHAN TRUST SHIRDI, MAHARASHTRA"

The tender details will be available on **https://mahatenders.gov.in** for downloading. For details and terms & conditions visit our website **www.sai.org.in**.

Tender Publishing Start Date	:-	02-11-2026 at 11.00 AM
Pre-Bid Meeting Date & Time	:-	13-11-2026 at 11.00 AM
Place of Pre -Bid Meeting	:-	"Sai Sabhagruh" Meeting Hall, Near P.R.O. Office, Shirdi
Last Date for Online Submission	:-	23-11-2026 Up to 05.00 PM

(Goraksha Gadilkar, I.A.S.)
DGIPR/2026-27/ROC 3525 **Chief Executive Officer.**

Additional Principal Chief Conservator of Forest (JFM)
Department of Forest & Climate Change
Aranya Bhawan, Sector 19, North Block, Nava Raipur (C.G.)
Phone: 0771-2512828, Mail: apccf_jfm@rediffmail.com
Website: www.forest.cg.gov.in

Request for Proposal for Redevelopment of Nandan Van on PPP Mode

The undersigned intends to select an eligible bidder for the redevelopment of Nandan Van on a DBFOT basis. Interested bidders may download the RFP from the above-mentioned website and submit their bids through the Chhattisgarh e-Procurement Portal at **https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in/**by 23.11.2026.

APCCF (JFM)
G-262704316/2 **Chhattisgarh, Naya Raipur**

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BMSICL **Govt. of Bihar**

Bihar Medical Services & Infrastructure Corporation Limited
2nd & 3rd Floor, Swasthya Bhawan, Behind IGIMS,
Sheikhpura, Adjacent to State Health Society, Bihar, Patna- 800014
Phone/Fax: +919006405255, + 919471009193

TENDER NOTICE

Tender for rate contract and supply of Medical Devices/Consumables for different healthcare facilities of state of Bihar

Notice Inviting Tender Ref No.: -BMSIC/MEDICAL DEVICES/CONSUMABLES/26-06
(Only through E- Tender on website: -www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)

Bihar Medical Services and Infrastructure Corporation Limited (BMSICL) invites E-Bids from the interested parties for **"Tender for rate contract and supply of Medical Devices/Consumables for different healthcare facilities of state of Bihar"**, vide Notice Inviting Tender No.- **BMSIC/MEDICAL DEVICES/CONSUMABLES/26-06**. Detailed tender document containing eligibility criteria, selection mechanism, other terms and conditions are available on the website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in.

Tender Schedule

Tender Reference No.	**BMSIC/MEDICAL DEVICES/CONSUMABLES/26-06**
Date of Pre-Bid meeting	06th November 2026 at 02:30 P.M. at BMSICL Conference Hall, 3rd Floor, Swasthya Bhawan, Behind IGIMS, Sheikhpura, Adjacent to State Health Society, Bihar, Patna - 800014
Last date and time of submission of online bids	25th November 2026 by 05:00 P.M.
Last date and time for submission of EMD and Tender Fees	27th November 2026 till 02:00 P.M.
Date, Time and Place of opening of Technical Bid	27th November 2026 (at 03:00 P.M.) on the website of www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in in the office of BMSICL
Date and time of opening of Financial Bids	To be announced later on www.bmsicl.gov.in and www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in
Validity of Tender	180 Days
Cost of the tender document	Rs. 11,800/- (Eleven Thousand Eight Hundred only) Non-refundable.

GM (Procurement)
PR. No. 014578 (B&C) 2026-27 **BMSICL**

This information is available on website **www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar** also

रक्त की आवश्यकता पड़ने पर लाईसेंस प्राप्त ब्लड बैंकों से ही रक्त प्राप्त करें।

Govt. of Bihar

बिहार शिक्षा परियोजना परिषद
शिक्षा भवन, राष्ट्रपति परिषद, परिसर
सैदपुर, राजेन्द्र नगर, पटना–800004

NOTICE INVITING RFP
(https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in).

I. Bihar Education Project Council (BEPC), Patna, invites "Supply of Library Booksin Government Schools of Bihar for the year 2026-27".

II. The complete RFP documents can be seen on and downloaded from the website https://www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in and our official website **https://bepcssa.in.**

iii. Schedule of Events:

Sl.	Information	Details
1	RFP Issuing Authority	State Project Director, Bihar Education Project Council (BEPC)
2	RFP No. and Date of availability from e - procurement portal	RFP Reference No. **BEPC/LB/2026-27/5223, Dated 29/10/2026** Available for download from **30/10/2026, 11:00 AM** onwards till **19/11/2026, 3:00 PM** on https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in
3	Last date for submission of written queries for clarifications	**04/11/2026, 02:30 PM** Email: ssabihar@gmail.com
4	Date of pre-bid conference	**05/11/2026, 03:30 PM** at through online mode Google Meet joining info Video call link: https://meet.google.com/tnt-yoee-kzs e-mail: ssabihar@gmail.com
5	Release of response to clarifications	**06/11/2026, 5:00 PM**
6	Last date of submission of bid	**19/11/2026, 4:00 PM**
7	Last date of submission of Hard copy of EMD	**19/11/2026, 4:00 PM**
8	Last date of submission of Sample (Before bid submission closing date & Time)	**19/11/2026, 4:00 PM**
9	Opening of Technical Bids	**19/11/2026, 4:30 PM**
10	Opening of Financial Bids	To be intimated
11	Contact person for queries	State Project Director, Bihar Education Project Council (BEPC), Shiksha Bhawan, Bihar Rashtra Bhasha Parishad Campus, Saidpur - 800 004., e-mail : ssabihar@gmail.com

For further details please visit : **www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar**

PR- 014594 (B & C) 2026-27 **State Project Director**
Bihar Education Project Council

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CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvnl.com

Letter No: 1025 **e-Tender Notice** Date: 31/10/2026

The office of Executive Engineer Project Distribution Division, Dakpathar (D.Dun) invites online bids from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:-

Tender No. E-PDD-10/2026-27
Name of Work: Annual Operation of 33 kV S/S, 11 kV S/S & DG sets at DPH Khodri under PDD.
Estimated cost : Rs. 33,92,724/- + GST extra
Date of availability of bid document on website : 02.11.2026 from 18:00 Hrs.
Last date for submission of bid on website: 23.11.2026 Upto 16.00 Hrs.
For eligibility criteria and full & further details, kindly visit e- procurement portal **"https://uktenders.gov.in/".**

Executive Engineer, PDD

"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

Government of Assam
Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA)
Assam Integrated River Basin Management Project (AIRBMP)

Ecf no. 381536/397

NOTICE INVITING REQUEST FOR BIDS (RFB)

The Chief Executive Officer, Assam State Disaster Management Authority, invites bids for the following assignment through the e-procurement process (Single StageTwo-Envelope Bidding Process) :

Sl. No.	Assignment Name and Reference	RFB Download Start Date and Time	Bid Submission Deadline
1	Supply, Installation and Commissioning of ESE type Lightning Arrester for Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA) under Assam Integrated River Basin Management Program (AIRBMP) **RFB Ref. No. IN- ASDMA-579344-GO-RFB**	02/11/2026 at 15.00 Hours	01/12/2026 upto 15:00 Hours

Bids must be submitted online through the website. https://assamtenders.gov.in The complete bidding document, including information regarding bid security and other requirements, may be downloaded by interested eligible bidders from the website. Bidders are required to obtain a Digital Signature Certificate (DSC) for submission of bids on the portal https://assamtenders.gov.in. Any amendment / corrigendum issued in future against the above tender shall be uploaded on https://assamtenders.gov.in only.

Sd/-
Chief Executive Officer
DIPR /CF/HT/2157/2-Nov-26 **Assam State Disaster Management Authority**

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2nd–5th November 2026
Bharat Mandapam,
New Delhi

Inauguration by
Shri Narendra Modi
Hon'ble Prime Minister
2 November 2026 | 16:30 hours onwards

75,000+	80+	20+	130+	400+	32,000 sqm
Participants Expected	Sessions	States	Countries	Exhibitors	Exhibition Space

India's Clean Energy Leadership: 2014 vs Now

Installed non-fossil power capacity	Installed solar power capacity
308 GW	171 GW
vs 81.16 GW in 2014	vs 2.82 GW in 2014
Solar module manufacturing capacity	**Installed wind power capacity**
226 GW	59.20 GW
vs 2.3 GW in 2014	vs 21.04 GW in 2014

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Benefiting from PM Surya Ghar rooftop solar

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NEW DELHI/METRO
Monday, November 02, 2026

Hindustan Times
FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Oppn marches together in display of force against CEC

Saubhadra Chatterji
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Leaders of the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) came together on Sunday for the largest Opposition mobilisation in recent years, renewing calls for the removal of chief election commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, and saying he will be jailed for treason in the future.

After headlining a march that snaked through central Delhi for more than an hour and a rally attended by thousands of people, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi also trained his guns at the government, saying Prime Minister Narendra Modi and home minister Amit Shah will not be allowed to escape the law.

"The first step to bring the country back on track is to remove Gyanesh Kumar. Amit Shah had said that Modi will not go anywhere. I am telling you, Narendra Modi can't go anywhere. We will not allow him to go. After Gyanesh Kumar, we will face you. There will be legal proceedings against Modi and Amit Shah. The country will get justice," Gandhi told the audience at Ramlila Maidan, one of the three new designated protest sites in the Capital.

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) hit back with parallel rallies of its own and alleged that Gandhi, also the leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, was acting at the behest of foreign powers to create anarchy in the country.

The Opposition march and rally is the largest show of strength by the INDIA bloc, which has been pushing for Kumar's removal over allegations of irregularities in the functioning of the Election Commission of India and the special intensive revision, which has already removed 130 million names from India's electoral rolls, many of them under absent, shifted or dead catego-

continued on →7

INDIA bloc leaders including Rahul Gandhi, Akhilesh Yadav, Mamata Banerjee, Farooq Abdullah and Tejashwi Yadav in an open-top vehicle during the rally from Connaught Place to Ramlila Maidan on Sunday. SANCHIT KHANNA/HT PHOTO

BJP HITS BACK, CALLS RALLY 'CALCULATED PLOT', 'ANARCHY BID'

The BJP on Sunday branded the Opposition INDIA bloc's rally a "calculated conspiracy" to push the country into anarchy, and countered it with "padyatras" and press conferences across the country. The party's leaders also dismissed the turnout, saying that large parts of the Ramlila Maidan were empty. →P9

OVER 50 PROTESTERS BRIEFLY HELD, MARCH PASSES OFF PEACEFULLY

Police said over 50 protesters were briefly detained on Sunday, even as the INDIA bloc rally, which drew tens of thousands of participants, unfolded peacefully and without any untoward incident. Officers said the detentions were after the rally as a few protesters went towards Minto Road, where restrictions were in place. →P8

BJP, OPPN TRADE BARBS AS TRADERS SAY LOST CUSTOMERS

The Opposition and BJP blamed each other as traders in Connaught Place reported a drop in sales on the last Sunday before Diwali. Union minister JP Nadda accused the Opposition of disrupting business during the festive season. LoP in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi in turn accused the BJP of pressuring shopkeepers to shut stores. →P8

Rahul can only be PM in mock Parl, says Shah

HTC and agencies
letters@hindustantimes.com

CHANDIGARH: Union home minister Amit Shah on Sunday launched a sharp attack on Rahul Gandhi over the INDIA bloc rally at Ramlila Maidan in Delhi, saying the Congress leader had chosen November 1, a date associated with the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, to hold a 'jalsa', and that if he wanted to become prime minister, he should stay in a "mock parliament" his entire life.

"If you desire to hold a 'jalsa' for the Congress party on such a dark day of genocide, then Rahul ji, no one will be able to take anything except hatred from your 'mohabbat ki dukaan'," Shah said at an event in Chandigarh.

Shah said the Congress had been losing elections for 15 years and that Sonia Gandhi's "dream of seeing her son become prime minister" remained unfulfilled. "For fifteen years — effectively spanning three elections — he has been losing. Sonia-ji's dream of seeing her son become Prime Minister remains unfulfilled. She has come up with a new approach: holding a 'mock parliament.' I would like to tell Rahul-ji: if you want to be Prime Minister, then just stay in a 'mock parliament' for the rest of your life — because your turn is never going to come," he said.

Shah also accused the Opposition of spreading lies, creating anarchy and negativity, and preventing Parliament from functioning. "Lying, spreading chaos, propagating negativity, obstructing the functioning of Parliament, and taking parliamentary issues to the streets to create a ruckus — if this has been your [Cong] nature, then get ready to spend another five years in the opposition," he said.

He accused the INDIA bloc of questioning the Election Commission because it had lost elections in some states, while accepting the people's mandate where it had won. Shah described this as "politics of convenience" and said the Opposition was unable to offer a constructive political alternative.

Shah also alleged that Gandhi was disrupting Parliament to prevent women from receiving 33% reservation. "Rahul ji, you disrupt the functioning of Par-

continued on →7

"Lying, spreading chaos, propagating negativity, obstructing the functioning of Parliament, and taking parliamentary issues to the streets to create a ruckus—if this has been your [Cong] nature, then get ready to spend another five years in the opposition."
— AMIT SHAH, Union home minister

CBI brings Mahadev betting app kingpin to India from Oman

Neeraj Chauhan
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), along with other agencies, has extradited Sourabh Chandrakar — the mastermind behind the ₹6,000-crore Mahadev online gambling syndicate — from Oman, officials said.

"CBI, in coordination with other central agencies has successfully secured the extradition of Sourabh Chandrakar, the promoter of the Mahadev App illegal betting syndicate, from the Sultanate of Oman. A CBI team specially deputed to Oman, has escorted him back to India. He will now be produced before the CBI special court in Raipur," a CBI spokesperson said in a statement on Sunday.

Chandrakar, in his 30s, was wanted by multiple agencies including the Enforcement Directorate (ED) and Chhattisgarh police.

One of the most wanted individuals in connection with the racket, Chandrakar set up the Mahadev betting empire along with co-founder Ravi Uppal. The two fled to Dubai sometime in 2019. According to an ED investigation, their network still runs betting apps and websites from there. Based on an Interpol red notice, the UAE authorities briefly detained Chandrakar in October 2024 and kept him under house arrest. The same month, India sent an extradition request for him which was not executed, "thereby making it infructuous".

HT reported on November 4, 2025, that Ravi Uppal had gone missing from the UAE after authorities in the Gulf country decided to close extradition proceedings against him. Sometime this year, Chandrakar also managed to flee from the UAE to Oman. →P10

Sourabh Chandrakar

GST COLLECTIONS SURGE 23% TO ₹2.31L-CR IN OCT, 2ND HIGHEST EVER

Rajeev Jayaswal
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India's gross GST collections rose 22.9% year-on-year to ₹2.31 lakh crore in October, the second-highest monthly collection since the tax regime was launched in July 2017, driven by strong growth in import-linked revenue. Gross GST collections stood at ₹2,31,290 crore in October, compared with ₹1,88,125 crore last October, excluding compensation cess. →P14

LCA MK-1A, STEALTH FIGHTER CENTRAL TO MODERNISATION OF IAF: AIR CHIEF

Rahul Singh
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India's new chief of air staff, Air Chief Marshal Ashutosh Dixit, on Sunday outlined the Indian Air Force's top priorities, placing the indigenous Tejas light combat aircraft (LCA Mk-1A) alongside the LCA Mk-2 and advanced medium combat aircraft programmes at the forefront of its modernisation drive. →P11

Cyclone Murasu forms over Bay of Bengal, set for landfall tomorrow

BHUBANESWAR: A deep depression over the Bay of Bengal on Sunday intensified into a cyclone, prompting Odisha to step up preparedness in its southern region for another high-intensity storm in less than a week.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), the latest storm is set to intensify into a very severe cyclonic storm and make landfall on the morning of November 3 between Nellore and Narsapur in Andhra Pradesh, with winds of speeds between 100kmph and 110kmph, gusting to 120kmph.

India has named the cyclone 'Murasu', meaning war drum.

Manorama Mohanty, director of the meteorological centre in Bhubaneswar, said Odisha will receive rainfall from November 2, and that its intensity will increase on November 3, continuing through November 4 under the cyclone's influence. →P10

ODISHA CYCLONE TOLL TOUCHES SIX, SEARCH ON FOR 10 MISSING

The death toll in Odisha due to Cyclone Arnab rose to six on Sunday with the recovery of two bodies from a landslide-hit village in the southern part of the state, while search was underway to trace 10 other missing people, officials said. →P10

Vehicle checks clog Delhi-Ggm border

A jam on the Delhi-Gurugram border on Sunday as traffic police personnel conducted checks amid restrictions on entry of non-BS VI compliant vehicles into the Capital. PARVEEN KUMAR/HT PHOTO

AQI DETERIORATES, WORST IN 198 DAYS

Delhi's brief air quality relief ended over the weekend, as the AQI worsened by 144 points to 261 on Sunday — the worst in 198 days. By 11pm, the AQI touched 290.

ENFORCEMENT UPPED AS CURBS IN EFFECT

As Delhi's pollution-control curbs became effective on Sunday, traffic police personnel said enforcement will be intensified on Monday as people will return to work. →P4

2 AAP MLAs in Punjab quit party months before '27 assembly polls

Karam Prakash
letters@hindustantimes.com

PATIALA: Two legislators of the ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in Punjab on Sunday resigned from the party's membership, a day after AAP announced its first list of 40 candidates for the 2027 state assembly elections, people familiar with the matter said.

Harmeet Singh Pathanmajra, an MLA from Sanaur in Patiala district, sent his resignation letter to AAP national convenor Arvind Kejriwal, quitting with immediate effect without specifying any reason, while former cabinet minister Chetan Singh Jouramajra, who represented Samana, also in Patiala, announced his exit on social media. The party has not yet declared its candidates for either of the constituencies.

THE EXITS COME A DAY AFTER AAP ANNOUNCED ITS FIRST LIST OF 40 CANDIDATES FOR THE ELECTIONS

The development has brought into focus the reportedly growing discontent within Punjab's ruling party, especially over the leadership's handling of constituency-level appointments and political decisions, people aware of the matter said. →P11

MAN HELD FOR AP CHAINSAW ATTACK SHOT WHILE TRYING TO FLEE CUSTODY

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: The 21-year-old man who allegedly attacked two Class 10 girls with a chainsaw at a school in Andhra Pradesh's Anantapur district was shot on Sunday as he tried to escape police custody, an officer said. The man, Hemanth, is critically injured. Police said he hurled stones at officers. The police fired six rounds at him. →P10

DigiYatra trials for int'l flyers start in Delhi, 6 more airports

Neha LM Tripathi
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: DigiYatra has begun trials for international passengers at seven airports across the country, allowing eligible Indian nationals holding e-passports to use the facility at designated airport touchpoints while travelling on select international flights operated by Air India and IndiGo, the government said on Sunday.

The trials, scheduled to run from November to December, are being conducted at Delhi, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Kochi, Mumbai, Chennai and Amritsar airports. Passengers will be able to use the facility at terminal entry points, security hold areas and boarding gates, the government said. HT reported in September that the government was working to extend DigiYatra to international departures. →P9

The DigiYatra trials will run till December this year. HT

CLASHES IN MANIPUR DISTT AS BODIES OF 2 MISSING MEN FOUND

IMPHAL: Security forces on Sunday recovered the mutilated bodies of two Kuki men, missing since October 28, from a hilly stretch in Kangpokpi district of Manipur, police said. The recoveries sparked tension as an irate mob confronted officers at the superintendent of police's office. →P10

4 DEAD, 3 FALL ILL WHILE CLEANING TANK IN UJJAIN

Shruti Tomar
letters@hindustantimes.com

BHOPAL: Four workers died of suspected suffocation while cleaning an overground waste chamber at a hotel in Ujjain on Sunday, police said. Three others who entered the chamber to rescue them also fell ill and were taken to a hospital, police said.

Ujjain superintendent of police Pradeep Sharma said the incident took place on Saturday night at Shri Ganga Hotel. "The workers went into the chamber one after another reportedly to clean it, but got trapped," Sharma said. →P11

Households caught between LPG curbs, missing last mile PNG links

Rajeev Jayaswal
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Households in farflung areas even along gas pipelines face a double whammy: state-run gas agencies have stopped issuing new domestic liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) connections in certain areas since March, while piped natural gas (PNG) suppliers often find it cheaper to pay penalties than bear the high cost of laying pipelines for last-mile connections, people familiar with the matter said.

The restriction has created difficulties for households that cannot access a PNG connection despite living in areas covered by a city gas distribution (CGD) licence, the people said. Meanwhile, CGD companies often do not extend pipelines to remote pockets within their authorised geographical areas because of the high cost of providing last-mile connectivity.

SUPPLIERS FIND IT CHEAPER TO PAY PENALTIES THAN BEAR THE COST OF LAYING PIPELINES FOR LAST-MILE CONNECTIONS

This leaves some households dependent on more expensive 5kg and 10kg LPG cylinders. Some consumers also resort to buying domestic cylinders from the black market, they added.

Distributors have been instructed not to issue new domestic LPG connections in areas where PNG is available or being made available, the people said, requesting anonymity. →P14

{ SAME DISTRICT, SAME BANK, DIFFERENT BRANCH }

Maha cop removed from service for robbing SBI branch in '23 held again for ₹36.5-cr bank heist

Shrinivas Deshpande
letters@hindustantimes.com

PUNE: A Maharashtra Police sub-inspector who was dismissed from the force and jailed in 2023 for orchestrating a robbery at a State Bank of India branch in Jalgaon used his knowledge of the police's operations and put together a network of criminal associates while in prison to carry out a sensational ₹36.48-crore armed robbery at another of the bank's branch in the same district on Saturday, investigators aware of the matter said on Sunday.

Ex-SI Shankar Ramesh Jasak

Saturday's robbery took place in Bhokar village between 2.45pm and 3.15pm, when four men — one of whom was the mastermind, Shankar Ramesh Jasak — wearing helmets and face coverings entered the bank armed with two pistols, knives and wooden sticks. They threatened the bank manager, cashier and other employees, forced them to open the lockers, and tied their hands and covered their mouths.

When the security guard attempted to intervene, the suspects allegedly fired at him and fled with ₹12.26 lakh cash and approximately 27kg of gold ornaments worth ₹36.36 crore stored in 16 lockers.

But the 42-year-old former sub-inspector's plans unravelled rapidly after an emergency alarm set off a hot pursuit that featured local officers and village residents.

The four were arrested about two hours later and police

continued on →7

PAGE ONE PLUS

{ MY INDIA } MODI HAILS END OF LWE

'Maoist-hit areas are now centres of peace'

Areas of Chhattisgarh once identified as part of the Maoist "red corridor" are now emerging as centres of peace, trust and development after the "decisive" end of Left Wing Extremism in the state, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has said. In a letter to Chhattisgarh CM Vishnu Deo Sai on the occasion of the state's foundation day, PM Modi said Maoist violence had been one of the biggest obstacles to the state's progress, but the situation had now transformed. "Some years ago, areas which were known as the red corridor of Naxalism are today becoming new centers of peace, trust, and development," Modi said in the letter on Saturday, adding that this shift had accelerated the expansion of connectivity and modern infrastructure. HTC

{ WORLD } DOZENS INJURED

6 killed in separate US mass shootings

Dozens of people were injured and at least six people died in mass shootings as gun violence broke in half a dozen cities across the US over the Halloween weekend. Police in Dallas, the site of the deadliest violence, said four people are dead and 15 others were injured following a handful of shootings. Police in college towns like Fayetteville, Arkansas; Birmingham, Alabama; and Newark, Delaware, also reported shootings in their nightlife districts. Dallas Police Chief Daniel Comeaux said investigators are still trying to determine if the shootings Saturday night over the span of about an hour and 15 minutes were related. AP

{ SPORT } STRAIGHT-GAME VICTORIES

PV Sindhu, Lakshya Sen bag Hylo Open titles in Germany

Double Olympic medallist PV Sindhu and Lakshya Sen made it a double delight for India, claiming the women's and men's singles titles with straight-game victories in the finals of the Hylo Open Super 500 badminton tournament in Saarbrücken, Germany on Sunday. Former world champion Sindhu, who won the Japan Open in July and finished runner-up at the French Open last week, registered a commanding 21-12, 21-14 win over eighth seed and world No. 25 Line Højmark Kjærsfeldt of Denmark in the 39-minute women's singles final. It was her second title of the season. "This gives me a lot of boost, a lot of confidence," she said. Later in the day, Lakshya outwitted Jonatan Christie 21-17, 21-10 in the men's singles final to complete a memorable double for India. →P15

{ MY INDIA } POLICE PROBE UNDERWAY

Pool lights in focus in B'luru hotel deaths

Investigators are examining an underwater swimming pool lighting failure in connection with the death of two European guests due to electrocution at a Bengaluru hotel, officials familiar with the matter said. The Karnataka State Electrical Inspectorate is examining a switch-mode power supply device that may have allowed electricity to leak into the water, an official said. "This unit converts high-voltage alternating current into low-voltage direct current used by underwater LED lights. A failure in the unit or its wiring connections could have allowed current to escape into the pool," the official said. →P10

{ MY INDIA } PMLA CASE

Azam Khan sent to judicial custody

A special PMLA court in Ghaziabad on Sunday sent former Uttar Pradesh minister and Samajwadi Party (SP) leader Azam Khan to 14 days in judicial custody, a day after the Enforcement Directorate (ED) arrested him in a case linked to the alleged misuse of government funds in the construction of the Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in Rampur. Khan founded the Jauhar University in 2006. "We requested the court to grant 14 days of judicial custody, and the court allowed our plea," a senior ED official said, confirming the agency's request and the court's order. Khan, who walked out of Rampur jail on Saturday after nearly 11 months in custody, was taken directly to Ghaziabad's Dasna jail from the court following the remand order. →P10

Trump preparing to wield executive power if Dems win

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WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump's White House has spent months preparing for a possible Democratic takeover of Congress, developing plans to keep advancing major parts of his agenda through executive power while bracing for investigations of his administration, according to a White House official and two people familiar with the plans.

Senior officials, including deputy chief of staff Stephen Miller and budget director Russell Vought, have been working with the White House Counsel's Office since April to identify executive actions on immigration, tariffs, housing costs and federal spending that Trump could pursue without congressional approval, said the three people, who spoke on the condition of anonymity.

White House counsel Will Scharf and his team are looking at "what Trump can legally do on his own, where he could push the limits of his authority and how to defend those decisions in court," the White House official said.

The planning underscores a paradox of Tuesday's midterm elections: Capturing control of Congress would give Democrats the power to investigate Trump, block legislation and constrain his spending priorities. But Trump would retain broad executive authority over trade, foreign policy and the federal bureaucracy that he has used aggressively during his second term.

Democrats need a net gain of four seats in the US House of Representatives as well as the US Senate to overturn Republicans' narrow 218-214 and 53-47 majorities. Opinion polls favour Democrats to win the House, while the Senate remains too close to call.

For the past month, Trump has held rallies across the country trying to preserve Republican control of Congress, even as his aides privately prepare for a very different political landscape in 2027.

The White House pushed back on the prospect of Republican losses and accused the media of promoting a false narrative. "This administration and commonsense Republicans will continue to secure our borders, restore law and order, putting more money back into the pockets of hard-working Americans, and deliver wins for the American people," White House spokeswoman Lauren Bis said.

Among the actions under consideration are tariffs on imports of critical minerals and wind turbines, tighter rules on visas for international students and temporary foreign workers, the White House official said.

I MAY BECOME 'MR VETO' IF DEMOCRATS GET MAJORITY: TRUMP

Donald Trump said he may have to become "Mr Veto" if Democrats win a majority in Tuesday's midterms, according to a clip of a New York Post interview aired Sunday on Fox News. "They'll be sending stuff up, you veto it," he said. "Eventually, after a month or two of getting all vetoed — you know, it's just waste — they come over and make a deal." "I guess I'll become Mr Veto," Trump said in the interview. AGENCIES

A fine balance: Reconciling large crowds and legacy lanes

Manoj Sharma
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NEW DELHI: A walk through north Kolkata is a lesson in anachronism. Its narrow, mazy lanes are flanked by cramped residential blocks and sprawling ancestral mansions in equal measure. Its neighbourhoods struggle to breathe and offer vast open spaces in the same breath.

Historically home to prominent families such as the Tagores, Mullicks, Chatterjees and Seals, north Kolkata is where Durga Puja took on its modern, community-driven shape centuries ago. The neighbourhood's pujas now draw hundreds of thousands of people every year, packing them into streets planned and built for far more modest numbers.

PICK OF THE DAY

On the evening of October 17, Saptami, families dressed traditionally for Durga Puja filled those lanes. Thousands filled through a narrow lane towards the Chorbagan Sarbojanin puja, one of the neighbourhood's oldest pandals. By 7.40pm, the approach was packed. Then the skies opened.

People outside pushed forward for shelter while those inside hesitated to step into the downpour. As the opposing flows jammed together, pressure built around the narrow exit. Then a loudspeaker announced that the pandal structure might collapse, according to police and eyewitness accounts. In the panic, people rushed to escape. The crush knocked some off their feet and trapped them. Nineteen people died.

Among them was a seven-year-old girl who had come with her family, like so many others that evening, simply to see the pandals.

Kolkata's was not the first gathering to end this way. A crush at the Maha Kumbh in Prayagraj last year killed 37 people. Eleven died outside Bengaluru's M Chinnaswamy Stadium, where fans had gathered to celebrate a cricket victory. At a rally featuring actor — now chief minister — Vijay in Karur, Tamil Nadu, 41 people died.

India's fast-densifying cities are compressing more people into the same old streets, squares and festival routes. Social media can turn religious festivals, political rallies, consumer expos and concerts into sudden mass gatherings, while the physical layout of the city barely changes. People now gather, celebrate and move in tighter, and often more dangerous, spaces.

OP Singh, former director general of police in Haryana and author of When the Crowd Holds the Camera, to be published by Penguin Random House India in December, calls a crowd "our most predictable disaster". "We know the date, the place and the number a year ahead," he says.

The police response, he says, often arrives as a bandobast: "a list of men, points and shifts drawn up a week before". Singh describes what that means on the ground: "The gali [lane] was never planned for fifty thousand visitors. The disaster plan covers flood and fire. And on the night, a few constables at a gate, soaked to the skin, are asked to hold back physics."

When crowds outgrow the space

The National Crime Records Bureau recorded 147 deaths in what it classifies as stampedes across India in 2024, according to its year-wise dataset. Ashish Verma, a professor at the Indian Institute of Science (IISc), Bengaluru, says crowd disasters have occurred frequently for decades, "almost once in a month on an average".

"Instead of pushing governments to take decisive action, we have normalised these tragedies as inevitable in a populous country, quickly forgetting one and waiting for the next. The root problem is that authorities treat crowd management purely as an administrative task to be handled by police and security personnel using kinetic force," says Verma, whose research examines crowd dynamics, pedestrian movement and walk-accessibility during mass gatherings.

Verma also questions the use of the word "stampede". In his view, it places blame on the people caught in a crush and takes attention away from organisers and authorities. "Human crowds are a complex system, yet crowd dynamics in India has not focused on treating and developing it as a scientific discipline. The country has put little into training specialists or building academic programmes for them," he says.

A police barricade blocks the entrance to the Chorbagan Sarbojanin Durga Puja pandal in north Kolkata, where a stampede last month killed 19 people. PTI

The problem is not simply that the police arrive late. No one may have properly assessed the space in the first place.

Monika Vij, a professor of geography at Miranda House, Delhi, has used remote sensing and geographic information systems (GIS) to map pressure points at pilgrimage sites. Planners, she says, often get the first calculation wrong: the width of the lane. "What matters most is actual walking width, the part people can actually walk through once parked vehicles, pandal structures, hawkers and food stalls are accounted for. In older temple areas, shrines and statues can narrow it further. Sometimes the lanes are so narrow that the entry and exit points are the same, leading to counterflow of people," she says.

Police plans divide a site into posts and sectors, Vij says, while spatial analysis looks at its physical features and how people move through it. "Carrying capacity and pressure points have to be worked out in advance," she says. She also wants the community involved. "When only the police are made accountable, the community cuts itself out from management and simply becomes a part of the crowd."

Dikshu Kukreja, architect and managing principal at CP Kukreja Architects, says the problem is also one of planning. Master plans and street designs look at land use, connectivity and infrastructure, he says, but rarely give the same attention to the periodic crowding of particular places.

Public space changes with the hour, the season and the event, Kukreja says, and planning needs to account for this temporal dimension. Safety depends on the whole pedestrian network, including approach roads, junctions, exits and alternative routes.

"A venue can become unsafe if even one critical section of its access network is unable to accommodate the volume of people moving through it," he says.

Verma says people need to be channelled into orderly, preferably single-file movement, or a rumour, a sudden stop or heavy rain can send pressure through a crowd.

"A barricade cannot calm a crowd that got there first," Singh says. "What protects people on the night is built months earlier."

Bengaluru is a case in point. The Chinnaswamy Stadium can hold about 35,000 people, but then chief minister Siddaramaiah said between 200,000 and 300,000 had gathered for Royal Challengers Bengaluru's victory celebrations. The commission headed by justice Michael D'Cunha found that the event had no prior permission, the gates opened directly onto public footpaths and there were no holding areas. Of the 515 personnel assigned for the event, only 79 were posted outside the gates. The commission blamed organisers and police for poor entry regulation, reckless announcements and the delayed opening of exit gates.

What tech can and cannot do

Atul Rai, chief executive and co-founder of Gurugram-based artificial intelligence firm Staqu Technologies, which was brought in to deploy crowd analytics at the stadium after the crush, says its software tracks crowd density, bottlenecks and unusual directional movement in real time, and automatically alerts control rooms before overcrowding reaches a critical level.

"Effective crowd management relies on assessing real-time inflow and outflow speeds rather than relying solely on static headcounts," Rai says. "But while technology provides real-time information, an alert is useless if nobody acts on it. The decision ultimately has to be made by a human."

Technology can help before an event too. Vij says satellite imagery and GIS can identify narrow lanes, obstructions and places that could serve as holding areas.

Making these spaces safer

"Nobody can widen a 200-year-old lane," Singh says. "We can change how people move through it." That, he says, starts with knowing the usable space: where routes narrow, which exits lead to open ground and where people can wait without blocking the street.

Organisers should work out the expected crowd, the number of exits and the time the site takes to empty, Singh says. "If the exits clear 20,000 an hour, you do not let in 60,000."

Singh recalls watching a marathon in Hisar from a footbridge. The runners moved calmly because they knew the start, the route and the finish. "That is crowd design. The safety is settled before anyone arrives."

On the eve of a festival, he says, the puja committee, engineer, fire officer and police station head should walk the lane together.

"A plan nobody has walked is only paper," he says.

"A review of every incident and near miss must be published, so that Prayagraj learns from Kolkata."

Kukreja says density by itself is not the problem. Supported by proper infrastructure and well-designed public spaces, it can strengthen urban vitality. Cities, he says, need to plan for collective gatherings with the seriousness given to transport or utilities.

"A festival crowd is families who came out to celebrate," Singh says. "We owe them a place that was ready before they arrived, and a safe way home."

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Air quality takes a nosedive; curbs kick in

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NEW DELHI: A week ahead of Diwali, a haze of pollutants shrouded the skyline in the early hours on Sunday as the Capital's air quality index (AQI) dipped into the "poor" category, erasing the brief respite brought on by rains last week. Forecasts show that the situation is expected to worsen in the coming days, dipping into the "very poor" category in the second half of this week.

The city recorded a 24-hour average AQI of 261 ("poor"), according to the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB)'s 4pm bulletin, worsening over 144 points from a day earlier when it registered 117 ("moderate") category.

It continued to deteriorate through the data, registering at 272 at 6pm, 287 by 10pm, and 290 by 11pm. This comes two days after heavy rains and strong winds brought respite from "poor" AQI and the city recorded an AQI of 60 ("satisfactory") on Friday.

This is the worst air quality since April 17, when the Capital recorded an average AQI of 263 ("poor") on April 17. It recorded an AQI of 261 on July 12.

CPCB classifies an AQI of 0–50 as "good", 51–100 as "satisfactory", 101–200 as "moderate", 201–300 as "poor", 301–400 as "very poor" and 401–500 as "severe".

AIR WE BREATHE

According to the Centre's Air Quality Early Warning System (AQEWS) for Delhi, the AQI is likely to remain in the "poor" category on Monday and Tuesday, and may further deteriorate to the "very poor" category by Wednesday.

The AQEWS bulletin added, "The outlook for the subsequent six days is that the air quality is likely to be in the very poor to poor category."

To be sure, Delhi winter pollution action plan came into effect on Sunday, which bars non-Delhi vehicles below BS-VI emission standards, bans all dust-generating demolition and outdoor civil construction activities, and mandates 50% attendance in offices and work from home.

Data from 57 of the city's 59 monitoring stations showed that 22 recorded "very poor" air quality, with Jahangirpuri logging the worst AQI at 378 at 4pm. It was followed by Rohini (352), Punjabi Bagh (351), Mundka (337), RK Puram (335), and Chandni Chowk at 328.

At 8pm, CPCB listed PM2.5 as the main pollutant at 50 of Delhi's 57 reporting stations and PM10 at 7.

According to the Decision Support System (DSS) for air quality management in Delhi, stubble burning's contribution to Delhi's air pollution rose to 18.57% on Sunday, up from 5.33% on Saturday. Past data shows the contribution of farm fires peaks typically in the first week of November, making it an important time of the year to capture data.

Lowest minimum temp for February since 2023

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), Delhi also recorded its lowest minimum temperature for November 1 since 2023, with the mercury settling at 18 degrees, 1.9 degrees below the season's average.

The maximum was 29°C, two degree below normal.

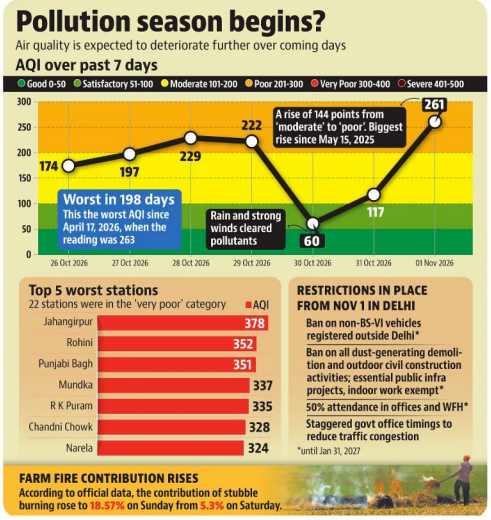
Typically, low temperature and wind speeds as well as fog slow down dispersion by trapping pollutants near the surface.

As a result, on Sunday afternoon, the weather worked against clearing Delhi's air, according to an HT analysis of IMD's weather-balloon readings from Safdarjung. It showed that, by 4:30pm the day's pollution had spread only 1,100 m up from the ground, where the wind averaged 10 km/h. On a typical early-November afternoon it spreads about 1,300m up, with wind of about 13 km/h.

Jinitha Varghese, programme manager at EnviroCatalysts, said two-thirds of the fine particles in Delhi's air came from outside the city, including NCR industries and traffic, coal power plants upwind such as those in Jhajjar, and burning across the region, while Delhi's own traffic is still its biggest single source. "About 40% of the particles form in the air from gases released in the air-shed, so the smoke from coal, fuels and stubble shows up as 'secondary' pollution and is easy to undercount," he added.

Meteorologist Navdeep Dahiya said, "Smog season begins now... Most AQI sensors across Delhi NCR are now reporting AQI levels above 300 and many are climbing 400-500 range tonight. The flow of winds are from north west with calm conditions. All emissions will persist in the atmosphere for longer duration.

SANCHIT KHANNA/ HT



7K vehicles checked, 700+ sent back at Delhi's borders

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NEW DELHI: As Delhi's winter pollution-control measures became effective on Sunday, authorities tightened checks at the city's borders to restrict the entry of vehicles below BS-VI from neighbouring states. Delhi Traffic Police personnel stationed at key entry points told HT that enforcement will be intensified on Monday as people will return to work.

To curb air pollution, the Delhi government has imposed several restrictions, including a ban on non-Delhi vehicles below BS-VI emission standards from November 1, 2026, to January 31, 2027, and a directive prohibiting fuel stations from dispensing fuel to vehicles without a valid Pollution Under Control Certificate (PUCC).

During a spot check by HT at three border points — the Delhi-Noida Direct (DND) Flyway, Chilla village, and the Kalindi Kunj border — Delhi Traffic Police personnel said they faced a marginal staff shortage due to the INDIA bloc's rally at Ramlila Maidan. However, they said the situation remained manageable.

"In around five hours, we sent back around six vehicles which were non-Delhi registered and BS-IV. Many were those who only had one vehicle and were headed to places where public transport does not provide last-mile connectivity. We suggested they take the metro as far as possible," said Pankaj Rana, a Delhi Traffic Police personnel.

He said around nine personnel were deployed at the Kalindi Kunj entry point, including two police officers, three transport department officials, and five traffic police personnel. However, during HT's nearly 40-minute visit, only two personnel were seen checking vehicles.

Non-Delhi vehicles below BS-VI emission standards were denied entry into Delhi at border points. SAKIB ALI/HT PHOTO

Unis Saifi, 31, a Delhi resident who works in Noida, said: "The bike that I own is BS-IV, and registered in Delhi. I had to go to Noida for some work, but wasn't sure if I would be allowed. So I took an Uber instead."

A traffic police officer said, "We are trying to spread awareness about the rules through print media, social media other channels. We have set up boards at the borders and distributed pamphlets. On November 1, between 12 am and 8 pm, 7,279 vehicles were stopped and checked. Of these, 10 were fined, 714 were turned back from the borders, and 38 were impounded."

{ CAQM } BETWEEN SEPT 15-OCT 29

Over 1,300 stubble burning cases reported across Pb, Hry, UP, Delhi

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NEW DELHI: The Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM), in a Right to Information response, has said that 1,383 stubble burning cases were reported between 15 September and 29 October. The highest number of cases were reported from Punjab followed by Uttar Pradesh.

The CAQM said 1,007 cases had been reported in Punjab, 29 in Haryana, 345 in Uttar Pradesh, and two in Delhi. Noting that total environmental compensation (EC) of ₹18.17 lakh was imposed in Punjab, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh (NCR), it said approximately 75% (₹13.57 lakh) has been recovered.

The RTI reply, dated October 30, was filed by activist Amit Gupta, said the figures indicate the scale of monitoring and enforcement being undertaken against stubble burning.

The farm-fire tracking period begins September 15 every year, with paddy procurement starting on October 1. Paddy straw burning in Punjab and Haryana is considered one of the factors contributing to the seasonal spike in air pollution in the national capital region during October and November. As the window for sowing wheat is very short after paddy harvest, farmers tend to set their fields on fire to quickly clear the crop residue.

According to the Decision Support System (DSS), which estimates the contribution of sources to Delhi's PM 2.5, the contribution of stubble burning rose to 18.57% on Sunday from 5.3% on Saturday.

The CAQM response states that, as per action taken reports, received from the state governments during the period EC imposed in Punjab amounted to ₹17.5 lakh, of which ₹13.1 has been recovered. "In Haryana, EC of ₹50,000 was imposed, out of which ₹30,000 has been recovered. In Uttar Pradesh (NCR), EC amounting to ₹217,500 was imposed and the entire amount of ₹217,500 has been recovered."

MCD OFFICIALS TO CONDUCT 4-HOUR DAILY CHECKS TO CURB POLLUTION

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NEW DELHI: Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar has directed all deputy commissioners to undertake mandatory field visits for a minimum of four hours every day, focusing on air pollution mitigation and enforcement of applicable pollution-control directions.

The direction, dated October 30, comes even as Delhi's winter action plan kicked in on Sunday.

The order states that the priority areas for these inspections should be road dust mitigation, waste management, identification of illegal/visibly polluting industrial activities, and pollution hotspots.

"Issues related to encroachment on public ways which lead to congestion and thus pollution. One inspection per week would mandatorily be a night weekly market, in the zone," the commissioner states in the communication.

The zonal deputy commissioners shall monitor compliance during their field inspections and ensure prompt enforcement action against violations, including issuing notices/challans and other measures permissible under applicable laws.

"Such issues shall be accorded priority during daily field inspections, and necessary corrective measures shall be undertaken and followed up for resolution," the letter adds.

Deputy commissioners have been ordered to submit their daily field inspection reports by 5pm.

According to the order, MCD additional commissioner (DEMS) shall act as the nodal officer for compiling daily reports from all zones and shall forward a consolidated daily report.

{ MANGOLPURI FACTORY FIRE }

Two factory owners still at large; 1 victim in ICU

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NEW DELHI : The family of Harinder, one of the two people injured in a massive fire at a four-storey shoe manufacturing facility in Mangolpuri Industrial Area Phase-I that killed four people on Friday, said that he was still in the intensive care unit (ICU) and was looking at months of recovery. Delhi Police said they had yet to locate the two men who run the factory.

On Friday, around 9.30 pm, a fire broke out inside the shoe factory, where six workers had been eating dinner on the first floor. Four of them died, mainly due to asphyxiation.

The victims were identified as Lal Babu (38), Ashok (25), Prem Chand (50), and Harihar (40). Apart from Harinder, a 45-year-old Vikas is also undergoing treatment, but is stable.

He has submitted a complaint to police blaming the building owners and supervisor for negligence and "stuffing" the basement with cartons and raw material which caused the fire.

A preliminary investigation had found that even though the fire was in the basement, all windows and alternative exits were sealed, trapping all workers. Police and fire officers who visited the scene of the fire said that five of the six victims were found unconscious in a room on the fourth floor, while the sixth person was found near the staircase on the third floor.

Police have so far arrested one of the owners, identified as Suresh Chand (78), and building supervisor Ashok Yadav. They have been booked for negligent conduct with respect to fire and culpable homicide not amounting to murder.

However, raids are being conducted across Delhi to nab the two other owners who have been identified.

Harinder (AGE) regained consciousness but is still not able to speak, his family said.

"Harinder spent more than 22 years in that factory. He was earning ₹25,000 and was the contractor. Though it was not required, he would still stay at night to help workers during the festive season. Now, he can't even speak because of heavy smoke inhalation," his brother-in-law Mukesh told HT. "Doctors have said it will take over three months for him to fully recover. He is only able to signal now."

Families of the other victims alleged that they had had to pay for the ambulances, which cost them ₹25,000 each.

Nagendra Yadav, Ashok's father, said, "The least the owners or the government could have done is help us. We have already spent a lot on flights as we had to rush from Bihar to Delhi. Ashok has a pregnant wife and two more children who are aged around six and four. But the ambulance services cost us ₹25,00. Ashok's monthly salary was only ₹15,000. How can we afford all this? Nobody is helping us. The owners are also on the run. The police are not doing anything."

Meanwhile, the Delhi Fire Services said preliminary inquiry showed certain modifications near lift shaft area and near staircases leading to "heavy accumulation" of smoke in the staircase area.

"We found that during the fire, a few workers reached the third floor and could have been saved as they reached the circular exhaust window to breathe but it was also sealed with sheets and tape. We were shocked as to why this was done. The same was done on all exhaust systems as they were all sealed," said a fire officer who accompanied a team from the sub-divisional magistrate's office for an inspection on Saturday.

During a spot check on Saturday, HT found that the building had window spaces that were sealed with iron gates and tiny air outlets blocked by sheets of cardboard.

An HT spot check found that the building's windows were sealed, while plastic sheets blocked the iron gates. RAJ K RAJ /HT PHOTO

Govt clears ₹387 crore for MB Road drainage revamp

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has sanctioned ₹387 crore for a complete overhaul of the drainage system along the Mehrauli-Badarpur (MB) Road to resolve waterlogging issues across several localities in southeast Delhi, officials said on Sunday.

Officials added that the project is expected to be completed within two years after the work is awarded.

A senior Public Works Department (PWD) official said the corridor is a severe waterlogging hotspot due to runoff received from the Sangam Vihar belt, alongside ongoing infrastructure projects that disrupt the natural drainage pathway.

"We will construct 22 km of pre-cast RCC (Reinforced Cement Concrete) box drains, starting from Lado Sarai and extending to the Pul Prahladpur railway over-bridge. An

OFFICIALS ADDED THAT THE PROJECT IS EXPECTED TO BE COMPLETED WITHIN TWO YEARS AFTER THE WORK IS AWARDED

expenditure sanction of ₹387.84 crore has been granted for this project," the official said.

The project is part of Delhi's new drainage master plan, which aims to modernise the Capital's outflow systems and reduce flooding during heavy rainfall.

Over the last several years, drainage issues have persisted alongside ongoing infrastructure works. The road from Shooting Range to MB Road was rebuilt ahead of this year's monsoon, but stagnant rainwater severely damaged it.

A second PWD official said the old brick drains will be replaced completely. "Replacement will focus on stretches where the existing brick drains have become old and require repeated maintenance. The objective is to replace the old drainage structures with properly designed precast RCC drains and ensure their capacity is adequate for stormwater discharge, particularly during the rainy season," the official said.

Officials added that the replacement is being carried out according to projections in the ₹57,000-crore drainage master plan announced last year.

The master plan marks the first major upgrade of the Capital's drainage network in five decades. It outlines a five-phase, five-year implementation plan and a 30-year roadmap to modernise stormwater systems and curb waterlogging during increasingly severe monsoons. The plan also envisions redesigning outdated channels.

MAN NABBED FOR KIDNAPPING TEEN, DEMANDING ₹40K BRIBE IN NE DELHI

NEW DELHI: Police rescued a 13-year-old boy and arrested his kidnapper within three hours of receiving a complaint in Shahdara, officials said.

The incident came to light on October 30 when a woman approached the police station in Shahdara and reported her son missing from Jyoti Nagar.

A police officer said, "The woman received a call from an unidentified person demanding ₹40,000 via a UPI transfer for the child's release. A case was filed and a probe was launched."

During the investigation, the kidnapper contacted the woman again and shared a barcode, following which police transferred ₹5,000 to track the transaction.

"Surveillance led the investigators to a cybercafe in Karawal Nagar, where the owner disclosed that a man, accompanied by a minor boy, had used his UPI barcode to receive ₹5,000 in exchange for a commission of ₹50," the officer added.

The cybercafe's CCTV footage and apprehended the suspect. The child was rescued. PTI

Three arrested for pro-Khalistan graffiti, writing threats against Diljit Dosanjh at 2 Metro stations

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Special Cell on Sunday said it arrested three men for allegedly writing pro-Khalistan graffiti at Jahangirpuri and Shastri Nagar metro stations last week. The graffiti also carried threats against Punjabi singer Diljit Dosanjh amid his Aura India tour, police said.

The accused have been identified as Sumeet alias Raftar, Sumit Kumar alias Kaka and Gurpreet. The graffiti, which expressed support for the banned separatist organisation Sikhs for Justice (SFJ) and the demand for Khalistan, was found at the two stations on October 29 and 30, respectively.

According to officers, the graffiti was discovered on the floor near Gate 1 of Jahangirpuri metro station on October 29. A day later, similar writing was found on the inner wall of the staircase near Gate 2 of Shastri Nagar station.

Following the incidents, two

Diljit Dosanjh HT

FIRs were registered under Section 3 of the Delhi Prevention of Defacement of Public Property Act, 2007, and Section 62(2) of the Metro Railways (Operation and Maintenance) Act, 2002. The first was registered at the Metro Azadpur police station and the second at the Metro NSP police station.

A team of the Special Cell's Northern Range, led by inspectors Anukul Panwar and Parveen Kumar, arrested the three accused under the supervision of ACP Rahul Kumar Singh, police said. They described the graffiti as an act of defacement of public property that could affect public order and national integrity.

Tracing the soul of a city through its homes, this column looks at houses as living archives of the millions of people who make Delhi

The haveli's last pulse: Village culture in an expanding city

Shekhar Tokas and Anica Mann
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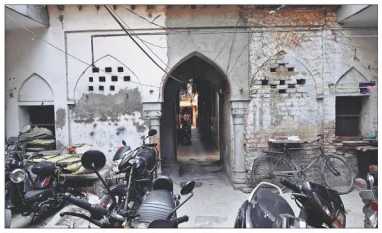
DELHI HOUSES

In Shenzhen, a fishing and farming county that became a metropolis within a few decades of 1980, the state acquired the surrounding farmland while the villagers kept their residential plots. On those acquired plots, they built upward until neighbouring blocks stood close enough for residents to shake hands from their windows — which is why these buildings acquired the local nickname "handshake buildings." They are usually read as a failure of planning, but they also record how a community contracts when a city closes in, keeping its ancestral halls, lineage ties and collective ownership inside a footprint that shrinks every year.

Rural Delhi has undergone a similar contraction on different terms. For that reason, the villages work as cultural islands, where older habits of marriage, worship and hospitality are carried on with less dilution than in the colonies around them. Inside the lal dora — the village settlement long exempt from municipal building rules — the haveli has been divided among sons, rented to migrants and raised to several storeys, so the old house occupies a smaller share of plot each decade.

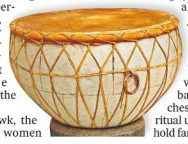


Villages work as cultural islands, where older habits are carried on with less dilution than in the colonies around them. COURTESY: SHEKHAR TOKAS

The way the house absorbs this pressure can be followed from its entrance inward. The deodhi was where a household first announced itself, and the satiya painted in geru and chuna on the wooden doorframe at Dev Uthani Gyaras, the thapi pressed onto the wall after a birth, and the Sanjhi Mai modelled in clay and cow dung during Navratri were all made on surfaces that every guest passed on the way to the baithak.

Today the satiya and thapi appear on the tiled or steel entrances of rebuilt houses, and Sanjhi, to whom women sing each evening until Dashmi, is made on a kitchen or courtyard wall wherever one remains.

The baithak that the deodhi opened into was furnished with a khaat and a hukka, and these objects did not stay in one room. The khaat that received guests was carried into the chowk when the house filled for a wedding, and the hukka that passed among the men also marked where they sat when kajal ghalai and sehra bandhi were performed on the outward side of the courtyard while women gathered inward around the saalh and obras. Where the courtyard has gone, these ceremonies are performed on a rooftop, at a local temple or in whatever corner remains. In many new houses the front room near the entrance serves as the baithak.



Behind the chowk, the saalh was where women churned milk with the bilona and ground grain on the chakki, work that was accompanied by the geet sung at festivals and weddings. Both implements have largely left the household, along with the hal, jua and kassi of agrarian work, yet the songs persist at ceremonies, and brass and copper vessels, matkas, silbatta and wooden chests are retained for ritual use or because they hold family memory.

This is the same contraction that produced the handshake buildings of Shenzhen, but Delhi's villages are early enough in it to be given a different course. A haveli replaced by a multistorey block gains units and rental income, and it loses the courtyard, the threshold and the inner hall that gave each practice its place, so that families keep their rituals without the ground on which they were performed.

Tokyo offers a working precedent in Nerima, where owners of farmland inside the city receive a large reduction in property tax for as long as they keep farming it. The arrangement is renewed in ten-year terms, and the land can be leased to a new cultivator when an heir does not want it. The Master Plan for Delhi 2047 provides an opportunity to recognise urban villages as living cultural landscapes. Its provisions for cultural precincts, Transferable Development Rights (TDR) and Heritage Funds could be extended through context-sensitive planning and community participation to sustain traditional havelis, chaupals, akhadas, ponds, wells and other spaces that continue to shape the cultural and social life of these settlements.

Anica Mann works on archaeology and contemporary art in Delhi; Dr Shekhar Tokas is assistant professor of urban studies at Dr BR Ambedkar University, Delhi.
The views expressed are personal

SC to hear 1st batch of Noida Sports City petitions on Dec 9

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court will hear on December 9 the first set of cases pertaining to the pending Sports City projects in Gautam Buddh Nagar facing a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) probe.

The top court will start the hearing with the Lotus Green projects in sector 150 (SC-02). The court directed the petitions for Logix Sports City (SC-01, Sector 150) to be heard on December 16, while the third batch of petitions for Three C Green Sports City (Sectors 78 and 79) will be taken up on January 20.

The order was passed by a bench of justices MM Sundresh and PB Varale on October 6 during a separate petitions against the three Sports City projects.

In their plea, residents and developers challenged a February 24, 2025, judgment of the Allahabad High Court ordering a CBI probe against alleged irregularities in the allotment of the Sports City projects in sectors 78, 79 and 150. The high court had also directed the CBI to examine the alleged collusion with the officials of Noida Authority, the land owning authority.

During the hearing into the matter, the Supreme Court bench was informed by CBI that a "prima facie" case has been established and the agency requested the court to lift the stay on coercive action issued by the court last year to enable further investigation.

According to the petitions,

SC WILL HEAR THE CASES IN BATCHES, AND THE FIRST ONE WILL BE LOTUS GREEN SPORTS CITY IN SEC 150

the CBI probe was necessitated after the homebuyers claimed that the final construction plan was contrary to promises made in the brochure; that 70% of project space would be reserved for open area, recreational and sports facilities.

In its affidavit to the court, the Noida Authority said the revised Resolution Plan for the sector 150 Sports City project, "facilitating" its development and "safeguarding the interests of thousands of homebuyers who have invested therein".

It further said that, following the court's order of November 2025 requiring submission of revised Master Plan by the builders, Lotus Green Constructions Private Limited, had submitted a revised layout plan. This plan was approved by the 222nd Noida Authority board meeting in April 2026 and notified on May 6.

Additionally, the Authority granted conditional occupancy certificates for four projects in SC-02, sector 150, where 100% of outstanding dues have been paid. These projects pertain to M/s Brickrise Developers, Ace Infracity Developers, Land Kart Builders, and Samridhi Infra Square Private Limited.

Prior to sanction of the revised layout plan, Noida Authority issued public notice in February this year inviting objections. However, homebuyers of Lotus Green Sports City project have filed an intervention application in the top court objecting to the revised plan.

The application by homebuyers said, "The revised layout plan dated May 6 for the Sports City project is much worse than even the earlier revised master layout plan of 2017." It was on these illegalities, the high court passed scathing observations while directing the CBI to register a case and investigate how nearly 15,000 homebuyers were cheated of their hard-earned investments.

However, Noida Authority's affidavit denies such claims. It states that out of the total area of 13,29,745 sq m in the Lotus Green Sports City, an area of 3,92,275 is proposed for residential, 6,648 sq m for commercial. The balance 9,30,822 sq m (i.e. 70%) is for recreational purposes, which includes sports, institutional and other facilities, and open space. The authority further stated that the Sports Facility drawings prepared by the project consultant were vetted by the Sports Authority of India (SAI). Following approval of the Resolution Plan, the benefit of zero period (from April 2020 to April 6, 2026) and extension of time has been granted to the project.

The authority further said that pursuant to HC's February order directing CBI probe, the authority has handed over all relevant material to the CBI.

45-year-old woman's decomposed body found inside Kalkaji residence

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NEW DELHI: The decomposed body of a 45-year-old woman was found inside her locked residence in southeast Delhi's Kalkaji area on Sunday, police said.

According to officers part of the investigation, the body was discovered after police were informed about a foul smell emanating from the house, which had been locked for the last 8-10 days.

Police personnel, accompanied by fire service staff and a crime team, reached the spot and broke open the door, officers said. The entire procedure was videographed, police added.

As the team reached the house, the decomposed body of the woman, who lived alone in Govindpuri Extension, was found lying on the floor, they said.

Prima facie, police said there were no signs of forced entry or foul play.

The body has been sent to the AIIMS mortuary for a post-mortem examination. Efforts are being made to contact the woman's sister, who lives in Kolkata, police said.

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Cops work to clear 18 choke points on key road in S Delhi

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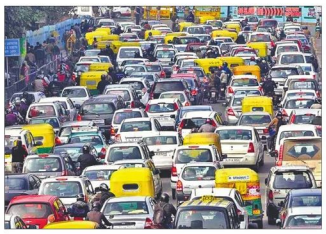
NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has identified 18 congestion points along SSN Marg, popularly referred to as the 100-foot road, in Chhatarpur to ask agencies concerned to address traffic bottlenecks caused by unauthorised parking, roadside installations and junctions without traffic signals, according to a survey.

Heavy traffic, particularly around busy junctions and access roads, has added to severe congestion along the stretch, police found in a survey conducted earlier this month. HT has a copy of the survey.

The congestion points identified in the survey fall under the jurisdiction of the Mehrauli and Fatehpur Beri police stations. "The findings flag several locations where the movement of vehicles is frequently disrupted and there is a need for coordinated intervention by civic bodies and other departments," an officer aware of the developments said.

The SSN Marg is a key road in south Delhi, connecting residential areas and commercial establishments, while also serving devotees travelling to a series of temples and other religious sites along the route. In June, the Delhi government approved the construction of a four-kilometre-long elevated corridor on SSN Marg, from Anuvrat Marg to DLF Farms in Chhatarpur, to facilitate faster movement of those using the stretch as a thoroughfare and ease chronic traffic congestion in south Delhi. Officials estimate that the signal-free elevated corridor will facilitate the movement of around 74,370 passenger car units daily.

According to the survey report, the Mehrauli police identified a Y-junction as a major congestion hot spot, where traffic from Anuvrat Marg, Chhatarpur Temple Road and Dera More converge. The Maidan Garhi exit and Rajpur Khurd exit were also flagged as major bottlenecks, as e-rickshaws and two-wheelers frequently travel on the wrong side to reach the Y-point. "Such movements can disrupt the orderly flow of traffic and create conflict between vehicles travelling in opposite directions," the officer said.



The SSN Marg is a key road in south Delhi, connecting residential areas and commercial establishments. HT ARCHIVE

The survey also highlighted unauthorised parking near a hub of restaurants near the junction. Parked vehicles occupy available road space and contribute to congestion, the survey found. Another concern is the presence of electrical transformers installed along the road, the report flagged. Three such locations were listed under the Mehrauli jurisdiction, with each transformer occupying an estimated 15-20 feet of road space. The survey also flagged pump houses at two locations and a permanent municipal dustbin structure, each of which reduces the space available for traffic movement, the report said.

The junction near the JVTS Garden Colony was identified as another location with heavy traffic movement. The Rajpur Khurd exit and Gaushala Road exit were also flagged because they are T-junctions without traffic signals, where vehicles frequently get stuck, the report stated.

Roadside parking near salons was identified as an additional problem, with several establishments generating parking demand that spills onto the road.

Under Fatehpur Beri jurisdiction, the police identified four congestion points, chiefly two spots where electrical transformers occupy an estimated 15-20 feet of road space each, the Fatehpur Beri exit and the Dera Mor exit. Both junctions were flagged because they lack traffic signals and traffic often gets stuck there, according to the survey. "The findings are a combination of infrastructure-related constraints and traffic management issues rather than a single cause of congestion. Roadside structures reduce the effective carriageway available to vehicles, while the absence of signals at busy junctions can complicate the movement of traffic from intersecting roads," the officer said.

A senior police officer said that they plan to take up the identified issues with the Public Works Department, Delhi Traffic Police, and Municipal Corporation of Delhi for action on matters within their respective jurisdictions. The survey, however, does not specify a timeline for the removal or relocation of the structures other measures.

Govt plans to revamp 3.3km Netaji Subhash Marg into heritage corridor

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi government will revamp the 3.3-km-long Netaji Subhash Marg from Delhi Gate to Kashmere Gate to decongest parts of Old Delhi, chief minister Rekha Gupta stated in a press statement on Sunday.

Gupta added that the landscaped stretch, featuring enhanced pedestrian facilities, will connect prominent landmarks such as the Red Fort, Jama Masjid, St James' Church, and the Chandni Chowk intersection.

The project, undertaken by the Indraprastha Virasat Punarvikas Nigam (IVPN), aims to transform the stretch into a more organised, attractive, safe, and convenient corridor. "Along with improving the appearance, the plan places special emphasis on connecting the historic monuments, parks, and public spaces in the surrounding area. It will be turned into a vibrant link between Delhi's history, heritage, architecture, and culture," she said.

Based on the available road width, the beautification plan has been divided into three sections, as per the project report, also seen by HT. The first section will extend from Kashmere Gate to GPO Chowk. "This is the busiest part of the corridor, with a road width ranging from 12 to 24 metres. The second section will cover the stretch from GPO Chowk to Brij Mohan Chowk, the intersection leading towards Jama Masjid, and has an average width of 45 metres. The third section will extend from Brij Mohan Chowk to the Delhi Gate intersection, with an average width ranging from 16.8 to 26 metres," an official said.

The official said the redevelopment plan provides adequate space for vehicular traffic as well as pedestrians and non-motorised transport.

"The proposed facilities include wider footpaths, bus lanes, motor vehicle lanes, parking spaces, pedestrian plazas, and cycle tracks. Public toilets will also be constructed on both sides of the road, while existing bus stops will be upgraded. These facilities will be developed in accordance with the design guidelines shared by the Public Works Department (PWD) for its existing streetscape project," the official said.

A key feature of the project is the integrated development of historic, cultural, and public spaces located around Netaji Subhash Marg. The plan includes prominent landmarks such as the Red Fort, Jama Masjid, St James' Church, the Kashmere Gate area, the Chandni Chowk intersection connected to the Red Fort, Subhash Park, Hindi Park, IGT University, Agrasen Park, and Sunehri Masjid.

"It also envisages integrating 12 prominent locations and green spaces, including Agrasen Park, Lothian Cemetery, Old Railway Station Chowk, the Red Fort Green Pocket, the Dussehra Mela site at the Red Fort, Chandni Chowk-Red Fort Chowk, Sunehri Masjid Bagh, Subhash Park, Brij Mohan Chowk, Delhi Gate Chowk, Ekta Sthal, and Hindi Park. The idea is to develop the available green spaces along the route more effectively and make this historic part of the city more attractive," the official added.

Gupta said under the plan, and a "Heritage Interpretation Park" will be developed.

Lawyers, police agree to set up panel to resolve future disputes

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: Lawyer bodies and the Delhi Police have agreed to set up a joint coordination committee and appoint nodal officers to address grievances and prevent disputes between the two from escalating. This comes days after a confrontation between lawyers and police personnel in Shahdara led to a strike across Delhi's district courts.

The decision was taken at a meeting on October 30 attended by senior Delhi Police officers, along with representatives of the Bar Council of Delhi, the Coordination Committee of All District Bar Associations and executive committee members of various district court bar associations.

Rajiv Ranjan, Delhi Police spokesperson told HT on Sunday, "Under the proposed mechanism, a joint committee comprising representatives of the police and lawyers will be constituted to facilitate dialogue and resolve issues between the two sides. Dedicated nodal officers will also be appointed at the district level and at police headquarters to ensure that grievances are addressed promptly."

It was also agreed that the concerned Bar Association would, as far as practicable, be informed whenever an FIR is registered against a practising advocate. Bar associations will provide updated directories of their office-bearers and members to the respective district DCPs.

Both sides also agreed to maintain professional courtesy and mutual respect. Police personnel will extend due courtesy to advocates at police stations, while lawyers will similarly respect police officials within court premises, the Delhi Police said in a statement.

The move follows a confrontation on October 23, when lawyers accused an ACP and a Shahdara SHO of threatening them and assaulting an advocate. The incident triggered an indefinite strike by lawyers across Delhi's district courts, with the bar associations demanding action against the officers.

The strike was called off on October 28 after the two officers were transferred.

Custom official said the MDMA was hidden in food packets the flyer was bringing from Manila, Philippines. HT PHOTO

Customs seize drugs worth ₹5 crore from passenger at IGIA

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NEW DELHI: Customs officials at the Indira Gandhi International (IGI) Airport on Sunday seized 5kg of synthetic narcotic substances from an Indian national returning from the Philippines.

The seizure, which is estimated to be worth ₹5 crore, includes Ecstasy, also known as MDMA or 'Molly' that acts as both a stimulant and a hallucinogen.

The contraband was seized from a passenger arriving from Manila during the intervening night of October 30 and 31.

"On specific intelligence, the passenger was intercepted by officers of the Customs Air Intelligence Unit upon his arrival from Manila. Examination of the passenger's baggage led to the recovery of around five kg of a homogeneous mixture suspected to contain MDMA and other narcotic substances, ingeniously concealed inside packets of everyday food products", a senior official at Delhi Customs said.

Preliminary tests indicated the presence of synthetic narcotic substances, leading to seizure under the NDPS Act, 1985.

Further investigation is underway to establish the source of the contraband and identify possible links in the drug trafficking network.

Recently, Delhi Customs has busted a gold smuggling syndicate at the IGI airport and seized 6.5kg of gold, worth around ₹9.9 crore, from eight passengers who arrived from Dubai.

The gold was concealed in the form of metallic chains, coated in black and silver.

Following the bust, several Customs officers posted at the airport were shifted to non-sensitive back-office postings or repatriated, while one officer was suspended. "A vigilance inquiry has also been ordered to examine allegations of collusion and supervisory lapses," an official had said, who did not wish to be named.

Delhiwale

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Mayank Austen Soofi

Sakina's Tyeb Mehta

Glimpsing into an artist's world

{ PRIVATE CAPITAL }

She called him Tyebi. The world knew him as the great modernist painter Tyeb Mehta.

Four years shy of a century, Sakina Mehta brings out her first book this month. My Tyebi: A Memoir tracks her six decades with husband Tyeb and their life in the world of modern Indian art. The couple's daughter Himani wrote it with author Nusrat Jafri, using over a decade of recorded conversations with Sakina and her archive.

From the mid-1960s through the 1970s, Sakina and Tyeb lived with their children, Himani and Yusuf, in Delhi: first in a bungalow outhouse in Nizamuddin East, then in a two-bedroom pad in Nizamuddin West. Tyeb would scarcely have imagined then the obscene sums his works would one day fetch. This year, the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art in Saket hosted a major retrospective of his work. (The photo, taken some years ago at Himani's Delhi home, shows her and Sakina with his 1966 painting Falling Figure.)

During his struggling years in Delhi, Tyeb painted daily. Sakina was the family's roti winner, working as an office secretary in Jorbagh. She now lives in Mumbai, where she grew up in a Bohra Muslim family. After Tyeb's passing in 2009, she would spend long stretches at daughter Himani's home, then in South Delhi. Once she shared with this reporter her recipe for the Bohra biryani she would cook for Tyeb. Sakina's version uses chicken instead of lamb, for red meat was out after Tyeb's first heart attack in 1983. Here's the recipe for biryani à la Tyeb.

Clean 1 kg chicken. Mix with 1 teaspoon salt, juice of 1 lemon and 1 tsp ginger paste. Deep fry 4 sliced onions until brown. Reserve the oil for potatoes. Blend onions with 500g curd. Add to the chicken with 2 tsp lal mirchi powder, 1 tsp garam masala and a dash of haldi. Marinate overnight in the fridge. Next morning, grind 2 green chillies, some coriander leaves and 6 garlic pods. Lightly fry in 4 tsp ghee. Add to marinade. Peel and halve 4 potatoes. Soak in salted water. Drain after soaking.

Deep fry the potatoes in reserved oil until reddish brown. Add to the chicken. Soak a few saffron strands in ½ cup warm milk. Set aside. Soak ½ kg basmati rice for 30 minutes. Boil water in a large pot with 2 bay leaves and some salt. Add rice. Partly cook the rice, then drain. It finishes cooking with the chicken. Heat additional ghee in another large pot. Spread half the partly cooked rice evenly. Add the chicken and potatoes. Cover completely with remaining rice. Pour saffron and soaking milk over rice. Rinse leftover masala from the marinating tray with ½ cup water. Pour over the remaining rice. Line the pot's rim with kneaded wheat dough, press the lid onto it and place a brick on top. Cook for 1 hour on low flame. Serve with sweet-salty dahi.

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{ HERITAGE TOURS } NEXT ON NOV 14

DDA set to organise walks in Sanjay Van

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) will organise heritage walks with guided tours in Sanjay Van to connect people with Delhi's rich heritage, the authority said on Sunday.

The walk on November 14 will be held in association with the Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage (INTACH).

"This will be the second walk in the series, and the guided tour will provide visitors with an opportunity to explore the area's extensive history and understand the significance of its historic structures. The walk will cover five locations: the historic well, the large fortification, the small fortification, the bastion near the small fortification and the Lal Kot wall. The historic well, located near the large fortification, is understood to date to the Delhi Sultanate period and represents Delhi's traditional water infrastructure," read a statement.

Forest's significance

The large fortification in Sanjay Van comprises some of the best-preserved remains of Lal Kot-Qila Rai Pithora, Delhi's first fortified city, built by the Tomars in the 11th century CE and expanded by the Chauhans in the 12th century CE. The historic walls reflect early Rajput military architecture and mark the beginning of Delhi's medieval history.

The DDA said interested candidates must pay a ₹500 fee per person and fill out the registration form on the heritage walk website.

PROPERTY DEALER HELD FOR DUPING MAN OF ₹47 LAKH IN HOUSE DEAL

NEW DELHI: A property dealer was arrested for cheating a man of ₹47 lakh on the pretext of selling him a flat in northeast Delhi's Jafrabad, police said on Sunday.

Anees, 38, was arrested from Kardampuri on Wednesday following an investigation into a complaint filed by 53-year-old Ahmad Ali Khan, an officer said.

According to the complaint, Anees allegedly induced the victim to pay ₹47 lakh on the pretext of selling him a flat. A case was registered at Jafrabad police station on October 15.

During the investigation, police recovered a mobile phone from the accused. Its contents are being examined to establish the alleged fraud and identify other people involved in the racket.

Police said he was also allegedly involved in another case in which he staged a firing incident targeting himself and his office to evade payments owed to his customers. PTI

Delhi LG calls on students to join efforts to clean Yamuna

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NEW DELHI: Lieutenant Governor (LG) Taranjit Singh Sandhu said that achieving a clean Ganga is possible only with a clean Yamuna, noting that the Yamuna basin accounts for about 40% of the Ganga basin.

Sandhu made these observations while addressing students of Delhi Public School Mathura Road during their annual day function themed "Ganga – Ek Aviral Dhara" on Saturday.

"Ganga may seem far away, but is closer than they think. The Yamuna, whose basin makes up about 40% of the Ganga basin, meets her at the Sangam in Prayagraj. Yet the Yamuna's 22-km stretch in Delhi, less than 2% of its length, accounts for about 76% of its pollution. An Aviral and Nirmal Ganga is therefore possible only with an Aviral and Nirmal Yamuna," Sandhu said.

Sandhu asked students to contribute in simple ways: by never throwing plastic or puja material into the river and by encouraging their families and friends to do the same.

LG TS Sandhu being welcomed by students at a school on Mathura Road on Saturday. X

"A cleaner Yamuna in Delhi means a cleaner Ganga for the whole nation," he added.

Congratulating the school on completing 77 years since its establishment in 1949, the LG commended its teachers and staff for their contribution to education. He noted that as the flagship school of the DPS Society, it has contributed to an educational tradition.

The LG said the Ganga occupies a unique place in India's civilisational history, finding expression in the country's scriptures, poetry, music, art and spiritual traditions. Along its banks, he noted, centres of learning, pilgrimage and cultural exchange have flourished, and the river has sustained communities, supported livelihoods and shaped settlements.

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

I.N.D.I.A. BLOC RALLY

ries. Sunday's stir was the first such street protest since a brief hiatus in agitation last month.

The Opposition programme included a march from the edge of Connaught Place to Ramlila Maidan, a route of 1.3km touching Minto Road and Kamla Market. It began at around 12.45 pm as leaders from more than 19 parties — Gandhi, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee, RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav, NCP (SP) leader Supriya Sule and National Conference president Farooq Abdullah – boarded open-top buses commissioned from Rajasthan. For about 1.5 hours, the convoy of vehicles, flanked by thousands of supporters and political workers, drove around central Delhi before reaching Ramlila Maidan at 2.30pm.

"We are here to ensure the chief election commissioner resigns. We stood our ground, were on the ground on every protest call, got beaten up, and detained by police," said Rakesh Solanki, who travelled from Badaun in Uttar Pradesh.

In the rally, nine leaders spoke, beginning with CPIML's Dipankar Bhattacharya and ending with Gandhi.

Several leaders demanded a trial for treason against Kumar, vowed to continue the fight and even set the stage for the upcoming Uttar Pradesh and Punjab elections. Rashtriya Janata Dal leader Tejashwi Yadav termed the rally "Mahabharata" and Akhilesh Yadav said Ramlila maidan had become democracy's battle of Haldighati, where Maharana Pratap and the Mughal forces clashed in the 16th century. Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge demanded Kumar be sent to jail "so that no one else dares to do such a thing again."

The BJP held a counter protest in Hari Nagar and alleged 40% of Ramlila grounds were empty.

Union minister JP Nadda slammed the Congress for holding its rally on a day that marked the anniversary of the anti-Sikh riots following the assassination of then prime minister Indira Gandhi on October 31, 1984.

"The Congress's objective is to reopen the wounds of the Sikh community, create anarchy in Delhi, destabilise a democratically elected government and malign the country," Nadda said

BJP chief Nitin Nabin accused the Opposition of disrespecting democracy. "When they get this people's mandate in Himachal, when they win in Karnataka, then they say democracy has won, but when they lose in Haryana, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and West Bengal, then they say democracy is in danger. What kind of dual mentality do you have?" he asked.

In the Ramlila Maidan rally, Gandhi said that they did not promote violence and neither had any hatred towards Modi, Shah or Gyanesh Kumar. "We will not spread hatred; we will work with love but we will not let them destroy the Constitution," he said.

"I want to say to you, Gyanesh Kumar will be removed from the CEC post. Gyanesh Kumar will go to jail," he added.

He also questioned the legitimacy of the BJP's victory in 2024.

"Whoever you are, you are not bigger than the Constitution. For years, vote theft has been taking place. After the 2024 election, 13.5 crore voters were removed. In 2024, we had just 3% difference with the NDA. Then 15% of voters were removed. This means, 2024 election was illegal. No power on earth can save Gyanesh Kumar. He will be removed as CEC and go to jail. This is the theft of people's voices. This is treason," he said.

He said the rally was the voice of Indians "saying we will not allow democracy to end".

Akhilesh Yadav referred to the SP's recent wins in the legislative council polls and stumped for the INDIA bloc in the upcoming UP assembly elections. "Those who hailed the double engine government, I am happy that people of Kashi gave them double zero. People know that if I have votes, their citizenship will remain. And the BJP wants only its supporters to have votes and remain citizens. This is Ramlila maidan. I can say that Ramlila maidan has become the Haldighati of democracy."

"This maidan has written many histories. This huge participation is an indication that another change will come. Those who came from UP, will leave from UP. People of UP know how to invite someone. But they know better how to send someone off. In the last Lok Sabha election, they were sent off partially. But next year they will face such an exit that they won't be able to come back. This is Ram ji ki lila ka maidan. And we know that for ages, that the sinners are removed. But those who have stolen Lord Ram's treasures, committed Chanda chori, donation theft, they will have disastrous consequences," he added.

Tejashwi underlined that SIR started before the 2025 Bihar elections and said, "This Ramlila maidan is for Ramayan, but we have organised a Mahabharat for the vote thieves."

Kharge alleged that Modi tried to steal the votes of young people, women and Dalits. "As long as Gyanesh Kumar doesn't go, we will continue to fight and we will definitely remove him. Modi is trying his best to hide him, but we will bring him out. Women and youth have this power."

Former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee said, "What haven't they looted? They looted the money of Ram Janmabhoomi, Waqf properties...The police became their comrades. The BJP has no organisation of its own. That is why they make the police do party work. Agencies don't work with the BJP. The BJP will go."

Congress parliamentary party chief Sonia Gandhi, party MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, former J&K CMs Farooq Abdullah and Mehbooba Mufti, CPI(Marxist) chief MA Baby, CPI(ML) leader Dipankar Bhattacharya, Forward Bloc's G Devarajan, NCP (SP) leader Supriya Sule, independent MP Kapil Sibal and others were present at the rally.

Police did not share the exact number of people who attended the rally but estimates suggest around 50,000 supporters turned up.

The ongoing protests are part of a longer string of events that have mounted pressure on Kumar. The developments follow an Indian Express investigation that said election commissioners SS Sandhu and Vivek Joshi recorded written dissents and objections at least 14 times between November 2025 and August 2026 and even wrote to the cabinet secretary. It also alleged that election officials found their access to the ECI software curtailed by the central IT team. ECI said differing views and observations were a normal part of deliberation and that all its digital platforms operated under strict data security protocols.

Over the past month, thousands of people have hit the streets, braving Metro closures, internet shutdown, prohibitory orders and 40,000 security personnel who turned the Capital into a virtual fortress and sparked controversy by dragging, manhandling and detaining many agitators. While the Opposition is seeking the removal of Kumar and scrapping the controversial special intensive revision, the BJP blames them for trying to destabilise constitutional bodies to deflect attention from their own political and electoral failures.

Last month, the Opposition submitted a memorandum to President Droupadi Murmu and filed a petition at the Supreme Court. On Saturday, 250 Opposition lawmakers met to symbolically impeach Kumar in an unprecedented act of protest against a CEC. The Opposition is again set to meet Murmu to submit evidence backing its allegations and launch state-level stirs. The last Opposition rally at the Ramlila maidan was held in March 2024 to protest against the arrest of then Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal and Jharkhand CM Hemant Soren. With Punjab elections round the corner, Kejriwal didn't attend Sunday's rally.

SHAH ATTACKS CONG

liament—all to prevent mothers and sisters from securing 33% reservation. Rahul Baba, let me tell you this: it is this very Narendra Modi ji who will ensure that the women of India— our 'Matrushakti' — receive 33% reservation; this is our firm resolve," he said.

On the choice of date for the rally, Shah said the BJP had asked the INDIA bloc not to hold it on November 1, 2 or 3, referring to the 1984 anti-Sikh riots.

He also claimed that traders in Delhi had appealed to the organisers to defer the rally until after Diwali, when festive sales account for a significant part of their annual business.

"The traders of Delhi pleaded with them, saying, 'We have just one day, one week in the entire year when Modi ji's business thrives. If we stock up on sweets and they don't sell, what happens? It will lead to losses. If we stock up on firecrackers and they don't sell, what happens? We suffer a loss,'" Shah said. He claimed that trade worth ₹25,000 crore takes place in Delhi's wholesale markets in the three to four days around Diwali, with buyers coming from across north India.

Shah recalled former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi's remark, "When a big tree falls, the earth shakes", made after Indira Gandhi's assassination. "I saw that statement on television, and I can never forget it in my lifetime," he said. Shah described the 1984 violence as having been "incited by the Congress party" and accused Rahul Gandhi of organising the rally to "rub salt into the wounds" of victims and their families.

He said the Modi government had reopened cases related to the 1984 violence after coming to power, provided financial assistance of ₹5 lakh to each victim and ensured that prominent Congress leaders involved in the riots were sent to jail. "India and Punjab will never forget this," he said.

Shah also warned the Congress that it would continue to fare poorly in Delhi. "Now remember my words: for the next three elections, your account is not going to open there," he said.

The INDIA bloc held its 'Chalo Dilli' rally at Ramlila Maidan on Sunday as part of its campaign against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over alleged irregularities in electoral rolls and the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise.

A day earlier, Opposition leaders had staged a symbolic "public impeachment" of Kumar at the lawns of Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, in a setting resembling parliamentary proceedings. They accused him of deleting votes to influence election outcomes and demanded that he be tried in court for treason and jailed. The BJP had described the exercise as a "mockery" of Parliament.

Turning to Punjab, Shah expressed confidence that the National Democratic Alliance would form the government in the state after the 2027 assembly elections. He said the alliance was working to bring a saffron government to Punjab and reiterated the Centre's target of making the entire country, including the state, drug-free by December 31, 2029. "Now, mark my words: by December 31, 2029, we will ensure that the entire country — including Punjab — is completely free from the menace of drugs," he said.

Shah was speaking at an event marking Chandigarh's 60th year, where he inaugurated projects and laid foundation stones for development works worth around ₹258 crore. Earlier, he attended the 60th Raising Day celebrations of Chandigarh Police and presented the President's Colour to the force.

SBI HEIST IN MAHA

recovered all of the cash and gold, along with firearms, weapons and two vehicles allegedly used in the crime.

Investigators believe Jasak's years in the police force, followed by his encounters with the criminal justice system, gave him the knowledge and contacts to orchestrate the robbery.

Three of the four suspects reportedly met in Jalgaon district prison and stayed in touch after their release.

They allegedly planned the heist before recruiting a fourth accomplice.

Jasak's own career in the Maharashtra Police ended in 2023 after he was named an accused in another robbery at an SBI branch in Jalgaon city. The ₹3.17-crore robbery case was registered at Shani Peth police station under sections 394 and 34 of the Indian Penal Code.

His father and brother-in-law, who worked as a security guard at the same bank, were also named as accused. Taking serious note of his alleged involvement, then special inspector general of police Praveen Pawar dismissed him from service.

Jalgaon police said Jasak joined the Maharashtra Police as a PSI in the 113th batch in 2015 and was posted to the Raigad district police force. His career first came under a cloud on December 27, 2018, when an Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) case was registered against him following a trap operation in Mahad.

He was suspended but subsequently reinstated by senior officers and posted at the Raigad district police control room.

Investigators said Jasak allegedly planned the latest robbery with Gajanan Rajendra Pawar, 32, whom he met in prison. Pawar was arrested for murder in 2024 and out on bail.

The gang allegedly conducted a reconnaissance of the SBI branch twice.

How the plan went awry

"Once the emergency alarm went off, villagers and police patils chased them down and helped arrest them. Police recovered all nine bags and the stolen valuables," said Shrikant Dhivare, superintendent of police, Jalgaon.

Police teams, assisted by villagers, tracked down the four men.

Two were found hiding in a field, while the others were intercepted. All four were arrested after allegedly resisting the police, leaving some personnel with minor injuries. During the chase, the accused allegedly abandoned four bags containing stolen valuables near Chavalkheda.

Umakant Gaikwad, police inspector at Dharangaon police station, who was part of the team pursuing the accused, said, "When we received information about the incident, two of the accused were heading towards Dharangaon. We immediately alerted police patils and villagers, and with their help, arrested all the accused. They resisted arrest, and some members of our team sustained minor injuries."

The other two accused have been identified as Ankush Tulsiram Pawar, 26, from Burhanpur district in Madhya Pradesh, and Ankush Shravan Chavan, 30, from Ramdevwadi in Jalgaon district.

Jalgaon district guardian minister Gulabrao Patil visited the bank after the robbery and reviewed the situation. He credited the swift response of villagers and the police for the recovery of valuables worth more than ₹30 crore.

"This is a very serious case of bank robbery. But due to alert local people and the police force, all the accused were arrested and all the cash and belongings were successfully recovered. Due to the involvement of local people in policing, we have successfully recovered belongings worth over ₹30 crore," Patil said.

"Due to drought-like conditions, the police now have to keep watch on financial institutions like banks," he added.

A case has been registered at Jalgaon Taluka police station under sections 309(4), 109(1), 127(2), 115(2), 351(2), 351(3), 352 and 3(5) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and sections 3/25 and 3/27 of the Arms Act.

EC SUSPENDS TWO EROs OVER PILIBHIT ELECTORAL ROLL IRREGULARITIES

Rajesh Kumar Singh
letters@hindustantimes.com

LUCKNOW: The Election Commission on Sunday ordered the suspension of two electoral registration officers (EROs) over irregularities in the electoral rolls of Pilibhit Sadar assembly constituency in Uttar Pradesh, directing that they not be reinstated without its prior approval.

The officers, Mayank Goswami and Hemant Chaudhary, were serving as subdivisional magistrates (SDMs) in Pilibhit. The state government transferred them on Saturday and placed them on the wait list.

In a letter to state chief electoral officer (CEO) Navdeep Rinwa, EC under secretary Deepmala said the commission had examined the report submitted by the state CEO regarding irregularities in the constituency's electoral rolls. "The EC has ordered suspension of both the EROs. Their charge sheets should be furnished to the Commission for further vetting. The erring officers shall not be reinstated without the prior approval of the commission," the letter said.

The commission also directed that Section 198 of the BNS, pertaining to a public servant disobeying the law, be considered for addition to the FIR already registered against the two EROs and Anil Kumar, a computer operator at the voter registration centre.

It further instructed officials to "rigorously pursue" the cases in court to ensure they reach their "logical conclusion".

The EC has sought a report from Pilibhit district election officer (DEO) on the scrutiny of electoral rolls across all four assembly constituencies in the district within a week, along with specific comments from the state CEO.

The commission has also directed that an action-taken report against the VRC operator and details of the role of five assistant electoral registration officers (AEROs) in Pilibhit Sadar be submitted within three days.

Separately, the EC has instructed all district election officers and EROs in Uttar Pradesh to thoroughly re-examine electoral rolls under their jurisdiction, particularly entries related to additions, deletions and modifications made through Forms 6, 7 and 8.

DIRECTORATE OF AVIATION
GOVT. OF CHHATTISGARH, MAHANADI BHAWAN
CAPITAL COMPLEX, MANTRALAYA
NAVA RAIPUR (CG): 492002, INDIA
Phone No.: +91(0)771-2510172
FAX No.: +91(0)771-2510172

Ref No. /DoA/Ops/tender/2026/1116 Nava Raipur,
Date: 29.10.2026

CORRIGENDUM

NOTIFICATION FOR THE RATE EMPANELMENT OF CHARTER SERVICES OF HELICOPTER/AEROPLANE

विमानन संचालनालय, छत्तीसगढ़ शासन द्वारा हेलीकॉप्टर एवं विमान के दीर्घकालीन तैनात तथा आवश्यकता अनुसार (As-and-when demand basis) किराये पर उपलब्ध कराने हेतु पात्र संचालकों के पैनल निर्माण (Empanelment) के संबंधित Corrigendum जारी किया जा रहा है, जिसमें आवेदन प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि 02.11.2026 है। यह इम्पैनलमेंट तीन (03) वर्षों की अवधि हेतु मान्य रहेगा।

विस्तृत निविदा दस्तावेज छत्तीसगढ़ राज्य ई-प्रोक्योरमेंट पोर्टल http://eproc.cgstate.gov.in/ पर उपलब्ध रहेगा।

महत्वपूर्ण तिथियां :

- निविदा प्रस्तुत करने की अंतिम तिथि : 02.11.2026 संध्या 05:00 बजे तक
- निविदा खोलने की तिथि : 03.11.2026 प्रातः 11 बजे

इच्छुक निविदाकारों को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे पात्रता मापदंड, नियम एवं शर्तें तथा अन्य आवश्यक निर्देशों हेतु उपरोक्त ई-प्रोक्योरमेंट पोर्टल अवलोकन करें।

Director
Directorate of Aviation
Mantralaya, Nava Raipur (C.G.)

G-262704297/2

THE INSTITUTE OF CHARTERED ACCOUNTANTS OF INDIA
(Set up by an Act of Parliament)
"ICAI Bhawan', Indraprastha Marg, New Delhi – 110 002

Notice Inviting Tender
(Tender Ref. no. ICAI/ Renovation works /New Delhi/2026/1)

The Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI), a statutory body set up by an Act of Parliament, invites unconditional sealed bids in Two Bid System (Technical & Financial Bid in two separate envelopes) in prescribed format, from eligible, experienced, and reputed Contractors/Companies/ firms in respect of proposed "Renovation works for ICAI Bhawan (Main Building), Indraprastha Marg, nearby ITO Metro Station Gate No-6, New Delhi - 110002".

The last date for receipt of duly filled in sealed bids is 23rd November 2026 upto 4 PM. The detailed terms and conditions along with Tender document are available at ICAI's website https://www.icai.org/post/icai-eoi-tenders.

Secretary, ICAI

ओएनजीसी ONGC
ऑयल एण्ड नेचुरल गैस कॉरपोरेशन लिमिटेड
Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Ltd.

Publication of EOI notice

Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Ltd. (ONGC), a Government of India "MAHARATNA" Enterprise, invites Expression of Interest (EOI) from experienced agencies for comprehensive Operation and Maintenance (O&M) of Drillmec make New Generation Drilling Rigs (NG/HP-2000 and NG-1500 categories). The EOI aims to assess market capability, technical expertise, manpower availability, maintenance systems, contracting models, mobilisation timelines and indicative commercial approach, for safe and reliable 24x7 rig operations.

Detailed information regarding the EOI is available on the ONGC Tender Portal https://tenders.ongc.co.in. The last date for submission of EOI responses is 23.11.2026. Interested vendors may submit their responses in electronic format to ts_support@ongc.co.in.

Corrigenda, addenda, amendments, and time extensions to the EOI (if any) will be published only on the ONGC tender portal only. No separate notification shall be issued in the press. Prospective participants are advised to visit the portal regularly for updates.

For further details, please visit ONGC e-portal: https://tenders.ongc.co.in

CAFRAL
CENTRE FOR ADVANCED FINANCIAL RESEARCH AND LEARNING
Promoted by Reserve Bank of India

Tender Notice

Centre for Advanced Financial Research and Learning (CAFRAL), Promoted by Reserve Bank of India, is inviting tenders for the IFMS services at its campus in Mumbai.

For details and to download tender document visit the CAFRAL website: https://www.cafral.org.in/tenders

Any related corrigendum / amendments will be published on the CAFRAL website.

Last date for tender submission November 30, 2026

vedanta oil & gas

SALE OF CRUDE OIL FROM ASSAM FIELD(S)

NOTICE INVITING OFFER

Vedanta Oil and Gas Limited invites offer from interested entities ('Bidders') with demonstrated presence in the Crude Oil processing to participate in the bidding process for the purchase of Low Sulphur Crude Oil produced from the following blocks in Assam, India:

Block: AA/ONDSF/HAZARIGAON/2018
District: Golaghat
RFP: RFP/DSF/HZ/2026/01 (may be published in multiple tranches (01A, 01B, 01C & so on) covering supplies during December 2026 to December 2027.
Grade: Low Sulphur Medium Density Crude Oil
Quantity in each Tranche: Refer respective RFP / Tranche RFPs
Duration: Refer respective RFP / Tranche RFPs

Block: AA/ONHP/2017/4
District: Jorhat
RFP: RFP/OALP/ASSAM/2026/01 (may be published in multiple tranches (01A, 01B, 01C & so on) covering supplies during December 2026 to December 2027.
Grade: Low Sulphur Medium Density Crude Oil
Quantity in each Tranche: Refer respective RFP / Tranche RFPs
Duration: Refer respective RFP / Tranche RFPs

SUSTAINABLE & RESPONSIBLE DEVELOPMENT
ENHANCING PRODUCTION FROM ASSAM FIELD(S)

Prospective Bidders are required to download the RFP(s) / Tranche RFPs as published from time to time during the year 2026 and 2027 made available at https://c1auctions.com/fa and follow instructions therein to participate in the e-bidding process. For any queries related to RFP(s), please contact e-Bidding agency at- vedlsupport@c1india.com.

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EVERYONE HAS A THEORY OURS HAS THE NUMBERS

Hindustan Times NUMBER THEORY

Question assumptions. Discover insights.

LOOK FOR NUMBER THEORY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES

कार्यालय तहसीलदार बहेड़ी, बरेली

पत्रांक 461 / वा0वा0न0 – संग्रह – 2026 दिनांक 31/10/2026

नीलामी प्रेस विज्ञप्ति

सर्वसाधारण को सूचित किया जाता है कि कार्यालय गन्ना आयुक्त उ0प्र0 के पत्र सं0 250 / सी / क्रय / 16 (2)/वसूली / 2024-25 दिनांक 26.05.2025 से प्राप्त 18,230.46 (लाख में) वसूली प्रमाण पत्र के क्रम में उ0प्र0रा0संहिता की धारा 169 सपठित नियम 141 (3) के अन्तर्गत व्यतिक्रमी अध्यासी केसर इन्टरप्राईजेज लि0 बहेड़ी को 18,230.46 लाख में का मांग पत्र दिनांक 13.06.2025 जारी कर व्यतिक्रमी को विधिवत तामीला कराया गया। मांग पत्र में विनिर्दिष्ट समय के अन्दर भुगतान न किए जाने के कारण दिनांक 16.07.2025 को व्यतिक्रमी की अचल सम्पत्ति / ग्राम मुड़िया मुकर्रमपुर के गाटा संख्या 402मि0 रकबा 11.443हे0 की नियमानुसार कुर्की की गयी। कुर्की उपरान्त आर0सी0 प्रपत्र – 43 दिनांक 01.09.2026 को जारी किया गया, जिसके क्रम में नीलामी की कार्यवाही की जानी है। पूर्व में इस कार्यालय के पत्रांक 444 / वा0वा0न0 – संग्रह –2026 दिनांक 08.10.2026 के माध्यम से नीलामी हेतु दिनांक 24.10.2026 नियत थी। नीलामी दिनांक को मात्र एक व्यक्ति द्वारा नीलामी में प्रतिभाग किये जाने के कारण नीलामी की कार्यवाही सम्पादित नही हो सकी तथा नीलामी कार्यवाही स्थगित कर दी गयी। जिलाधिकारी महोदय के आदेश दिनांक 31.10.2026 के क्रम में उत्तर प्रदेश राजस्व संहिता – 2006 की धारा 184, 185 व 186 तथा उत्तर प्रदेश राजस्व संहिता नियमावली 2016 के नियम 164 (**प्रत्येक अचल सम्पत्ति का विक्रय कलेक्टर अथवा उसके द्वारा प्राधिकृत सहायक कलेक्टर द्वारा किया जायेगा, जो समय–समय पर विक्रय को स्थगित कर सकता है। यदि विक्रय 21 दिन से अधिक के लिये स्थगित की जाती है तो नये विक्रय के नये उद्घोषणा पत्र की आवश्यकता होगी**) में उल्लिखित प्रावधान के अनुसार पुनः ग्राम मुड़िया मुकर्रमपुर तहसील बहेड़ी जनपद बरेली की भूमि / सम्पत्ति, जिसका विवरण निम्नवत् है, की नीलामी दिनांक 17.11.2026 को नियमानुसार आयोजित की जायेगी।

ग्राम	मुड़िया मुकर्रमपुर, तहसील बहेड़ी जनपद बरेली।
गाटा संख्या	402 मि0
रकबा	11.443हे0 . देय भू–राजस्व मु0–291.70 /– रूपये
नीलामी तिथि	17.11.2026
समय	अपराहन 01 बजे
स्थान	तहसील सभागार बहेड़ी, बरेली।
मूल्यांकन	रू0 33,78,77,930 (तैंतीस करोड़, अठत्तर लाख, सतहत्तर हजार नौ सौ तीस रूपये मात्र)
न्यूनतम बोली मूल्य	रूपये 35,00,00,000 (पैंतीस करोड़ रूपये मात्र)
जमानत राशि	न्यूनतम बोली मूल्य का 10%
अधिकतम / सफल बोलीदाता को कुल धनराशि के नीलामी तिथि पर जमा करने हैं।	अधिकतम बोली का 25%

1. यह भूमि बरेली–नैनीताल मार्ग पर मुड़िया टोल प्लाजा से 01 किमी0 पहले स्थित है एवं मेगा फूड पार्क से लगी हुई है।
2. नियत समय और तिथि के उपरान्त किसी आवेदन पर विचार नहीं किया जायेगा।
3. जमानत, व अन्य समस्त धनराशि डिमाण्ड ड्राफ्ट के माध्यम से स्वीकार की जायेगी।
4. नीलामी की प्रक्रिया उत्तर प्रदेश राजस्व संहिता 2006 के अध्याय 12 में उल्लिखित धाराओं तथा उत्तर प्रदेश राजस्व संहिता नियमावली 2016 में अचल सम्पत्ति की कुर्की एवं विक्रय हेतु उल्लिखित प्रावधानों के अनुसार होगी।
5. सफल बोलीदाता को बोली का कुल राशि का 25 प्रतिशत उ0प्र0रा0 संहिता की धारा 189 में प्राविधानानुसार जमानत राशि को समायोजित करते हुये तत्काल एकमुश्त जमा करना होगा, शेष 75 प्रतिशत धनराशि राजस्व संहिता – 2006 की धारा 190 में उल्लिखित प्रतिबन्धों के अधीन यथावर्णित विधि के अनुसार विक्रय के दिनांक से 15वें दिन पर अथवा इसके पूर्व जमा की जा सकेगी।
6. धारा 89 सहित सभी विधिक प्रावधानो, प्रतिबन्धों एवं अनुमतियों का पालन करना अनिवार्य होगा। अतः सभी इच्छुक पक्ष इस सम्बन्ध में स्वंय सुनिश्चित करें।
7. नीलामी से पूर्व भूमि का निरीक्षण किया जा सकता है। इच्छुक व्यक्ति तहसील से आवश्यक जानकारी प्राप्त कर सकते हैं।
8. इस नीलामी का उद्देश्य वैधानिक प्रक्रिया के अन्तर्गत भू–राजस्व के बकाये की वसूली से सम्बन्धित है। इच्छुक व्यक्ति नियत तिथि एवं स्थान पर ससमय उपस्थित होकर प्रतिभाग कर सकते हैं।

तहसीलदार
बहेड़ी, बरेली।

SPOTLIGHT | INDIA BLOC PROTEST

At Delhi rally, Akhilesh casts UP polls as next battle against BJP

Saubhadra Chatterji
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NEW DELHI: Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday joined the Opposition leaders in launching scathing attacks at the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) during the Ramlila Maidan rally in New Delhi against the alleged vote theft and irregularities in the special intensive revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls, as he turned his offensive into a fervent poll speech ahead of the Uttar Pradesh assembly elections due next year, and hailed his party's victory in the Varanasi MLC elections and warned of ousting the BJP from the state.

"Those who once boasted about making India a 'Vishwaguru' are now busy manipulating the electoral rolls. Akhilesh added that the people are set to save democracy, and this movement will begin in Uttar Pradesh," he said.

Likening the gathering to the "Haldighati of democracy", referring to the engagement between the Mewar kingdom and the Mughal empire in 1576, Yadav said the public support reflects the possibility of change. "Today, Ramlila Maidan has turned into the Haldighati of democracy...People of UP know how to cordially invite someone but they know better how to send someone off. In the last Lok Sabha election, they were sent off partially. But next year they will face such an exit that they won't be able to come back," Yadav said, referring to the BJP's 33 seats as against 62 in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls from the state.

The Opposition claimed that a massive turnout at the rally indicated that a change is in the offing, while asserting that those in the Centre will have no ground to stand on as the demand for the removal of Chief Electoral Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar intensified.

Speaker Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, the rally was participated by opposition leaders across party lines, including former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee, CPI(M) general secretary MA Baby, CPI general secretary D Raja, and National Conference chief Farooq Abdullah, among others.

Targeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge claimed that the democracy will survive "only if Modi goes" and called for the prime minister's ouster.

He accused the BJP-led governments in the Centre and states of choosing themselves rather than being elected by the people.

"Who votes for them? They choose themselves. The public does not elect them. The current central government, as well as the governments in Maharashtra, Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, are all governments of vote theft. We must remove these thieves," Kharge said, addressing the rally.

Congress's general secretary (organisation) KC Venugopal later said: "The people of India want to send a message to (PM) Narendra Modi and (home minister) Amit Shah about the way they are destroying the democracy of this country. The people of India have given a clear message to Modi and Shah today: 'your days are over'."

The rally followed an unprecedented public impeachment at a mock-Parliament organised by the INDIA bloc at Kharge's Rajaji Marg residence in New Delhi. Following the exercise, 19 Opposition parties unanimously adopted a resolution to remove CEC Kumar, accusing him of deleting votes to steal elections and carrying out compromised SIR of electoral rolls, at the behest of the BJP, in a six-point charge against him. They also demanded that CEC Kumar be tried in court for treason.

On Sunday, Baby demanded prosecution against CEC Kumar for "vote theft". He also called Modi a "king of lies". "Mahatma Gandhi followed the path of truth during the freedom struggle. But, Narendra Modi is the king of lies...We have to collectively move forward in this struggle to end vote theft," he said.

The TMC chief accused the BJP of looting West Bengal through SIR and vowed to continue fighting against the exercise. "Bengal is the victim of the circumstances of this SIR. We will not give up. We will give our lives, we will fight, but we will not surrender. They looted our Bengal. We will save democracy and bring it back. We will take revenge through politics. We will take revenge through democracy. We will fight," Banerjee said.

The Opposition has been leading protests against the CEC and has met President Droupadi Murmu on October 9, demanding his removal and the repeal of the 2023 law that provides immunity to the CEC and Election Commissioners. It has accused the CEC of the "unilateral and arbitrary exercise of the collective powers" during the ongoing revision of electoral rolls.

On Sunday, Abdullah questioned the claim that most electors were deleted for them being infiltrators, asking whether Hindu voters allegedly removed from the rolls in Uttar Pradesh were also "Pakistanis". "Over one crore Hindus have been removed in UP. Are they also Pakistanis? How long will you give this excuse?" he asked, accusing the poll body of "vote chori". "This is Ambedkar's Constitution. This is India's Constitution. We are all equal, and everyone has an equal vote. Jammu and Kashmir was, is and will remain a part of India. They will not be able to separate it."

Rashtriya Janata Dal leader Tejashwi Yadav described the fight against the alleged vote theft as a battle between the country's voters and "cheaters".

"Prime Minister Modi, you have to choose between the country and Gyanu; the whole country is watching. This fight is between the country's voters and its cheaters," Yadav said.

Peoples Democratic Party chief Mehbooba Mufti warned the Constitution was being hollowed out. Addressing the rally, she said: "The very Constitution that has given you the vote to change the government, to bring down the government, and to form a new government, they want to snatch that right away from you. We, the people of Jammu and Kashmir, have been ruined. In 2019, they destroyed the Constitution there. But now you must save yourselves, lest they turn the entire country into Jammu and Kashmir. We are with you. Standing shoulder to shoulder, we are with you in your struggle."

CPI(ML) chief Dipankar Bhattacharya said, "For the past one month, we launched the agitation, Vote Chor Gaddi Chore. Now we have come to the Ramlila ground. The whole country is a tool to snatch away voting rights from the people."

(With PTI inputs)

Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Congress Parliamentary Party Chairperson Sonia Gandhi, SP Chief Akhilesh Yadav, RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav, and other Opposition leaders during the INDIA bloc's rally in Delhi. ARVIND YADAV/HT

50+ protesters briefly held over 'violations'

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NEW DELHI: Delhi Police said over 50 protesters were briefly detained near Minto Road on Sunday for violating restrictions, even as the INDIA bloc's rally, which drew tens of thousands of participants, unfolded peacefully and without any major incidents.

Police said they made detentions after the rally as a few protesters went towards Minto Road, where restrictions were in place.

More than 2,500 paramilitary personnel were deployed to ensure peace during the march. Police said permission was granted for the Ramlila Maidan rally, not for the march from Connaught Place to the protest ground.

"With large crowds, we didn't stop the march. We ensured that it navigated peacefully," said a police officer, part of the arrangement, who did not wish to be named.

Police said paramilitary deployment was retained in the New Delhi district area, with suspicion that protesters "swaying" from the march and heading towards CP or other areas.

The nearly 12-acre Ramlila Maidan, which can accommodate around 50,000 people, has eight entry and exit gates. One gate was reserved for the VVIPs.

According to the security plan, the entire Ramlila Maidan was divided into eight regions and 14 zones. A deputy commissioner of police (DCP) or additional DCP-rank officer was in charge of each region and an assistant commissioner of police-rank officer of each zone. They were assisted by at least 25 Inspectors and personnel between the ranks of sub-inspectors and constables.

Body-worn cameras and anti-riot measures were in place to deal with violence or "untoward incidents", police said.

An additional 10 companies of the paramilitary forces and Delhi Police personnel were kept in reserve.

"We had made elaborate arrangements, which were successful. A huge crowd was managed well," Special Police Commissioner (law and order) Devesh Srivastava said.

DCP (Central) Rohit Rajbir said door-frame metal detectors were installed to screen participants.

Meanwhile, several protesters said there were restrictions on the Delhi-Faridabad and Delhi-Noida borders.

A few Congress leaders from Rajasthan alleged their cards were stopped near Faridabad.

However, when reached, Delhi Police refuted the allegations, saying no such restrictions were in place and free movement was allowed.

Police personnel detain a demonstrator marching towards Jantar Mantar at Minto road on Sunday. PTI

Crowds converge at Ramlila Maidan

An aerial view of people gathered during the INDIA bloc's 'Chalo Dilli' protest rally against alleged electoral irregularities and demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar at Ramlila Maidan in New Delhi on Sunday. PTI

OPPN LEADERS SAY

People of UP know how to cordially invite someone but they know better how to send someone off

AKHILESH YADAV, Samajwadi Party chief

The current central govt, as well as the governments in Maharashtra, Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, are all governments of vote theft. We must remove these thieves

MALLIKARJUN KHARGE, Congress chief

Bengal is the victim of the circumstances of this SIR. We will not give up. We will give our lives, we will fight, but we will not surrender

MAMATA BANERJEE, Former West Bengal CM

Stir keeps shoppers away, CP bears the brunt before Diwali

Hemani Bhandari and Paras Singh
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NEW DELHI: The Opposition and Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) blamed each other on Sunday as traders in Connaught Place reported poor sales on the last Sunday before Diwali in light of the INDIA bloc protest.

Speaking to reporters, hours ahead of the protest, Union minister and senior BJP leader JP Nadda accused the Opposition of disrupting business ahead of the festive season. "It is the festive season. Throughout the year, small traders, street vendors, shopkeepers wait for it for some earnings during these festivals. But Rahul Gandhi does not care about stoves burning in traders' homes. He only wants to ignite the fire of his politics," he said.

Hours later, leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha and senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi accused the BJP of pressuring shopkeepers to shut their stores, despite rally participants having been urged to support local traders.

"We told everyone that when you come here for the march and the mega rally, buy things, do some shopping. But, while coming to CP here, we found out that the BJP has forcibly shut down every single shop. So, you should know who is causing the loss to the traders, and how it's happening," the Congress leader alleged, speaking to the media.

In a post on X, Union home minister Amit Shah said, "Delhi's traders pleaded that the rally be held after Diwali, otherwise there would be heavy losses in business, but Rahul Baba just had to hold the rally on the very day the Sikh massacre took place. More than ₹25,000 crore trade occurred in these three days as whole North India comes to the wholesale market of Delhi to purchase goods... I want to tell Congress that you have caused losses to small traders and now your electoral account will not open for the next three elections."

Traders in CP said the rally had affected business as parking was occupied by participants and customers opted to stay away amid apprehensions of restrictions and congestion.

"Once again, CP is bearing the brunt of these rallies, creating an atmosphere of uncertainty and fear among customers," said Atul Bhargava, president of the New Delhi Traders Association.

Bhargava said repeated disruptions were worsening an already difficult situation for traders during the festive season and arguing that rallies and processions through commercial areas are affecting traders' right to livelihood.

Restaurants, however, remained open through the day. "Of course, the business is impacted as people avoid coming but what should we do, we have been seeing this for a month now," said a branch manager of a south Indian restaurant in CP.

Last week, the Chamber of Trade and Industry (CTI) wrote to Rahul Gandhi, urging him to postpone the rally post-Diwali to avoid affecting festive-season business.

The Confederation of All India Traders (CAIT) also launched an online petition last week against protests in central Delhi as they were disrupting commercial activity and livelihoods.

CAIT general secretary, BJP MP Praveen Khandelwal, on Sunday said Gandhi's appeal to protesters to purchase from Delhi's markets was not serious. "Delhi's markets need customers not the crowd of a rally," he said.

Other hubs

In contrast, Sarojini Nagar traders reported better-than-expected business despite initial apprehensions about the rally.

"Over 100,000 people visited Sarojini Nagar market on Sunday. The business was better-than-expected, with a significant number of shoppers coming not just from Delhi-NCR but also from other regions," said Ashok Randhawa, president of the Sarojini Nagar Mini Market Traders Association.

Some retail shops remained closed at CP amid protest. HT

{ PARTICIPANTS FROM ACROSS INDIA }

Cockroaches, Batman, cut-finger garlands: Protesters bring colour to anti-SIR march

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NEW DELHI: By 11 am on Sunday, the Inner Circle of Connaught Place was already crowded with people ahead of the march to Ramlila Maidan, some 2km away, as part of the "Chalo Dilli" protest planned at noon. There were students, activists, political groups from across the country and even ordinary people, carrying placards and chanting slogans.

Standing near H-Block, 38-year-old Rakesh Solanki said, "We are here to ensure the chief election commissioner resigns." He had travelled all the way from Uttar Pradesh's Badaun and was part of a group who called themselves the Cockroach Volunteers.

"We are the real cockroaches. We stood our ground, were on the ground on every protest call, got beaten up, and detained by police," he told HT as the crowds made their way to the Minto Road junction.

The Congress-led INDIA Bloc rally drew tens of thousands of people. Starting 1.30pm they marched from Minto Road to Ramlila Maidan. The entire way people could be heard chanting slogans against CEC Gyanesh Kumar.

While there are no official figures for attendance, local police officials estimate over 50,000 people were present in the area.

But the mood was not of anger with people dressed up in costumes and contingents of tribal workers in traditional attire, performing cultural dances.

A 21-year-old college student from Mumbai, who introduced himself as 'Takshroach', said he was wearing a full cockroach costume. "I came dressed as a bat on October 10. I order these costumes so I get noticed and can convey what I have come for. To believe in the electoral process is extremely important and that faith needs to be restored," he said.

Earlier, around A-Block in the Inner Circle, wearing a bright orange dress Ramayan Singh Rathiya, a worker with the Chhattisgarh Adiwasi Congress, said, "My troop and I, around 200 of us, have come to represent our traditions and our people. We reached Delhi yesterday and have been preparing for the dance for a week."

Just feet away, another group from Gujarat, led by Sunil Chaudhary, also presented a tribal performance. Chaudhary said it was a way of representing their identity at the rally. "This music performance is called Dovdu and using this will bring attention to us so we can be heard. Those who have stolen the votes, must go."

Several participants also spoke of overnight journeys, travel disruptions and the effort involved in reaching the venue.

Jagbir Singh, a farmer from Rohtak in Haryana, said his group had left around 4am on Sunday. They were allegedly stopped at the Kundli border, and the police had installed barricades at the Grand Trunk Road. The group eventually reached the rally venue around 1pm. "Several buses were stopped. We were aware they would do this so we came in a car, but they still stopped us," he said.

Around 500 women from Mahila Congress from Chandrapur city in Maharashtra travelled to Delhi arrived on October 30 by train. "This is the voice of the people. The CEC should be removed from here," said president Chanda Veragde.

Wearing a Batman mask, Pramod Pandey, 45, stood at Minto Road. He is the organising secretary of the West Bengal Pradesh Congress Committee and had come from Kolkata. "My sister-in-law's name was deleted from the voter list," he said when asked for the reason for his participation.

One group, dressed in black, could be seen wearing garlands of cut fingers. "These fingers are symbolic of all those people whose names have been deleted and stolen. The first step towards justice for them would be CEC's resignation," said Aditya.

Protesters also carried a kilometre long list of names of the deleted voters.

Around 1.30pm, Rahul Gandhi and other Congress leaders — sitting in an open mini van — reached the Minto Road- CP junction and headed to the Ramlila Maidan as the crowds followed them. They entered the Ramila Maidan around 3pm, where crowds had been swelling all morning.

Krishna Dubey, a joint secretary of the Chhattisgarh Pradesh Congress, said, "It's a very successful rally. We are glad we came but we are now going back because there is no space to even stand. Rahul Gandhi has shown the country his potential."

People dressed up in costumes and contingents of tribal workers came in traditional attire. REUTERS/PTI

'Orchestrated drama': BJP slams Oppn rally

Ruling party accuses Oppn INDIA bloc of conspiring to push country into anarchy

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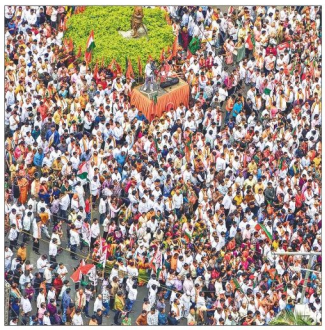
NEW DELHI: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday branded the Opposition INDIA bloc's rally at Ramlila Maidan a "calculated conspiracy" to push the country into anarchy, and countered it with "padyatras" and press conferences across the country. Party leaders also dismissed the turnout, saying large parts of the ground were empty, with Union minister JP Nadda accusing Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi of choosing the anniversary of the 1984 anti-Sikh violence for its show of strength.

Leading the attack, Nadda said, "What is unfolding today at Ramlila Maidan is not an act of respect for democracy; rather, it is a calculated conspiracy to plunge the nation into anarchy, in the name of democracy. This is a foolish, orchestrated drama staged by those who have been defeated and repeatedly rejected by the people."

Targeting Gandhi, the Union minister said the rally had four objectives: "First, to rub salt into the wounds of our Sikh brothers; second, to orchestrate riots and chaos in Delhi in order to topple a democratically elected government; third, to rob the shopkeepers and traders of Delhi of their earnings during the festive season; and fourth, to bring disrepute to the nation."

Nadda also set out what he called the Congress model of politics. "The first stage is spreading lies and rumours; the second is inciting anarchy and chaos on the streets; the third is damaging the nation's economy; and the fourth is attempting to destabilise an elected government at the behest of foreign powers," he said. The Congress has not responded to these charges.

The rally was held against the backdrop of the opposition's campaign against the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. Meanwhile, the date added to the charged mood as November 1 marks the day in 1984 when anti-Sikh violence spread across Delhi after the assassination of then Prime Minister Indira Gandhi. The BJP said it urged the Congress to defer the rally by a day or two.



People participate in a 'Loktantra Bachao Padayatra' organised by the BJP and Mahayuti alliance in Thane on Sunday. PTI

BJP MP Sambit Patra said Union home minister Amit Shah raised the issue on both Saturday and Sunday. "This kind of insensitivity only Rahul Gandhi can show," Patra said at a press conference in New Delhi. He said about 5,000 Sikhs were killed and alleged that voter lists were used to mark Sikh homes. The figure and the allegation are his own, and the Congress was not available for comment on them.

Taking a granular approach, Patra said the party watched the rally from morning and found it "a complete waste of time", then played a video on a screen to dispute the Opposition's claim that the rally was attended by a massive crowd.

He said Ramlila Maidan spans roughly 10 to 12 acres. By his estimate, about 15% is taken by the stage and the enclosure in front of it, and a further 40% was screened off by a tent that he called a "view cutter" and left empty.

"Twenty-eight thousand chairs were laid out in the remaining space," Patra said. He said the video, shot around 3.30 to 4 pm, showed 5,000 to 7,000 of them vacant. "Where were the 10 lakh people? Show us. This is trick photography," he said.

No independent estimate of the Ramlila Maidan turnout was available at the time of print, and the Congress has not yet answered the BJP's specific claims on crowd size.

Patra linked the rally to the SIR debate. "The calculation of the SIR is exactly the same," he said, arguing that the opposition's cry of "vote cut" rests on inflated arithmetic. "The day you sit in the chair and fill Form 6, you too will be counted as a voter," he said. Patra said Kumar took charge only in 2025. "If the 2024 election was illegal, then are all of your own MPs also illegal?" he asked, and challenged the Congress to show one petition in any court challenging the 2024 result.

On PDP chief Mehbooba Mufti's remark that the Centre is trying to turn the whole country into Jammu and Kashmir, Patra said she scored a self goal. "The people have already given their message," he said. On Mamata Banerjee's "kafir" jibe at BJP leaders, he said, "This fight is to protect infiltrators," and added that "only an Indian citizen will be an Indian voter."

On the alliance, Patra said the INDIA bloc is a coalition of many flags with one stick. "Flags are many, stick is one. In the end the flags will go and only the stick will remain," he said, predicting a fight over ticket distribution in Uttar Pradesh. On Modi, he said, "He has the blessings of 140 crore Indians. He is not going anywhere."

The party took its message to the streets as well, holding the 'Loktantra Bachao, Arajakta Hatao' footmarch in several states. Union ministers Bhupendra Yadav and Piyush Goyal and Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma were among the senior BJP leaders held the march in states including Maharashtra and Himachal Pradesh.

Last resort of repeated losers, says Nabin

BJP national president Nitin Nabin framed the rally as the "last resort of repeated electoral losers". "We defeated Congress in Delhi and Haryana. We defeated Akhilesh Yadav in Uttar Pradesh. We defeated RJD in Bihar. We defeated Trinamool Congress in West Bengal," he said. "Today, all these defeated people want to spread anarchy in the country out of their frustration and despair." He cast the rally as a coalition of those who lost at the ballot box rather than a movement of the people.

Nabin was speaking at one of the padyatras in Rohtak of Haryana. He said that instead of seeking atonement and offering an apology for the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, the Congress has come out to protest on the anniversary of the killings in Delhi. In democracy, people's mandate is supreme, said Nabin.

"When they get this people's mandate in Himachal, when they win in Karnataka, then they say democracy has won, but when they lose in Haryana, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and West Bengal, then they say democracy is in danger.

"What kind of dual mentality do you have? This makes one thing clear: they want to run democracy according to the Gandhi family's law, but democracy will run in accordance with the country's constitution," he said.

CONG CONSPIRING WITH FOREIGN POWERS TO IMPOSE LEFT RULE: FADNAVIS

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MUMBAI: Maharashtra chief minister and senior BJP leader Devendra Fadnavis on Sunday accused the Congress and Rahul Gandhi of conspiring with foreign powers, particularly China, to create political anarchy and impose a communist regime in India.

Addressing the Mahayuti's "Loktantra Bachao, Arajakata Hatao" (Save Democracy, Remove Anarchy) rally in Thane, Fadnavis alleged that the Congress was using the Constitution as a shield while discrediting constitutional institutions to pave the way for "China-influenced rule".

"Why is the Congress getting funding from China to spread anarchy in our country," he asked, claiming that the red-covered Constitution displayed by the party was merely a mask and its real intentions were contained in a "red book".

"Using this red book, conspiracies are being hatched to change our Constitution, as they did in Nepal, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka," Fadnavis said.

Accusing the Congress of undermining democracy, Fadnavis cited the Emergency and said, "You accuse us of vote theft, but you have stolen the Constitution itself." He also defended the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls. "The Congress is upset because Bangladeshi infiltrators have been removed from the electoral rolls. We will not allow a single Bangladeshi infiltrator to have voting rights...," he said.

Hitting back at the chief minister, Maharashtra Congress chief Harshwardhan Sapkal accused Fadnavis of making baseless allegations and sought a "proof" of his claims of foreign funding.

Delhi chief minister Rekha Gupta, BJP state chief Harsh Malhotra and other leaders join members of the Sikh Sangat for the protest march from Hari Nagar Bus Depot to Tilak Nagar Metro Station in New Delhi on Sunday. ANI

'1984 violence planned': BJP says Cong should apologise

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NEW DELHI: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday carried out a protest march against the Congress in west Delhi's Hari Nagar, targeting the party over the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, as the INDIA bloc held a rally at Ramlila Maidan in central Delhi against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and alleged irregularities in the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The BJP protest was led by Union petroleum minister Hardeep Puri, who said the violence unleashed in Delhi on November 1, 1984, was not spontaneous anger but a "well-planned massacre". BJP leaders said the Congress should apologise to the Sikh community for choosing such a sensitive date for its political rally.

"There has been a concerted effort to argue that the violence was spontaneous and caused by anger among people. This is not right... The violence started on November 1 but continued for four days. It was a well-planned conspiracy... The Congress should introspect. If they had to select a day for this [protest], should it have been November 1?" Puri said, describing the 1984 violence as "genocide".

THE PROTEST MARCH BEGAN AT HARI NAGAR DEPOT AND CONTINUED FOR A KILOMETRE UP TO TILAK NAGAR METRO STATION

The protest march began at Hari Nagar depot and continued for a kilometre up to Tilak Nagar metro station. Thousands of BJP workers, carrying tricolours and BJP flags, marched through the Sikh-dominated areas with placards blaming the Congress for the 1984 violence. The march also saw the participation of Delhi chief minister Rekha Gupta, cabinet ministers Manjinder Singh Sirsa and Ashish Sood, Delhi BJP chief Harsh Malhotra, and other senior leaders. They raised slogans against the Congress and the Gandhi family, demanding an apology for the killings of Sikhs in 1984.

CM Gupta, wearing a black headband at the protest, recalled how a Sikh neighbour had taken shelter at her parents' home during the violence. "The violence forced lakhs of Sikhs to cut their hair to protect their identities and save themselves... They [Congress] have selected this day for their political aspirations. They are still entangled in the same greed. Rahul Gandhi is also promoting lawlessness to gain power."

Gupta said Congress leaders talk about the Constitution, but the 1984 violence was the murder of the Constitution and democracy.

Delhi BJP chief Malhotra said: "Congress leaders like Sajjan Kumar were directly responsible for the genocide against Sikhs. They even targeted and identified certain houses... The Congress has deliberately chosen this day for its protest. We have reached here in large numbers to pay homage to the martyrs of this genocide."

{ ACROSS SEVEN AIRPORTS }

DigiYatra trials begin for international flyers

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NEW DELHI: Digi Yatra has begun trials for international passengers at seven airports across the country, allowing eligible Indian nationals holding e-passports to use the facility at designated airport touchpoints while travelling on select international flights operated by Air India and IndiGo, the Union government said on Sunday.

The trials, scheduled to run from November to December 2026, are being conducted at Delhi, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Cochin, Mumbai, Chennai and Amritsar airports. Passengers will be able to use the facility at terminal entry points, security hold areas and boarding gates, wherever the required infrastructure is available, the government said in a statement.

HT had reported in September that the government was working to extend Digi Yatra to international departures.

Feedback received during the trial period will inform the planning of a wider rollout in 2027, the government said.

Unlike the domestic Digi Yatra system, which uses Aadhaar-based enrolment, the international facility will use electronic passports to create a digital identity credential. Eligible Indian nationals holding e-passports will have to create an e-passport-based Verifiable Credential (VC) through the Digi Yatra mobile application. The process involves scanning the Machine Readable Zone (MRZ) of the e-passport, reading its embedded chip using the Near Field Communication (NFC) feature of a compatible smartphone, capturing a selfie and verifying the details. The photograph stored in passport chip is used as part of identity verification process.

FEEDBACK RECEIVED DURING THE TRIAL PERIOD WILL INFORM THE PLANNING OF A WIDER ROLLOUT IN 2027, THE GOVERNMENT SAID

The credential is stored in the passenger's Digi Yatra wallet on the device and can be used at airport touchpoints enabled for the trials, the government said.

The initial phase is restricted to departure-side airport processes. Immigration clearance will continue under the existing system, and passengers arriving on international flights will see no change. The facility will complement, not replace, existing travel procedures. Passengers must continue to carry their travel documents and complete all mandatory airline document checks, immigration procedures and other applicable travel formalities, the statement said.

HT had earlier reported that the international expansion would require software upgrades, security assessments and additional technology integration. Officials had said the initial rollout would focus on terminal entry, security and boarding, while integration with immigration would be taken up at a later stage. The ministry of civil aviation's policy document also envisages automated border control at departure and arrival as a subsequent phase.

The international expansion is part of a broader push to digitise air travel. The government has already allowed passengers to use electronic boarding passes at immigration counters, doing away with the requirement to carry physical boarding passes for immigration clearance. Physical boarding passes continue to be issued by airlines.

ODISHA'S PRISONS DG BOOKED OVER JUNIOR'S SEXUAL HARASSMENT

BHUBANESWAR: Odisha's director general of prisons Sushanta Kumar Nath was booked for allegedly sexually harassing a subordinate woman officer and transferred to the Home Department as an officer on special duty (OSD) pending an investigation, officials said on Sunday. His friend, Kudleep Rath, was also named in the case.

A case was registered against the two at Choudwar police station in Cuttack district on October 31 under various provisions of the BNS relating to sexual harassment, criminal intimidation and common intention.

The 41-year-old woman, then a jailor at Choudwar Circle Jail, alleged that Rath repeatedly sent her "suggestive and unwelcome" messages from July 2025, inviting her to meet Nath for dinner. After she declined invitations to a restaurant and a hotel, where Rath claimed the IPS officer "wanted to meet her alone", she was allegedly targeted and falsely implicated in the case involving the escape of two undertrial prisoners from the jail.

Nath, a 1993-batch IPS officer and contender for the state DGP's post, did not respond to calls and messages.

Meanwhile, a parliamentary standing committee has summoned the home secretary and other officials on November 3 over the matter. PTI

DGCA says 2 pilots must from today for Char Dham helicopters, operators object

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NEW DELHI: The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has directed operators conducting Char Dham helicopter charter services to fly with two pilots from Monday and obtain prior destination and enroute clearances for every flight sector.

The instructions, seen by HT, issued following an urgent meeting with helicopter operators on Saturday, a day after a Char Dham helicopter crashed in Jyotirmath in Chamoli district of Uttarakhand, killing five passengers and the pilot of the chopper.

The set of directives mandated a two-pilot configuration for all Char Dham charter flights, with the co-pilot also required to be hill-qualified.

DGCA has also directed that crews obtain positive destination and enroute clearance from the control room at Sahastradhara before taking off for each sector. As per the instructions, they will also have to submit a Pilot Report (PIREP) to the control room after landing at every destination helipad.

The aviation regulater further asked the head of operations of the Uttarakhand Civil Aviation Development Authority (UCADA) to formulate the modalities for providing clearances before each take-off and for receiving, reviewing and maintaining records of all pilot reports.

The directions, however, have prompted operators to threaten a suspension of services from Monday, stating financial implications of the new requirements.

However, helicopter operators collectively objected to the two-pilot directive.

In a letter to DGCA, dated October 31, the operators said: "After due consideration and mutual consultation, all operators collectively express their inability to accept the mandatory twin-pilot requirement in its present form."

"We wish to formally convey that all participating operators are proposing to suspend their Char Dham charter operations with effect from 02 November 2026, until the matter is reviewed and a mutually workable solution is arrived at by the concerned authorities in consultation with the operators," the letter said.

The operators said deploying two pilots on every charter sortie would substantially increase operating costs, crew requirements, accommodation and logistical expenses.

Meanwhile, the bodies of six people killed in the Chamoli crash on Friday were retrieved and handed over to their families after postmortem examinations at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Rishikesh, district disaster management officer NK Joshi said on Sunday.

"They were then airlifted by helicopter to AIIMS Rishikesh for autopsy. After official procedures, their bodies were handed over to their respective families," he added.

(With inputs from Uttarakhand)

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Some souls are simply larger than life,
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You were strength wrapped in elegance,
Courage softened by compassion,
An iron will, a generous heart,
A fierce spirit, an impeccable grace.

You taught us that love lies in the smallest details,
That adversity can be met with dignity,
And that true greatness is measured
By how deeply we touch the lives of others.

Years may pass, but your legacy will never fade.
For you were not just a remarkable woman,
You were a way of being in the world.

..... By Shweta Shroff Chopra

inserted by Shardul S. Shroff & Family

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S. Charanjit Singh Bindra

Your generosity, your compassion, your dynamism, your love, your inspiration will live on in the hearts of all whom you touched....
May God continue to keep you in his loving care.

Fondly remembered by:
Jaspreet Singh Bindra
Harmanjit Kaur Bindra
Meher and Jasmira Bindra

Mahadev case: Promoter brought back from Oman

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NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), along with other agencies, has extradited Sourabh Chandrakar — the mastermind behind the ₹6,000-crore Mahadev online gambling syndicate — from Oman, officials said.

"CBI, in coordination with other central agencies has successfully secured the extradition of Sourabh Chandrakar, the promoter of the Mahadev App illegal betting syndicate, from the Sultanate of Oman. A CBI team specially deputed to Oman, has escorted him back to India. He will now be produced before the CBI special court in Raipur," a CBI spokesperson said in a statement on Sunday.

Chandrakar, in his 30s, was wanted by multiple agencies including Enforcement Directorate (ED) and Chhattisgarh police.

One of the most wanted person in connection with the racket, Chandrakar set-up the Mahadev betting empire along with co-founder Ravi Uppal. The two fled to Dubai sometime in 2019. According to an ED probe, their network still runs betting apps and websites from there.

Based on an Interpol red notice, the UAE authorities briefly detained Chandrakar in October 2024 and kept him under house arrest. The same month, India sent an extradition request for him which was not executed, "thereby making it infructuous".

Sourabh Chandrakar, the 'kingpin' in Mahadev betting app case, flanked by CBI officials after being extradited from Oman. PTI

HT reported on November 4, 2025, that Ravi Uppal had gone missing from the UAE after authorities in the gulf country decided to close extradition proceedings against him. Sometime this year, Chandrakar also managed to flee from UAE to Oman.

Based on the Interpol red notice, he was located in Muscat and detained by Royal Omani police in late June.

"CBI and ED immediately sent formal extradition proposals to the Sultanate of Oman, along with all the evidence gathered against him. The extradition request was pursued in close coordination with the agencies of the Government of India and the Interpol's National Central Bureau (NCB), and with the support of the competent authorities of the Sultanate of Oman. Once the extradition was granted, a CBI team travelled to Muscat and escorted him back to India," said the spokesperson.

CBI, the spokesperson added, "acknowledges with gratitude the cooperation extended by the government of the Sultanate of Oman and the Royal Oman Police, which reflects the close and friendly relations between the two countries and their shared resolve to combat transnational organized crime".

Asserting why Chandrakar's extradition is crucial, an officer said that "several public servants including police officers and politicians who were allegedly bribed by Mahadev promoters are under the scanner in this case".

Former Chhattisgarh chief minister Bhupesh Baghel has also been named by CBI in the case. ED had claimed in one of its charge sheets that Sourabh Chandrakar and Ravi Uppal have paid bribes worth ₹508 crore to Baghel.

The illegal betting operations are still running across India despite the government banning multiple platforms and apps linked to Mahadev, according to officials.

The federal agency said Mahadev app's systematic operation ran locally with the "active support and connivance" of local police and politicians from Chhattisgarh and that "the bureaucrats and politically exposed persons have been receiving illegal gratification for turning a blind eye to this illegal betting racket".

Azam Khan

JAUHAR VARSITY CASE: AZAM KHAN SENT TO 14-DAY JUDICIAL CUSTODY

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LUCKNOW: A special PMLA court in Ghaziabad on Sunday sent former Uttar Pradesh minister and Samajwadi Party (SP) leader Azam Khan to 14 days in judicial custody, a day after the Enforcement Directorate (ED) arrested him in a case linked to the alleged misuse of government funds in the construction of the Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in Rampur.

Khan founded the Jauhar University in 2006.

"We requested the court to grant 14 days of judicial custody, and the court allowed our plea," a senior ED official said, confirming the agency's request and the court's order.

Khan, who walked out of Rampur jail on Saturday after nearly 11 months in custody, was taken directly to Ghaziabad's Dasna jail from the court following the remand order.

ED produced Khan before the special PMLA court amid tight security. Five ED vehicles entered the court premises around 10.30 am, accompanied by nearly 100 security personnel.

Khan appeared calm as he was brought to the court. When he briefly rolled down the window of his car, mediapersons asked whether he had anything to say. "What is left to say?" he replied.

Andhra, TN on alert as another cyclone looms

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AMARAVATI/CHENNAI/BHUBANESWAR: Andhra Pradesh chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Sunday directed officials to remain fully prepared for relief and rescue operations as another cyclone threat loomed over the state, while Tamil Nadu directed district collectors to remain on high alert for heavy to very heavy rainfall over the next three days and Odisha stepped up preparedness in its southern region.

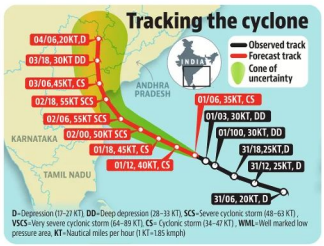
This cyclone has been named 'Murasu' by India, meaning war drum. The previous cyclone to hit the Andhra Pradesh coast, neighbouring Odisha, was Arnab. It had wind speeds up to 150 kmph when it made landfall on October 28.

"Another cyclone is approaching Andhra Pradesh and officials must remain fully prepared to undertake relief and rescue operations, as a severe cyclonic storm is expected to cross the coast near Bapatla on the morning of November 3," Naidu said in a press release.

The system is likely to bring moderate to heavy rainfall, with isolated extremely heavy showers, over south and central coastal districts on November 2. Several areas may receive heavy to very heavy rainfall on November 3 and 4, with wind speeds of up to 110 kmph expected during landfall.

Of the 20 mandals forecast to receive extremely heavy rainfall, nine are in Eluru district, five each in Krishna and NTR districts and one in Bapatla.

Preliminary estimates indicate that strong winds could damage around 15,128 electricity poles across 12 districts.



Naidu directed officials to keep adequate manpower and equipment ready for relief and rescue operations and shift necessary personnel and materials to vulnerable areas in advance.

In Tamil Nadu, the additional chief secretary and commissioner of revenue administration has instructed the district collectors to mobilise all administrative machinery and take adequate preparedness measures. Authorities have also been asked to maintain strict vigilance and immediately report any untoward incident to the State Emergency Operations Centre.

On November 1, heavy to very heavy rain is likely at isolated places in Tiruvallur district, while heavy rain is expected at isolated places in Chennai, Chengalpattu, Kancheepuram, Ranipet and the Nilgiris.

On November 2, heavy to very heavy rainfall is forecast at isolated places in Chennai and Tiruvallur, with heavy rain continuing in Chengalpattu, Kancheepuram, Ranipet, Vellore and the Nilgiris.

Odisha disaster management Minister Suresh Pujari said the government was fully prepared to tackle the impending cyclone and assured people not to panic.

The state has already sounded a high alert in the southern region, including Ganjam, which was severely hit by Cyclone Arnab, he said, adding orders have been issued to evacuate people from low-lying areas and hilly terrain before Murasu makes landfall.

Odisha cyclone toll at 6

Meanwhile, the death toll in Odisha due to Cyclone Arnab rose to six on Sunday with the recovery of two more bodies from a landslide-hit village on the border of Ganjam and Kandhamal districts, while search was underway for 10 missing people, officials said. Home to around 26 people, the hilltop Gidipabali village disappeared from the map after huge amount of sludge and debris cascaded down the hills and levelled houses.

The accused, Hemanth

ANDHRA CHAINSAW ATTACK ACCUSED TRIES TO ESCAPE CUSTODY, SHOT

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HYDERABAD: The 21-year-old man who allegedly attacked two Class 10 girls with a chainsaw at a school in Andhra Pradesh's Anantapur district was shot on Sunday as he tried to escape police custody, an officer familiar with the matter said, adding that the man is critically injured.

An officer from Anantapur police headquarters told HT the accused, Hemanth alias Dummu, was picked up in Atmakur forest area of the district in the evening. "When the police were bringing him to Raptadu mandal to reconstruct the scene of the offence he had committed at the school, he tried to escape and started hurling stones at the police personnel. Several police personnel sustained injuries in the attack, when they tried to overpower him," he claimed.

As the situation escalated, police officers said they fired at Hemanth in self-defence.

"The police fired six rounds at him, leaving him seriously injured," he said, adding that he was shifted to a hospital for treatment.

The attack occurred at around 10.30am on Saturday in the Zilla Parishad High School when Hemanth entered the premises carrying a chainsaw and attacked the student. Meanwhile, state education and IT minister Nara Lokesh said the 15-year-old girl, who is undergoing treatment at Manipal Hospital in Bengaluru, continues to be in a critical condition. "The next 48 hours will be critical," Lokesh told reporters.

Don't cover up court failures by freeing convicts, SC tells courts

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has cautioned courts against suspending the sentences of people convicted of heinous offences merely because their appeals are unlikely to be heard in the near future, holding that the judiciary's inability to decide cases quickly cannot become a reason to set convicted criminals free because such an approach puts the "life of civil society at peril" and exposes the "fault lines" of the judicial system.

A bench of justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran said that courts must exercise greater circumspection while considering bail pleas after conviction, balancing the liberty of an individual against the actual period of incarceration and the sentiments of the victim's family.

"The courts should be sensitive to the sentiments of the victims' family too while being concerned with the liberty of an individual, especially when the accused stands convicted by a court of law, no longer being a enabled the presumption of innocence," held the bench in its October 27 order.

The court held that such an approach puts the "life of civil society at peril". HT

The court added that the burden of judicial pendency was ultimately borne more by citizens than by courts, and that the judiciary could not cover up its institutional shortcomings by releasing those convicted of grave crimes.

"Whatever be the reason for the pendency of cases, the courts cannot be complacent and release criminals convicted for heinous offences, especially when they have not undergone sentence for any considerable period, since it puts to peril the life of the civil society; exposing the fault lines of the system, which we definitely cannot cover up but should always endeavour to overcome," it emphasised.

In laying down the considerations that must guide courts in such matters, the bench said that the decision to suspend a sentence cannot be a "knee-jerk reaction" to the pendency of appeals. Courts must first undertake a prima facie examination of the evidence, and where that evidence is compelling, weigh the period of incarceration already undergone against the reality of delays in the appellate process, it added.

The observations came while setting aside suspension of sentence granted to a man convicted of masterminding the 2017 murder of a candidate contesting a sarpanch election in Rajasthan, allegedly over political rivalry.

Bodies of 2 Kuki men found after 5 days

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IMPHAL: Security forces on Sunday recovered the mutilated bodies of two Kuki men, missing since October 28, from a hilly stretch in Kangpokpi district of Manipur, police said.

According to police, the two men, identified as Paoginlal hangshing (20) and Tinginlun Chongloi (21), went missing at around 5.30 pm on October 28 after allegedly being abducted by unidentified miscreants while they were travelling between Hengbung and Taphou Kuki village in the district. Their bodies were found in a general area of Senapati-Phaibung (SP) road on Sunday morning.

"In continuation of these operations, an extensive joint search operation was conducted today, i.e., 1 November 2026, by joint teams comprising Manipur Police, CoBRA, CRPF, Assam Rifles and RAF in the general area east of NH-2, along the SP Road and recovered the bodies," police said in a statement.

ACCORDING TO POLICE, THE TWO MEN WENT MISSING ON OCTOBER 28 AFTER ALLEGEDLY BEING ABDUCTED BY UNIDENTIFIED MISCREANTS

Police said extensive search and combing operations will continue in the area to apprehend those responsible.

This comes after three Kuki individuals were killed during an exchange of gunfight between two armed groups on Saturday at Kekru Naga village under Nungba police station in Manipur's Noney district.

The Committee on Tribal Unity (CoTU) has been protesting against the missing of the two men by imposing total shutdown across Kangpokpi district since October 29.

They alleged the men were abducted by members of the Naga community.

The recovery of bodies sparked tension in Kangpokpi as an irate mob confronted with police at the superintendent of police's office.

Placing five charters of demands, the CoTU refused to accept the bodies until those demands are fulfilled.

On Saturday, the committee extended the total shutdown by 24 hours, urging deputy chief minister Losii Dikho to convince Naga members, who allegedly abducted the men, for their safe release.

Alleging that the deputy CM failed to convince the Naga people, CoTU spokesperson Ng Lun Kipgen on Sunday demanded Dikho's removal from the cabinet.

The Kuki body also asked for immediate rectification of police jurisdiction by transferring Taphou Kuki village from Senapati police jurisdiction to Kangpokpi; removal of the NSCN-IM's Huthrong Brigade from its Oklong Camp in Senapati; immediate handing over of the case to the National Investigation Agency (NIA); and immediate arrest of those involved in the abduction and killing.

'SC, HCs not competing destinations for justice'

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Sunday said the Supreme Court and high courts were not "competing destinations for justice", stressing the need to strengthen public confidence in high courts as the first forum for constitutional remedies.

Addressing the Kerala High Court's platinum jubilee celebrations in Kochi, the CJI highlighted the significance of Article 226, which empowers high courts to issue directions for enforcement of fundamental and other legal rights.

"The difference between justice and injustice lies not in the final judgment, but in whether the court intervenes when intervention is most needed," he said.

CJI Surya Kant described the Supreme Court and high courts as constitutional partners with complementary responsibilities, adding that constitutional justice did not begin and end in New Delhi but rested on a robust network of 25 high courts across India.

The CJI also praised Kerala's contribution to women's representation in the judiciary, citing Anna Chandy, the country's first woman High Court judge, and M Fathima Beevi, the first woman Supreme Court judge.

TN WITHDRAWS 65 ANTI-NEET PROTEST CASES AGAINST 1,800

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CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu government has issued an order to drop 65 criminal cases registered against over 1,000 citizens who participated in protests seeking the abolition of the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) soon after the ruling TVK assumed office on May 10 this year.

A total of 65 criminal cases were registered across police stations against 1,800 individuals who took part in the protests held between May 10 to July 31.

The government, as per instructions of CM, has issued an order immediately to take appropriate legal steps to withdraw 65 criminal cases against approximately over 1,800 who took part in anti-NEET protests, an October 31 statement said.

B'luru hotel electrocution: Cops say pool lights being examined

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BENGALURU: Investigators are examining an underwater swimming pool lighting failure in connection with the death of two European guests due to electrocution at a Bengaluru hotel, officials familiar with the matter said.

The Karnataka State Electrical Inspectorate is examining a switch-mode power supply (SMPS) device that may have allowed electricity to leak into the water, an official said. "This unit converts high-voltage alternating current (AC) into low-voltage direct current (DC) used by underwater LED lights. A failure in the unit or its wiring connections could have allowed current to escape into the pool," the official, who spoke on conditions of anonymity, said.

A case of death by negligence has been registered. REUTERS

Alexander Maximilian Theiss, 52, a German national and Lufthansa crew member who was in the city on a layover, and Juraj Horvat, 45, a Slovak national who worked as a project manager with IBM in Bengaluru, died on Friday evening at Bengaluru's Conrad hotel when someone switched on the lights. Two persons, Matthew DeSantis, 41, a US national staying at the hotel, and pool attendant Rahul Tiwari, 28, were injured while trying to rescue them.

In a complaint to the police, Silvia Hotuatova, Horvat's wife, alleged negligence by the hotel management. She said Horvat entered the swimming pool at about 5.15 pm on Friday. After hearing screams, she rushed towards the pool and found her husband motionless in the water. A hotel employee who entered the pool to rescue him also suffered an electric shock, she said in the complaint.

Halasuru police have registered a case of death by negligence under BNS Section 106 against the hotel management. The hotel has closed the pool pending the investigation.

{ GREENPIECE }

LULA'S BRAZIL WIN GOOD FOR GREEN GOALS OF INDIA

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NEW DELHI: Brazilian President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva's dramatic re-election carries good news for India's environmental goals. His victory is certainly welcome, given his commitment to protecting the Amazon rainforest, which has already been damaged. However, locally elected representatives continue to push for its destruction to make way for ranches and mining activities. How this challenge will be addressed is another story, one that will require considerable political manoeuvring and a fair amount of luck. Nevertheless, protecting the Amazon and restoring its lost forest cover would be a gift to a climate-ravaged world. As we know, it acts as carbon sink, absorbing around 5% of global carbon emissions. It is a treasure trove of biodiversity and a giant reservoir of freshwater.

Yet, from India's perspective, there is more at stake. Brazil can strengthen our efforts to combat climate change, given that it holds some of the world's largest reserves of critical minerals. These include niobium, used to strengthen steel, and lithium, which, as we know, is vital for electric mobility. India, like many other countries, has struggled to build partnerships beyond China for access to critical minerals. Lula stands out for his commitment to institutional leadership from the Global South and greater South-South cooperation. This commitment also stems, in part, from his belief in inclusion for all.

India already has a trade agreement with Brazil, but a newer one, aligned with our own vision, is vital. We must join hands with our allies swiftly to fight for a more stable planet for everyone.

(The writer is the founder and director of Chintan Environmental Research and Action Groups)

Entire staff shunted after rape of woman in J'khand police station

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RANCHI: The entire staff at the Gamharia police station in Seraikela Kharsawan district of Jharkhand was suspended on Sunday after a woman was allegedly raped on the police station premises, a senior police officer said.

The incident took place on October 29 when the woman had reached the police station to lodge a complaint after an altercation with her husband. She was asked to wait inside a room at the station, where a wireless operator allegedly raped her, the officer said.

Following the incident, six officers attached to the police station were suspended on Saturday. On Sunday, the remaining staff, including two Sub-Inspectors (SIs), four Assistant Sub-Inspectors (ASIs), two Havildars (Head Constables), and one Constable were suspended in connection with the probe into the incident, the officer said.

INCIDENT TOOK PLACE ON OCT 29 WHEN A WOMAN HAD REACHED GAMHARIA POLICE STATION TO LODGE COMPLAINT AFTER AN ALTERCATION WITH HUSBAND

A special investigation team (SIT) was formed the day after the incident on the orders of Seraikela-Kharsawan Superintendent of Police (SP) Manoj Swargiary to probe the incident.

While the main accused was arrested on Saturday, the officer on duty and the station clerk have also been arrested in the case, the officer added. All three have been sent to jail, he said.

In her complaint, the woman told the police that she had an altercation with her husband on Thursday and left home, fearing that she would be beaten up.

The woman went to a neighbour's house and contacted police using her mobile phone. A PCR van arrived at the house and brought her to the police station that night, police said in a statement. The officers on duty provided her with a room in the police station to rest where the crime took place.

Director General of Police Tadasha Mishra and state home secretary Vandana Dadel could not be reached for comment.

CBSE collected ₹16.47 crore from students in post-Class 12 result processes: RTI data

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NEW DELHI: The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) collected ₹16.47 crore (unaudited) from students seeking scanned copies of evaluated Class 12 answer books, verification of marks and reevaluation after its 2026 board examinations, according to an October 14 reply to a Right to Information (RTI) application filed by HT on August 22.

The board said its finance division had not received any "sanction order" for payment to its on-screen marking (OSM) vendor, Coempt Edu Teck, for scanning Class 12 answer books, and that the finance section had no information on penalties imposed on the company.

CBSE PROMISED FULL REFUND IF MARKS INCREASED ON REEVALUATION. HOWEVER, MANY STUDENTS TOLD HT THEY DID NOT GET REFUND DESPITE IT

CBSE disclosed ₹3.57 crore (unaudited) in refunds to candidates whose marks increased following reevaluation, equivalent to 21.68% of the combined collections. However, it did not disclose the number of beneficiaries, the total number of unique students who applied for the three services or subject-wise changes in marks. Several students told HT they received no refund despite an increase in their marks.

CBSE did not respond to HT's queries seeking clarification on the figures, refunds, vendor payments and penalties.

"OSM evaluation and re-evaluation was a big mess. I have never seen so much chaos in my decades of experience as a teacher and a school administrator," said a principal of a CBSE-affiliated school in Gurugram, requesting anonymity. One student who usually topped a subject saw his marks rise by 30 after reevaluation, the principal said, adding that delays cost several students opportunities to apply to foreign universities.

CBSE conducted its Class 12 examinations from February 17 to April 10 and declared results on May 13, with the pass percentage falling to 85.20% from 88.39% in 2025. Amid concerns over OSM, the board on May 17 reduced fees for scanned answer books from ₹700 to ₹100 per subject, verification of marks from ₹500 to ₹100, and reevaluation from ₹100 to ₹25 per question. It also promised full refund if a candidate's marks increased following reevaluation.

Students could apply for scanned copies from May 19 to 26, while the portal for verification and reevaluation remained open from June 1 to 7.

In its October 14 reply, CBSE disclosed ₹11.37 crore (unaudited) in collections from scanned-copy requests and ₹5.10 crore (unaudited) under the combined category of verification and reevaluation.

LCA Mk-1A, stealth fighter highest priority in IAF chief's 'VAYU' vision

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NEW DELHI: India's new chief of the air staff, Air Chief Marshal Ashutosh Dixit, on Sunday outlined the Indian Air Force's top priorities, placing the indigenous Tejas light combat aircraft (LCA Mk-1A), expected to enter service shortly, alongside the LCA Mk-2 and advanced medium combat aircraft (AMCA) programmes at the forefront of its modernisation drive.

Restoring the IAF's combat strength through a renewed push for indigenisation will be his "foremost task," Dixit said, as the air force grapples with a critical shortage of fighter aircraft.

In his first public comments after taking over as the 29th IAF chief, Dixit said, "The Tejas Mk-1A and Mk-2, AMCA (a fifth-generation stealth fighter jet), and Indian weapons and sensors are our highest priority. We will fight with Indian solutions, and we will hold them in numbers that meet our operational demands. Our responsibility is to fight and win, but most importantly it is to deter conflict through credible air power."

Air Chief Marshal Ashutosh Dixit, left, is greeted by Vice Chief of the Air Staff (VCAS) Air Marshal Inderpal Singh Walia and others during a Guard of Honour ceremony in New Delhi on Sunday. PTI

Dixit, an experimental test pilot and a qualified flying instructor, took over as IAF chief from Air Chief Marshal AP Singh on Saturday. He outlined his vision for the IAF's future using the acronym "VAYU": V for vigilance and readiness, A for atmanirbharta (self-reliance), Y for yukti (ingenuity) and U for unity of effort.

The IAF chief underscored the importance of vigilance and combat readiness. "Every squadron, every radar, every air defence unit along with each and every air warrior must be ready to respond at a moment's notice. Restoring our combat strength towards the sanctioned level will be my foremost task." The IAF is counting on the timely induction of new aircraft, including the LCA Mk-1A and 114 additional Rafales, to shore up its fighter fleet and keep the combat squadron numbers from falling below 30 compared to a sanctioned 42.5.

Ingenuity is key, he said.

"Innovation in doctrine, procedures and technology; networked, AI-enabled command and control; layered counter-drone defence; responsive maintenance; force protection; and the use of near-space as an operational domain for the IAF are areas which will be constantly monitored," he said.

On unity of effort, he said IAF will plan and fight as one along with the army, navy and other national agencies. "Air power delivers most when it is integrated from the very first plan."

Dixit's appointment comes at a pivotal moment as the armed forces advance theaterisation, a long-awaited reform designed to integrate the military's resources for future conflicts.

India's security environment remains demanding, even as new technologies and systems—including drones, long-range precision weapons, space and cyber capabilities, and artificial intelligence—are reshaping the character of warfare, he said.

Operation Sindoor, the four-day military confrontation with Pakistan following the Pahalgam terror strike last year, showcased what precise and decisive air power can achieve, Dixit added.

Operationalising LCA Mk-1A will be his immediate priority.

It is finally nearing induction into the IAF after missing several deadlines. It will be the first aircraft to enter service under his watch by year-end. The LCA Mk-1A will replace the IAF's workhorse MiG-21s, which retired last year after more than six decades of service. The IAF has placed two orders with Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) for 180 Mk-1A fighter jets worth a combined ₹1.1 lakh crore.

He will also have to speed up LCA Mk-2 and AMCA.

The more advanced LCA Mk-2 programme is gathering momentum. HAL has built the structure and coupling has been completed — the front, centre and rear fuselage sections have been joined, and the airframe is ready. HAL is targeting the first ground run by March 2027, with the maiden flight expected later that year. The IAF will now be moving a case for the LCA Mk-2 procurement. It will replace the Mirage 2000s, MiG-29s and Jaguars.

Speeding up the AMCA programme is critical because China has already deployed the J-20 fifth-generation fighters, and it is rolling out the J-35 stealth fighters.

'America's retreat from global role is likely to outlast Trump'

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NEW DELHI: US Secretary of State Marco Rubio's recent visit to India came at a moment of uncertainty about the future of US-India relations—and the wider international order. As New Delhi carefully navigates ties with Washington, Beijing, and Moscow, how can it preserve its freedom of action while advancing its interests? And does India have the capabilities to match its global ambitions?

Ambassador Pankaj Saran addressed these and other questions on a recent episode of "Grand Tamasha," a weekly podcast on Indian politics and policy co-produced by HT and the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace.

Saran is a former diplomat with forty years of experience in foreign policy, strategic affairs, and national security. From 2018 to 2021, he served as India's Deputy National Security Adviser for Strategic Affairs. He also served as India's Ambassador to Russia and India's High Commissioner to Bangladesh. Saran is currently Convenor of NatStrat, a Delhi-based independent centre for research on strategic and security issues.

Saran spoke with host Milan Vaishnav about the significance of Rubio's visit, the structural shifts in America's strategic orientation, and what the West misunderstands about Brics.

"I think it's a very interesting move by Rubio to come back to India the second time this year, especially because... it was preceded by a lot of chatter and points of friction in the India-US relationship," said Saran. "I think this time he has been more forthcoming about the American commitment to the relationship than he was a few months ago in India, and I think it has helped a lot to address some of the concerns." Saran called the visit "a good balm to soothe raw nerves."

> AMBASSADOR PANKAJ SARAN SAID THAT BRICS WILL CONTINUE BECAUSE ITS MEMBERS SHARE A DESIRE FOR 'AN EQUAL PLACE IN THE WORLD ORDER'

GRAND TAMASHA

Saran added that many of the shifts in US foreign policy under President Donald Trump are likely to persist beyond his tenure. "Trump reflects more a symptom of the internal changes within American society rather than a symbol of those changes. He has been thrown up because of certain structural, fundamental changes and adjustments going on within American society," Saran said.

"For American policy overseas, there seems to be an irreversible trend to pursue a less internationalist, more inward-looking approach to regroup American power, to cut your losses or to retrench from an overstretched American global footprint."

He added that these shifts also shape America's dealings with its friends and partners, and that many of them predate Trump. "This is a long-term trend that Trump has exaggerated," explained Saran.

Saran also discussed India's participation in the Brics grouping, an entity he believes the West does not fully understand. "If you see it at a minimal level, it has a set of countries which are non-Western...It is a reminder that there is a whole section of humanity which is not the West," he said. "While each one of them has significant relationships with individual Western countries or the Western world, there is something which brings them all together." Saran said this collaboration continues despite the disputes between India and China and the fact that the Brics economies are not always complementary. The Brics will continue, he argued, because its members share a desire for "an equal place in the world order."

LISTEN: Scan the QR code to listen to the full episode.

Four die after inhaling toxic gas at Ujjain hotel

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BHOPAL: Four workers died of suspected suffocation while cleaning an overground waste chamber at a hotel in Ujjain district of Madhya Pradesh on Sunday, police said, adding three others who entered the chamber to rescue them also fell ill and were taken to a hospital.

Ujjain superintendent of police Pradeep Sharma said the incident took place on Saturday night at Shri Ganga Hotel. "After receiving information about the incident, a team from Madhav Nagar police station rushed to the spot and launched a rescue operation. The workers went into the chamber one after another apparently to clean it but got trapped," Sharma said, adding the workers collapsed on a slippery surface after inhaling toxic gas.

The deceased were identified as Kamlesh Tamboli, Nitin Valmik, Manoj Meena and Wahid. Their bodies have been sent for post-mortem examination, officers said, adding that a probe has been launched into the incident.

Chief minister Mohan Yadav expressed grief over the deaths of the four people and announced financial assistance of ₹4 lakh each to the families of the deceased.

Police station in-charge Gajendra Pachoriya said rescuers had to use a cutting machine to open the chamber door. "The four were pulled out after a nearly 90-minute rescue operation. Police personnel administered CPR to revive them, but none survived," Pachoriya said.

2 Punjab AAP MLAs quit party ahead of polls, set to join BJP

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PATIALA: Two Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) legislators in Punjab resigned from the party's membership on Sunday, a day after the party announced its first list of 40 candidates for the 2027 assembly elections, people familiar with the matter said.

Harmeet Singh Pathanmajra, MLA from Sanaur in Patiala district, sent his resignation letter to AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal, saying he was quitting with immediate effect without specifying any reason, while former minister Chetan Singh Jouramajra, who represented Samana in Patiala, announced his exit from the party on social media.

The AAP has not yet declared its candidates for the two seats.

Harmeet Pathanmajra (L) and Chetan Jouramajra

Meanwhile, Pathanmajra said he and Jouramajra will join the Bhartiya Janata Party (BJP) on Monday. "It's a national party and after the party forms a government in the state it will reap huge benefits. Drugs will be eradicated, as home minister Amit Shah Ji has already announced," he said.

The development has brought into focus growing discontent within the AAP, especially over the leadership's handling of constituency-level appointments and political decisions, people cited in the first place said. The party recently appointed new constituency in-charges in both segments, signalling a possible change in its electoral strategy.

After quitting AAP, the two leaders attacked the party's Delhi leadership, of influencing Punjab's governance and failing to deliver on the promise of a drug-free state.

Punjab AAP chief Aman Arora said, "The party had never hesitated in acting against leaders involved in corruption or working against Punjab's interest."

Senior BJP leader Ravneet Singh Bittu also took a dig at AAP. "The picture has just begun," Bittu said in a post on X in Hindi, hinting at the possibility of more such developments.

Bengal CM promises citizenship to 250K B'desh refugees

KOLKATA: West Bengal chief minister Suvendu Adhikari on Sunday announced that 250,000 members of the Dalit Matua community, who came to India from Bangladesh as refugees, will be issued citizenship certificates under Citizenship Amendment Act by year end and enrolled as voters in fresh enumeration starting in January 2027.

TN min says he was offered ₹5cr bribe, BJP asks why no case yet

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu minister A Rajmohan on Sunday sparked a row after he said at an event on Sunday, that he was offered ₹5 crore for the post in the state government run Tamil Nadu Eyal Isai Nataka Manram. TN BJP leader Narayanan Thirupathy slammed the minister, asking why a case has not been registered in the matter.

2 killed as fire engine bursts into flames after collision in Raj

JAIPUR/UDAIPUR: Two firefighters were killed after a fire engine caught fire after a collision with a trailer on National Highway 48 in Udaipur district on Sunday. The fire engine's driver and the trailer driver were seriously injured, police said, adding that the accident took place near Makadjapa village, in Rishabhdev police station area, around 11 am.

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HT Talks Hosts Insightful Discussion on Empowering Students to Become Vigilant Citizens

HT PACE hosted an insightful edition of HT Talks on 'Empowering Students to Become Vigilant Citizens', bringing together educationists and experts to discuss the importance of nurturing awareness, critical thinking and social responsibility among students. Moderated by Bhawana Gariya, Editorial Interface, Hindustan Times, the session featured Shekhar Dutt, Co-founder, Sleepy Classes IAS; Sudhanshu Shekhar, Principal, K. L. International School, Meerut; Rishi Pal Chauhan, Founder-Director, Jiva Group and innovator of the Jiva Learning System; and Dr. H. S. Vashisht, Principal, Delhi Public School, Noida.

Vigilance Begins with Awareness and Critical Thinking

Shekhar Dutt emphasised that vigilance is about awareness rather than suspicion. He encouraged students to notice everyday issues such as littering and bullying and develop the courage to respond with compassion. Highlighting the influence of adults, he described children as both sponges and mirrors who absorb and reflect the behaviour they observe. He also cautioned against emotional manipulation on social media, where selective information and propaganda can distort understanding. Stressing the importance of context and verification, he urged students to recognise partial truths and question what they consume. He added that stereotypes related to caste, religion, gender and success are often absorbed from families and surroundings, making it essential for adults to model honesty, respect and integrity.

Encouraging Independent Thinking and Responsible Citizenship

Sudhanshu Shekhar highlighted the importance of digital literacy through the principle of 'Stop, Check and Share', urging students to verify the source, date and context of information before forwarding it. He advocated creating classrooms where students can question policies, express disagreements respectfully and develop evidence-based opinions. According to him, schools must teach children how to think rather than what to think. He also distinguished political neutrality from silence, explaining that students should understand constitutional rights, duties, public policies and accountability without being influenced by partisan views. Parents and teachers, he added, must lead by example, as children learn values more from everyday actions than words.

Creating Change-makers Through Experiential Learning

Rishi Pal Chauhan stressed that education must move beyond marks towards meaningful learning connected with everyday life. He encouraged students to identify problems such as pollution, water wastage, traffic and inequality, and take small steps towards addressing them. Introducing the Jiva philosophy of 'Self, Others and Environment', he highlighted self-reflection, community initiatives and experiential learning as tools for developing responsibility. He also advocated constructive dialogue over hostile debates, suggesting that schools create spaces where students can understand different perspectives and work towards practical solutions. He underlined that freedom of expression must be accompanied by self-awareness and sensitivity towards others.

Building Responsible Citizens Through Everyday Actions

Dr. H. S. Vashisht observed that citizenship involves responsibilities towards one's neighbourhood, school, society and country, not merely individual rights. Respecting rules, protecting public property, maintaining cleanliness and helping others are everyday ways of practising responsible citizenship. He urged schools not to avoid difficult conversations about social unrest and protests, but to provide students with balanced information and a safe space to examine different viewpoints. Emphasising fairness and factuality, he encouraged young people to question information, respect differences and speak against injustice with courage and consideration.

The discussion brought out a common understanding that vigilant citizenship cannot be developed through textbooks or academic instruction alone. It requires a sustained effort by schools, parents and society to nurture critical thinking, empathy, integrity and a sense of responsibility among young people. From questioning information and challenging stereotypes to respecting differences and standing up against injustice, the panellists highlighted that meaningful citizenship is reflected in everyday choices and actions. The panellists collectively emphasised that education must prepare students not only for examinations and careers but also to become informed individuals who contribute thoughtfully to society.

The Hindustan Times
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{ OUR TAKE }

A boost for Oppn but big test ahead

The INDIA bloc managed massive mobilisation with the protest against the CEC. Whether this impacts 2027 state poll results remains to be seen

The INDIA bloc's mega show of strength in the Capital, against chief election commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar is the parliamentary Opposition's biggest mobilisation of force in recent years. It underlines how the chaos triggered by the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls has diminished the moral standing of the Election Commission of India (ECI). But the longevity of the movement and possible electoral dividends will only be determined next year in the five-state assembly elections, which present familiar challenges to both the incumbent and the Opposition.

The current moment is different from both the July protests against examination paper leaks and the initial waves of the current stir, which was then dominated by unaffiliated student groups and the Cockroach Janta Party, and is now currently led by the formal Opposition. This is also reflected in the administrative response, which was initially heavy handed that led to Delhi being cloaked in a virtual security blanket and the denotification of Jantar Mantar as a protest site. There is little doubt that the constantly changing and controversial rules under SIR, the media reports indicating disagreements within ECI, and the hardships suffered by common people — eased only after belated course correction by the poll body — contributed to the sustenance of the agitation. But whether it carries similar resonance for the ordinary citizen, who was legitimately concerned about her job prospects and the fidelity of the exam system earlier this summer, remains to be seen.

For the Opposition, the protest brought forth hitherto unprecedented scenes of leaders from diverse and often conflicting political trajectories sharing a common stage and issuing a unified appeal. The successful showing will boost the organisational wings of the INDIA bloc, which has struggled to project unity and hold joint events in the past. But the BJP — which holds that the stir lacks both legitimacy and popular support — must feel confident given its electoral performance in major states since the 2024 Lok Sabha polls. In that sense, the Opposition may have passed one big test in Delhi on Sunday — that of mobilisation, dominating the political stage, and stamping its leadership on the protest — but a bigger one looms in the form of the five-state elections next year. In key states such as Uttar Pradesh and Punjab, the Opposition will need to curb infighting, hit the ground running, and work on the nuts-and-bolts of electioneering if it hopes to translate street protests into formal democratic representation.

The crisis in Poland has a simple lesson

Quis judicabit ipsos judices? This Latin maxim is supposed to be about the accountability of the judiciary, but it hides a deeper, more mundane message within: the inevitable clash between those who govern and those who judge. Poland's constitutional crisis has brought the latter meaning into focus. On Friday, Polish police cordoned off the Constitutional Tribunal as chief justice Bogdan Święczkowski and his deputy, Bartlomiej Sochanski, stood suspended. President Karol Nawrocki, quite dramatically, turned his plane around and called it a coup. Both camps, ironically, claim to defend the rule of law. The suspended chief justice is an appointee of PiS, Prawo i Sprawiedliwość (Law and Justice), Poland's right-wing populist, national-conservative political party. He is accused by Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk of using his powers to block parliament from electing new judges. This is not a new grievance against the far-Right centres of power that Tusk replaced. But can redressal be the very thing it condemns? Suspending a court's head by the declaration of one faction of judges, with police at the doors, is force — quite the opposite of restored legality.

PiS governed the country between 2015 and 2023 and remains quite influential as the opposition. The president is seen to be closer to the PiS than to Tusk's centrist government and refused to administer the oath of office to five of the eight parliament-elected judges of the tribunal. The situation in Poland is a multifaceted constitutional crisis. The EU, in 2021, accused the tribunal of miscarriage of justice due to an inappropriately appointed judge's involvement. The crisis in Poland holds a simple lesson: Courts are not trophies. Poland has spent a decade showing what happens when they are treated as one.

{ GRAND STRATEGY }
Happymon Jacob

Pakistan's year of pacts and India's long game

A State can only build lasting influence based on what others need from it over time, not immediately. And India is building that influence, even if unevenly

On October 21, the defence ministers of Pakistan, Turkey, Qatar, and Indonesia signed the Badr Memorandum of Understanding, a project to jointly develop defence equipment. It caps a year of several geopolitically important moments for Islamabad. Recall that in August this year, Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Turkey signed the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement, which treats an armed attack on one as an attack on all three, even if, so far, only on paper. And last week, the Maldivian President spent three days in Islamabad, the first visit to Pakistan by a head of State of the island-nation in 11 years. Further, Pakistan and its army chief, Asim Munir, continue to be US President Donald Trump's favourites.

It would seem, then, Pakistan is doing extremely well geopolitically, and India is on the back foot. But that may be a short-sighted take.

To be fair, let me acknowledge the obvious first. These agreements do carry some geopolitical weight. The Mecca pact has already moved beyond the signing ceremony: The three countries have agreed to activate deterrence measures and deploy forces to Saudi Arabia against the Houthi attacks, and Turkey has sent the pact to its Parliament for ratification. The symbolism of the pact, too, has its uses — for signalling relevance, drawing in money, and, surely, complicating India's planning and preparedness. The next time there is a crisis on the Line of Control, New Delhi will have to account for the Saudi treaty commitment to Pakistan that did not exist two years ago. Saudis may or may not come to Islamabad's aid, but that's not the point. The point is that New Delhi can't afford to ignore it. In that sense, the treaty makes the unlikely less unlikely.

And yet, it is important to ask what exactly gives Pakistan the ability to get what it does from time to time. The answer is its geographical location. Located at the intersection of South Asia, West Asia, and Central Asia, with a large army and a nuclear arsenal, it does have some utility for its partners — at least, on the face of things. So, when the US is at war with Iran and Gulf monarchies are under fire, Pakistan's stock has risen. In other words, Pakistan's real value is also a function of other people's crises, and, therefore, it falls when those crises end.

Pakistan has had moments of geopolitical relevance like this before. In the 1950s, for instance, it joined SEATO and the Baghdad Pact when India decided to stay non-aligned; three decades later, the war against the Soviet Union in Afghanistan brought it American money and arms (as well as social rupture within Pakistan); it became an important part of America's war on terror after 9/11. To be clear, Pakistan's stocks rose when the region was not in peace. Very little of such opportunities was converted into building an economy at home, though. Pakistan has never been able to become — or even seen as — an important stabilising power in the region because it rides on the back of chaos, not prosperity. In a peaceful world, Pakistan's geopolitical importance diminishes.

This is where Pakistan's contrast with India becomes sharper, and it must be noted by those in India who feel uneasy about what Pakistan has been able to supposedly achieve. India has been doing things more slowly, thoughtfully, and more consequentially. Let me highlight three features.

The first is the time horizon. India's major engagements of the past two years, to take a similar time frame, are investments meant to mature over a decade or more. Trade agreements take years to create dividends, defence co-production takes longer still, and minilaterals take time to identify areas of mutual interest and work on them. None of them produces dramatic photographs or moments or the attention received by, say, the Mecca agreement.

The second feature is the choice of

The signing of the Badr Memorandum of Understanding capped a year of several geopolitically important moments for Islamabad. REUTERS

India's partners. India's FTAs are with the UK, New Zealand, the EU, Australia, and the US, among others. Qatar, Turkey and Indonesia matter in their regions; India's partners are nations/blocs that will shape the future of the global economy.

The third feature is the foundation of India's power. India's defence exports reached a record ₹38,424 crore in 2025-26, up 62% from the previous year. GE Aerospace and Hindustan Aeronautics will produce the F414 fighter engine in India, itself one of the most ambitious technology-transfer arrangements India has negotiated with the US. Companies commit to co-production in a country when they expect to be around for decades. These things compound over time, eventually becoming a country's strategic weight.

You might ask, and rightly so, that if India's ties with the US and others are now much deeper, why is Washington warming to Islamabad? This is likely why: In a crisis, the country that is useful in the immediate context and geography gets attention and is courted — Pakistan has always been very good at making itself useful in a crisis. Durable economic ties and defence production partnerships cannot find themselves in every news cycle.

That said, India should also be careful not to oversell the importance and weight of such ties and partnerships because it continues to be a net importer of arms and its trade agreements will take time to deliver.

However, a State can only build lasting influence on what others need from it over time, not immediately. It is that kind of influence and power that India is building, even if unevenly.

So, while we focus on how a Saudi commitment to Pakistan would play out in an India-Pakistan crisis, and whether the Badr brothers end up sharing what they learn about Indian systems, we should keep our nerve and resist the temptation to match Islamabad's headlines. Pakistan likes to be on the right side of events. India should build power to be on the right side of history.

Happymon Jacob is the author of India After Nonalignment and editor, INDIA'S WORLD magazine. The views expressed are personal

{ STRAIGHTFORWARD }
Shashi Shekhar

China may be a heavyweight, but India is no pushover

It was during the gathering chill of October-November 1962 that Chinese troops breached India's northeastern frontiers, forcing the country into an agonising conflict that ended in a searing national setback.

Sixty-four years later, the political cauldron is being stirred again over purported incursions in the same arena — the North East. While the Union government has cleared the air regarding border integrity, faceless keyboard warriors and an anxious Opposition remain up in arms.

The only real departure from the 1962 episode is an ironic twist of political fortunes. The ideological heirs of those who raised hell in 1962 are now at the helm, while the political descendants of that era's ruling establishment occupy the Opposition benches.

However, beyond these political tussles lies an uncomfortable reality. The Diwali fairy lights on our balconies and even the sacred idols of Ganesha and Lakshmi on our altars are largely imported from across the Himalayas. Chinese products have become deeply entrenched in everyday life in India while India's footprint in Chinese markets is virtually negligible.

India must strengthen its economic muscle to a point where Beijing — or any other adversary, for that matter — thinks hard before embarking on a misadventure. The self-reliance campaign that gained momentum after the Galwan Crisis has made commendable progress; but India must traverse a long and arduous path before it reaches parity with China. While China remains India's single-largest trading partner, India barely makes it to the country's list of top 10 or 12 trading relationships.

Beijing's authoritarian machinery has long functioned behind an iron curtain. Consequently, the Chinese are woefully unaware of India and its way of life. This information vacuum ensures that border standoffs do not trigger the kind of public outrage in China that they routinely do in India.

When I was in China in June this year, I asked my young Chinese guide what he knew about India. "Very little," he replied bluntly, "because we only read and see what the State wants us to see."

The information and economic asymmetry prevents any genuine public groundswell for peace from taking root across the border. It also explains why diplomatic talks on boundary disputes, since 1980, have often hit a brick wall.

Owing to historical ambiguities, the Line of Actual Control (LAC) acts as a *de facto* but undelineated boundary between the two Asian giants. In the absence of clarity on the ground, patrols from both sides occasionally stray into overlapping territory, resulting in inevitable friction. Yet, barring the bloody clash in Galwan, both nations have often exercised restraint to avert all-out hostilities.

BEIJING HAS LONG FUNCTIONED BEHIND AN IRON CURTAIN. CONSEQUENTLY, THE CHINESE ARE UNAWARE OF INDIA AND ITS WAY OF LIFE

The present row can be traced back to a video featuring the just-retired director general of the Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP), Shatrujeet Kapur, that recently went viral. In the video, Kapur says the standoff that flared up in July remains unresolved. Digital provocateurs seized upon the clip and unleashed an avalanche of alarmist commentary and sensational claims. The ministry of external affairs immediately tried to clear the air, and ITBP scrubbed the video from its official handle.

Over the past decade, India has systematically bolstered its security apparatus along the LAC. Engineering breakthroughs such as formidable Himalayan passes, including the Atal and Sela tunnels, along with the nearly complete Zojila project, ensure that strategic supply arteries to forward frontier bases remain operational in all seasons.

Those tracking border infrastructure will be well aware that roads, tunnels, and rail lines are being built on a war footing. Forward landing grounds and airfields have been extensively modernised to ferry heavy armour, logistics, and rapid reinforcements in compressed timeframes.

Further, state-of-the-art Heron Mk II surveillance drones and all-weather perimeter sensors have been deployed to detect and deter clandestine intrusions, backed by dedicated military reconnaissance satellites such as RISAT and EMISAT.

Battle-hardened from the Siachen and Kargil, India's mountain infantry remains virtually peerless in high-altitude operations. Their tactical superiority was proven after the skirmish (Galwan) when our troops preemptively secured the heights along the Kailash Range.

The doubting Thomases and doomsayers should recall September-October 1967 at Nathu La and Cho La. Riding high on their 1962 victory, Chinese commanders arrogantly demanded that Indian forces vacate both strategic passes by launching a series of incursions. To put an end to the intrusions once and for all, Major General Sagat Singh ordered the erection of a defensive barbed-wire perimeter.

Chinese troops opened indiscriminate fire to stop the barricading on September 11, killing several of our soldiers. Sagat Singh — without waiting for bureaucratic clearances from the Army headquarters — unleashed heavy artillery fire to pound enemy fortifications into submission. Weeks later, on October 1, brave Gorkha soldiers at Cho La drew their *khukris* and repelled the intruders in ferocious hand-to-hand combat. Over 300 Chinese soldiers were reportedly neutralised, against 88 Indian martyrs.

The message was bold and clear: India will never again be cowed down by a bully. Has India not emerged far stronger since?

Instead of calling the frontier villages the last posts of India, the Modi government has branded them as the first line of defence in a significant morale-boosting exercise. China may well be an economic and military heavyweight, but India is no pushover. India can ably defend its first villages and their valiant citizens.

Shashi Shekhar is editor-in-chief, Hindustan. The views expressed are personal

{ DONALD TUSK } PRIME MINISTER, POLAND

Shouting, lies, and brawling cannot — and will not — serve as a source of law in Poland

On the far-Right in the country, against the backdrop of the changes initiated by his government in the Polish top court, which the EU top court has deemed "not independent" in a 2021 ruling

Renewable energy success that should inspire the world

India's energy needs are growing rapidly. As the economy expands — with 7.8% real GDP growth in the first quarter of 2026-27 — so does demand for electricity from factories, businesses, and households. In the first half of this year alone, electricity demand grew by 6%. By 2035-36, demand could reach 459 gigawatts, according to the Central Electricity Authority.

At the same time, renewable energy has moved from the margins of India's power system to its centre. This reflects a long-term strategy that Prime Minister Narendra Modi has pursued since his years as chief minister of Gujarat, where he placed an early emphasis on solar energy, and transmission has been a central part of it.

Michael R Bloomberg

Pralhad Venkatesh Joshi

India is developing a Green Energy Corridor to connect renewable-rich regions with centres of energy consumption. Its recently announced third phase, a $19.3-billion investment in storage and transmission infrastructure, will help integrate another 135 GW of renewable energy capacity into the grid. The need for it is already clear.

Last May, as temperatures soared across northern and central India, the country's peak electricity demand reached a record 271 GW. Crucially, renewable energy met nearly one-third of that peak demand.

Air conditioners continued to run, fans kept turning, and homes and businesses stayed powered through one of the most demanding periods of the year.

A decade ago, such a surge in demand would have put far greater pressure on India's power system. Today, the country is better equipped to absorb it, largely because it hit its clean energy capacity targets five years ahead of schedule. Now, India generates a similar share of its power from renewables as the US does. And round-the-clock renewable energy with storage now costs about ₹5.2 per kilowatt-hour, the cheapest form of new power available.

India's renewable energy transition is crucial to supporting its next phase of economic growth, and progress has been accelerating. PM Modi's Pradhan Mantri Surya Ghar program, launched in 2024, aims to bring rooftop solar to 10 million homes by March 2027 — and it has already surpassed 6 million. That has helped make the electrical grid more resilient, while also reducing household bills. Around 2.1 million households have received zero electricity bills in at least one billing cycle after installation of rooftop solar under the PM Surya Ghar scheme.

Setting and meeting those targets has also given investors confidence. Solar capacity in India has grown nearly twentyfold over the last 10 years, making it the world's third-largest renewable energy market. India has also built a domestic ecosystem of developers, financial institutions, manufacturers, and service companies, creating jobs and attracting investment. It has topped BloombergNEF's Climate-Scope rankings of emerging economies for energy transition investment three years in a row. The lesson is clear: International capital followed because the domestic market proved the plan could work.

Bloomberg Philanthropies has helped bolster India's solar progress by partnering with India's ministry of new and renewable energy to map rooftop potential in 120 cities using satellite data, train nearly 9,500 vendors and installers, and reach nearly 1.4 million people through outreach. It used to take India 118 days to install solar on 100,000 rooftops. Now, thanks to this programme, it takes only six days.

Government, business, philanthropy, and civil society have all helped India lower electricity bills, clean the air, and create jobs. India now supports nearly 1.3 million renewable energy jobs, making it one of the world's leading clean-energy employers, with even more jobs expected in the years ahead.

India used to be entirely reliant on coal to power its grid. Coal remains part of its energy mix, but the tide has turned. Clean energy is now cheaper to build, faster to deploy, and a source of jobs and energy independence. India has been making this transition because it serves its economic, strategic, and public health interests.

Other countries face the same problems India did a decade ago: rising demand, unreliable grids, and populations without access to affordable power. India's example offers a potential roadmap for them, as they work to address those challenges.

Michael R Bloomberg is the founder of Bloomberg L.P. and Bloomberg Philanthropies. Pralhad Venkatesh Joshi is India's minister of new and renewable energy. The views expressed are personal

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Trump talks to Bibi as US mulls new strikes on Iran

HTC and Agencies
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NEW DELHI/DOHA/ABU DHABI: US President Trump spoke by phone with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu on Saturday (local time) as Washington weighed possible renewed military action against Iran. The White House had said last week that the US will not conduct any new strikes against Iran before the US midterm elections on November 3.

The Saturday call between Trump and Netanyahu was first reported by the Wall Street Journal. It came even as Iranian negotiators were in Doha on Sunday for a third consecutive day of talks with Qatari mediators aimed at pushing for a deal to end the US-Israeli war on Iran, an official briefed on the discussions told Reuters.

The talks come amid concerns that the conflict could escalate again after November 3. Donald Trump has said that talks with Tehran have been productive, though he has not ruled out further military action afterwards.

Iran's foreign minister Abbas Araqchi said on Sunday that the purpose of the "ongoing and progressing" talks was to continue consultations with the Qatari mediators, adding Tehran is prepared for "both defence and diplomacy", Reuters reported.

Speaking to state media, Araqchi said discussions on a "two-day proposal" were continuing, but that no final conclusion had been reached.

Qatari broadcaster Al Jazeera quoted Araqchi as saying in an interview on Saturday that Iranian and Qatari negotiators had developed a proposal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz within two days of a potential agreement with Washington.

Iran has repeatedly said it would respond to any new attacks by striking US and Israeli targets in neighbouring countries, as the eight-month-old war continues to disrupt global oil supplies and spill over across West Asia.

A Sea Hawk takes off from the deck of USS George Washington as the carrier enforces the US blockade against Iran on Sunday; (inset) an F-16 fighter jet flies over West Asia. U.S. CENTCOM-X

Trump WSJ suit over Epstein report tossed

Agence France-Presse
letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: A US judge on Saturday dismissed President Donald Trump's defamation lawsuit against the Wall Street Journal and media magnate Rupert Murdoch over a report that Trump sent a bawdy birthday letter to notorious sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

Trump had sued for $10 billion after the newspaper's story was published in July 2025 detailing the president's alleged 2003 letter to Epstein, which apparently featured a drawing of a naked woman.

Murdoch is the founder of News Corp, which owns the Wall Street Journal.

The report piled scrutiny on Trump from both Democrats and his own Republican party, who rejected the president's attempts to downplay the saga as a hoax and called for a full release of legal files on Epstein.

In Saturday's ruling, Judge Darrin Gayles dismissed Trump's lawsuit with prejudice, meaning Trump cannot file an amended version of the suit, as he did when Gayles turned down an initial version of it back in April.

US President Donald Trump speaks with the media as he arrives at a Halloween party at his Mar-a-Lago club in Florida. REUTERS

The judge wrote that in bringing his defamation claim, Trump had both times failed to establish that the defendants "acted with actual malice."

The House Oversight Committee last year published a copy of Trump's alleged birthday note to Epstein, which consists of a short dialogue between "Donald" and "Jeffrey."

"We have certain things in common," says Donald, to which Jeffrey responds: "Yes, we do, come to think of it."

"Enigmas never age, have you noticed that?" asks Donald.

"As a matter of fact, it was clear to me the last time I saw you," says Jeffrey.

"A pal is a wonderful thing. Happy Birthday -- and may every day be another wonderful secret," the note ends, followed by Trump's signature, which takes the place of pubic hair on the nude outline.

One or two targets left to hit: US prez

Agence France-Presse
letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump said on Saturday that the United States has knocked out much of Iran's military but still has to "take care of" one or two targets, as Tehran warned of reprisals if attacked.

Trump maintained that negotiations with Iran to end the war, which was started by the United States and Israel in February, were "going fine but you know they're not very reliable."

The Republican president said the United States is not in a hurry to take offensive action because it had already decimated Iran's military and nuclear program.

"We've knocked out their nuclear. We still have to take care of, I would say one or two sites, but we can do that in 10 minutes," Trump told reporters at his Florida residence.

"You probably could look at Pickaxe Mountain, and you have to take care of that. We can do that all very quickly," he added, referring to a suspected underground nuclear complex.

The Iranian government denied any nuclear work is carried out there.

Earlier Saturday, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said Trump has not made a decision about fresh strikes on Iran and that the United States would be open to a diplomatic solution.

Iran's supreme leader on Saturday warned the United States and Israel against launching a new offensive, following threats they could resume strikes .

New war could last longer, US warned

Agence France-Presse
letters@hindustantimes.com

TEHRAN: Iran warned on Sunday that any new war with the United States could last longer than the previous conflict and that US President Donald Trump would not be the one to determine its duration. "A potential future war could last longer than previous conflict, and the American president would not be in a position to dictate the timing or the conditions of its conclusion," said army spokesman Mohammad Akraminia, according to Iranian state television.

Iran's Defence Minister Mehrdad Akhlaghi on Sunday warned of a "proportionate, decisive, and impactful response" to any attack on the country, according to state TV. "Those who pose threats will not dictate the scope, timing, or consequences of Iran's defensive response," he added.

Also on Sunday, IRGC spokesperson Hossein Mohebbi echoed the remarks made by the Mojtaba Khamenei the day before.

INDIAN CARRIERS' FLIGHT DISRUPTIONS TO SAUDI EXTENDED

DUBAI: Flight disruptions between India and Saudi Arabia continue, with Akasa Air on Sunday extending the suspension of its services to Jeddah until November 18. Flights to and from Riyadh would remain suspended until November 30. Air India and Air India Express said earlier that their flights to and from Jeddah, Riyadh and Dammam would be suspended till November 14. PTI

BOLSONARO STAYS IN U.S. AS LONG AS HE WANTS: TRUMP

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PALM BEACH: President Donald Trump said on Saturday evening that defeated Brazilian presidential candidate Flavio Bolsonaro can stay in the United States indefinitely.

The comments, made to reporters during a Halloween party at Trump's Mar-a-Lago club in Florida, suggest that relations between the Western Hemisphere's two largest democracies may remain strained for some time, even as US Secretary of State Marco Rubio spoke with Brazil's top diplomat earlier in the day.

"He can stay here as long as he wants," Trump said of Bolsonaro, who left Brazil after losing the election to leftist incumbent Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, despite leading in most opinion polls. "In my opinion, the election was a disgrace."

The Brazilian embassy in Washington did not immediately return a request for comment.

Outside observers described the election as free and fair. Bolsonaro's decision to go to the US followed a ruling by a Brazilian Supreme Court justice to revoke his passport shortly after his loss.

FBI says North Korea behind Binance theft

Agence France-Presse
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NEW YORK: Binance said Sunday that it had resumed withdrawals after more than $6 billion in virtual assets were stolen from the cryptocurrency exchange in a major hack the FBI said North Korea was responsible for.

Binance is the world's largest crypto exchange by daily trading volumes. News of the hacking attack, which is thought to be the biggest-ever crypto heist, caused the prices of most major cryptocurrencies to fall sharply on Friday.

The company has offered reassurances it will cover the losses from the attack, saying it has used company funds to buy tokens to replenish 90 percent of what was stolen.

Binance suspended user withdrawals after the attack but said they would be resumed in phases, the first of which began on Sunday.

"First batch network now opened in phase one of withdrawals," the exchange posted on X.

The US law enforcement agency accused North Korea of being behind the hack in a statement on Saturday, confirming earlier suspicions from private investigators and analysts that a Pyongyang-affiliated group called TraderTraitor was responsible.

TraderTraitor is the same group blamed for a $1.5 billion theft from the Bybit platform in February last year.

"The Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) is releasing information advising the Democratic People's Republic of Korea (North Korea) was responsible for the theft of more than $6 billion USD in virtual assets from cryptocurrency exchange Binance, on or about October 29, 2026," the statement said.

The FBI added that it had observed "TraderTraitor actors" converting stolen assets into Ethereum, and expected those assets to be laundered further by converting them using decentralized finance and instant swap services.

BINANCE SEES INITIAL SPIKE IN CUSTOMERS PULLING OUT FUNDS

BARCELONA: Binance saw an initial spike in customers pulling money out after the exchange resumed withdrawals for a number of assets on Sunday. It said it had net outflows of $3.64 billion between 0600 and 1530 GMT on November 1. The outflows represented 2.1% of Binance's total $171 billion in assets under management, it said on X. REUTERS

Communist Party tightens official oversight in China

BEIJING: China's ruling Communist Party has adopted measures aimed at closer oversight of officials, official Xinhua reported on Sunday. It calls for expanded study of party and national history, enhanced monitoring of cadres throughout their careers and stricter scrutiny of officials' personal disclosures. Authorities will verify cases in which family assets and spending appear to exceed normal income, while strengthening routine oversight of business activities involving senior officials' spouses, children and children's spouses. REUTERS

Looking closely at Nvidia CEO China spy plot report: US

WASHINGTON: Donald Trump voiced on Saturday his support for the "brilliant" head of US chip giant Nvidia, Jensen Huang after a report he was targeted by a Chinese spy plot. Trump said the US was looking "very closely" at the issue. The NBT has reported that a Chinese executive linked to a Singapore-based data centre company, who had interacted with Huang, had been funneling information to Beijing. China has dismissed the report as "groundless speculation." "I have a lot of respect for Jensen.We want to protect our brilliant people," the president told media. AFP

Poland's Tusk says he won't back down in court standoff

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WARSAW: Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk vowed to press on with changes at the top court and accused the opposition of stirring up violence in an attempt to destroy the rule of law as the political crisis continued to spiral.

Tusk said in a TV address on Saturday that the Constitutional Tribunal in its current format isn't independent and his government's attempts to fix it have been sabotaged by the Law & Justice party and President Karol Nawrocki.

He spoke hours after riot police were deployed in front of the court, and two of its top judges were suspended. Nawrocki turned back his plane en route to Senegal and returned to Warsaw to hold consultations with parliamentary parties on Saturday, which Tusk's ruling Civic Coalition didn't attend.

"We have waited too long to be intimidated and to back down now," Tusk said. "I'm confident that the Constitutional Tribunal will begin to function as it ought to — independently, autonomously, and in accordance with the Constitution."

Poland's PM Donald Tusk

Hundreds of people continued to stage protests in front of the tribunal overnight into Sunday.

The battle over Poland's top court has pitted the pro-European Union veteran prime minister against the nationalist opposition, which stacked the tribunal with political appointees during its eight years in power. The EU's top court ruled in 2021 that the tribunal wasn't independent and impartial in its rulings.

Tusk pledged to restore the rule of law when he won the 2023 parliamentary elections, but has so far failed to deliver on most of the promises with his legislative agenda repeatedly vetoed by the opposition-backed Nawrocki. Facing another vote late next year and rising support for the far right, the prime minister signaled he has lost his patience.

"On certain matters, there can be no compromise," Tusk said. "Shouting, lies, and brawling cannot — and will not — serve as a source of law in Poland."

The European Commission spokesperson said the EU's executive arm is following closely the recent developments around the constitutional tribunal.

How the conflict eventually shakes out will matter for the rest of the EU as countries including Spain and France are facing general elections in the coming months with far-right parties gaining strength.

6 INDIAN TOURISTS STRANDED NEAR NEPAL'S DHO AREA DUE TO SNOWFALL

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KATHMANDU: Six Indian tourists have been stranded in the Sheyphoksundo National Park area of Nepal since Saturday afternoon due to heavy snowfall, with security personnel mobilised and efforts underway to rescue them, officials said on Sunday.

The tourists have been identified as Moumita Halder, Piyali Koley, Jajla Trivedi Kumar, Aditya Singha, Diplina Bishwas and Rajesh De.

The six had gone to the Dho area in Shey Phoksundo Rural Municipality's Ward No. 8, 300km northwest of Kathmandu. The area was covered in heavy snow. Dolpa chief district officer Junu Dhakal said they had ventured into the area despite warnings from security personnel and the Nepali guide accompanying them.

Shey Phoksundo Lake is Nepal's deepest lake. It is situated at an altitude of 3,600 metres and has an estimated depth of 145 metres.

Canada's Quebec to ban turbans, niqabs from elementary schools

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TORONTO: The new government in the Canadian province of Quebec will prohibit all religious coverings, including turbans and niqabs, from elementary schools, in a move that adds restrictions to those already in existence. The impact will mostly be on young Sikh, Muslim and Jewish children.

The separatist Parti Québécois came into power in the provincial election held in October and the ban on school children wearing overt religious attire was part of its platform. "We were elected on this base, and it's on this that we're going to work," the province's education minister Joël Arseneau said, according to the outlet Montreal Gazette.

In September, Paul St-Pierre Plamondon, now the province's Premier, said, "It's accepted that when you send your child to school, there are rules. The vast majority of people will understand that a religious symbol can be removed."

It builds on further restrictions enacted in April this under the previous Coalition Avenir Québecor government. That banned religious practice in public universities, private institutions subsidised by the government, even child car centres, the Gazette reported at the time. It also prohibits collective religious practices on roads or in parks.

The process of barring religious attire in public spaces began in 2019. The so-called secularism law prohibited certain categories of public servants from displaying a visible symbol of faith like the Sikh turban or a Muslim woman's hijab.

French protest violence eases while rioters loot stores in German city

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PARIS: French authorities expressed relief Sunday after mass protests over rising living costs resulted in less violence than previous weekends. But police expect new demonstrations as high schools at the heart of the movement reopen Monday after their autumn break.

Germany faced its own challenges after nationwide protests Saturday ended with rioters attacking police and looting stores in some cities. Around Europe, hundreds of thousands joined overwhelmingly peaceful marches Saturday inspired by young people, despite scattered unrest.

In Paris, rioters targeted police with Molotov cocktails at the end of Saturday's march on the city's eastern edge, injuring three officers and setting a car ablaze, police said. Across town, masked groups hurled fireworks at officers at a viewpoint across from the Eiffel Tower, and police charged repeatedly, sending panicked tourists fleeing the area.

Overall, however, the violence was less severe than on Oct. 17, when a city hall was torched and more than 2,000 stores were looted in hours of violence that authorities seemed unprepared to control, or during follow-up protests Oct. 24.

Police had arrested 779 people as of Saturday night, compared with 2,628 on Oct. 17 and 1,314 last weekend. Paris and Marseille police said a handful of shops were targeted but no major damage was reported.

A national police official said Sunday authorities had prepared for a larger turnout of both peaceful marchers and troublemakers. About 70,000 police were deployed around the country.

Police are preparing for more tensions as schools reopen Monday and as student groups and labor unions call for new nationwide protests on Tuesday and Thursday, the official told The Associated Press. The official spoke on condition of anonymity because they weren't authorized to be publicly named according to police policy.

More than 100,000 mostly young people protested peacefully across Germany on Saturday, demanding that the government invest more money in education, housing, climate protection and make daily life more affordable. In some cities the protests turned violent at night.

Following a demonstration in Frankfurt, rioters attacked police downtown and looted stores. More than 100 officers were injured and 54 people — aged 13 to 29 — were detained. It wasn't clear how many of the protesters were injured. Police said 17 stores were damaged and five of those were looted. After police cordoned off an area in the city center, the situation calmed down by early Sunday morning.

Violence also broke out Saturday night in Cologne.

A protester breaks a store window in Frankfurt; (right) a protester holds a firecracker in Paris. REUTERS

GST mop-up rises 23% to ₹2.31 lakh cr

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NEW DELHI: India's gross Goods and Services Tax (GST) collections rose 22.9% year-on-year to ₹2.31 lakh crore in October, the second-highest monthly collection since the tax regime was launched in July 2017, driven by strong growth in import-linked revenue.

Gross GST collections stood at ₹2,31,290 crore in October 2026, compared with ₹1,88,125 crore in October 2025, excluding compensation cess, according to government data released on Sunday. The collections reflect transactions undertaken in September.

On a comparable basis, October's collection was the second-highest ever, after the ₹2,42,702 crore recorded in April 2026. While April 2025 collections were higher at ₹2,36,716 crore before adjustment, they stood at ₹2,23,265 crore after deducting ₹13,451 crore in compensation cess. The cess was levied under the earlier GST regime but is no longer part of collections.

Deloitte India partner M S Mani said the October figures were significant because, for the first time, both gross and net GST collections had reached these levels in a normal month.

April collections are typically higher because they include year-end reconciliations. GST collections for a particular month reflect business transactions undertaken in the preceding month.

Import-linked GST collections led the growth, rising 42.2% year-on-year to ₹72,246 crore. Collections from domestic transactions grew 15.8% to ₹1,59,044 crore, the data showed.

The stronger growth in import-linked collections may also reflect higher imports of inputs used in manufacturing, rather than consumption alone, experts said.

Import-linked GST collections led the growth, rising 42.2% year-on-year to ₹72,246 crore.

Saurabh Agarwal, tax partner at EY India, said collections could rise further next month on the back of festive demand. "Looking ahead, the festive season should keep demand buoyant, and collections for the coming month are likely to remain strong," he said.

He, however, stressed the need to strengthen domestic activity to balance import-led revenue growth. "While the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes have delivered encouraging outcomes in select sectors, it may be time to revisit and recalibrate schemes in certain sectors with unutilized budgets, so that they better support the larger objective of an Atmanirbhar Bharat," he added.

After refunds of ₹27,934 crore, net GST collections in October stood at ₹2,03,356 crore, up 25.6% from ₹1,61,900 crore in the same month last year.

Refunds rose 6.5% from ₹26,225 crore in October 2025.

"Overall, the October numbers provide a positive signal for revenue mobilisation and reinforce the growing maturity of India's GST framework," said Abhishek Jain, partner and national head indirect tax for KPMG in India.

Deloitte India partner M.S.Mani said while the gross GST collections have crossed ₹2 lakh crore several times in recent months, the festive-season consumption boom had also pushed net collections above that mark. "Since the festive season is ongoing, this robustness is expected to continue as it ties with leading macroeconomic indicators," he said.

According to experts, monthly GST collections have stabilised at around ₹2 lakh crore following the rate rationalisation announced in September 2025.

At its 56th meeting on September 3, 2025, the GST Council announced a simplified two-slab structure of 5% and 18%, with a special rate of 40% for luxury and sin goods. The revised rates came into effect on September 22, 2025.

The rate changes were followed by a series of process reforms. At its 57th meeting in New Delhi on October 8, 2026, the GST Council recommended measures to simplify compliance, including changes to registration, refunds and adjudication.

It also recommended removing arrest provisions under GST and raising the prosecution threshold from ₹1 crore to ₹5 crore.

SEBI PLANS TO DELIST FIRMS WITH NO BIZ ACTIVITY

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KOLKATA: The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) is working towards removing companies with no economic activity from the stock exchanges, as their continued presence in the listed space poses a potential risk to investors, a top official said.

There are a number of listed companies with no economic activity, SEBI chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said.

"They pose a potential danger to investors, and therefore, it is necessary to remove them from the listed space. We are making efforts towards their delisting," Pandey said here on Saturday during a programme.From the perspective of market integrity, it is important to address the presence of such companies, as their continued listing could expose an increasing number of investors to potential risks through social media groups, he said.These stocks are used in "pump and dump operations" by some manipulators, the SEBI chairman said.

He said SEBI was using AI techniques to track and scrutinise such accounts, along with numerous other interventions to protect retail investors from getting trapped.On the small and medium enterprises (SME) listing board, Pandey said SEBI has proposed several changes through a consultation paper to improve the framework, while acknowledging that some older companies remain a concern.

Commenting on foreign portfolio investors (FPIs), he said the regulator would soon come out with another consultation paper, proposing easing of certain norms, particularly relating to disclosures and concentration limits.

The consultation paper is likely to be issued in the coming weeks, rather than months, he said. Pandey said FPIs operate across global markets and their investment decisions are influenced by post-tax returns in dollar terms.

Households caught between LPG curbs, missing last mile PNG links

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NEW DELHI: Households in far-flung areas even along gas pipelines face a double whammy: state-run gas agencies have stopped issuing new domestic liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) connections in certain areas since March, while piped natural gas (PNG) suppliers often find it cheaper to pay penalties than bear the high cost of laying pipelines for last-mile connections, people familiar with the matter said.

The restriction has created difficulties for households that cannot access a PNG connection despite living in areas covered by a city gas distribution (CGD) licence, the people said. Meanwhile, CGD companies often do not extend pipelines to remote pockets within their authorised geographical areas because of the high cost of providing last-mile connectivity. This leaves some households dependent on more expensive 5kg and 10kg LPG cylinders. Some consumers also resort to buying domestic cylinders from the black market, they added.

Distributors have been instructed not to issue new domestic LPG connections, which come with a 14.2kg cylinder, in areas where PNG is available or being made available, the people said, requesting anonymity. They added that restrictions also apply to refills for existing connections in some such areas, even where households have not obtained individual PNG connections.

The restriction has created difficulties for households that cannot access a PNG connection. MINT

A parliamentary panel flagged the problem in its report on "Supply and Distribution of Natural Gas – Challenges and Prospects", presented in August. Explaining the constraints to the committee, the petroleum ministry said: "If we ask now whether PNG will reach every home, the answer is no, it will not. Because the initial cost of providing piped gas is very high."

According to the ministry, CGD companies bid for licences to develop networks in specified geographical areas (GAs), committing to provide a certain number of PNG connections and establish a specified number of compressed natural gas (CNG) stations. Companies that fail to meet their targets face penalties determined by the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB), the downstream regulator.

The ministry told the committee that it had asked the regulator to impose penalties on CGD companies for failing to meet their targets. "Some people say that these companies are happy to even pay that penalty because the cost of giving the pipe natural gas connection is more than the penalty...," the report quoted the ministry as saying. The petroleum ministry, PNGRB and state-run energy companies, including Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation (BPCL), Hindustan Petroleum Corporation (HPCL) and GAIL India, did not respond to email queries on the matter.

In a written reply to the Lok Sabha on August 2, 2021, then petroleum minister Hardeep Singh Puri said penalties totalling ₹21.8 crore had been imposed on several CGD entities, including GAIL Gas Ltd, Aavantika Gas Ltd, Maharashtra Natural Gas Ltd, Siti Energy Ltd and Sanwariya Gas Ltd, for various violations.

A PNGRB presentation by its monitoring division in April 2026 showed that penalties totalling ₹34.31 crore had been imposed in 20 geographical areas for shortfalls in minimum work programme targets for domestic PNG connections and pipeline infrastructure.

Experts said the penalties were too small to incentivise companies to expand networks into commercially unviable areas, given the scale of the country's ambitions for PNG and CNG infrastructure.

Under the minimum work programme, authorised entities are required to provide approximately 12.6 crore domestic PNG connections and establish 18,336 CNG stations by 2034, the parliamentary committee report said. As of January 31, 2026, companies had provided around 1.63 crore domestic PNG connections and established 8,616 CNG stations, it added.

Centre takes Vedanta's Ravva award to SC

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NEW DELHI: The Union government has approached the Supreme Court, challenging a Delhi High Court order that allowed Vedanta Ltd and Ravva Oil (Singapore) Pvt Ltd to enforce foreign arbitration awards arising from a dispute over the Ravva oilfield, involving claims of $99 million.

According to the Supreme Court's cause list, a bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwala and Manmohan will hear the Centre's plea on Monday.

The Centre has challenged the Delhi High Court's 1 July 2026 judgement that rejected its objections to the enforcement of the awards. The high court also directed that bank guarantees furnished by Vedanta and Ravva Oil be released within eight weeks.

The dispute dates back to 1994, when the government entered into a production-sharing contract (PSC) with a consortium comprising Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC), Videocon Petroleum, Ravva Oil and Cairn Energy to develop the Ravva oilfield in the Krishna-Godavari basin. Cairn Energy's interest in the project subsequently passed to Cairn India, which was later merged with Vedanta.

At the heart of the dispute was how payments made by the companies towards ONGC's historical costs should be accounted for while calculating the parties' respective shares of revenue from oil production. The issue came to be known as the ONGC Carry issue.

The PSC provided for disputes to be referred to arbitration in Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia, under Malaysian law and the United Nations Commission on International Trade Law (UNCITRAL) Arbitration Rules.

In a partial award dated 12 October 2004, the tribunal ruled in favour of the companies on two of six issues and in favour of the government on the remaining four.

It left the quantification of the ONGC Carry issue unresolved, retaining jurisdiction to decide the matter if the parties failed to reach an agreement.

The government challenged the partial award before Malaysian courts. Although the Kuala Lumpur High Court initially set it aside in January 2009, the Malaysian Court of Appeal restored it in September that year.

The Malaysian Federal Court upheld the award in October 2011.

Domestic PV sales cross 5-lakh units mark in Oct on strong festive demand

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NEW DELHI: Buoyed by robust festive demand, domestic passenger vehicle dispatches breached the record 5-lakh mark in October, with leading automakers such as Maruti Suzuki, Hyundai and Mahindra & Mahindra recording their highest-ever monthly sales.

Domestic passenger vehicle wholesales in October are estimated in the range of 5.25-5.3 lakh units, against 4.6 lakh units in October 2025.

This should represent growth of around 13-15% year-on-year despite a high base in the year-ago period. "My take is, the industry should be between 5.25-5.3 lakh units," said Partho Banerjee, senior executive officer at Maruti Suzuki. Market leader Maruti Suzuki reported domestic passenger vehicle dispatches of 2.12 lakh units in October, which represents growth of 20% year-on-year. Tata Motors recorded 21% growth to 73,894 units, while M&M posted a 2% rise to record 73,338 units. Hyundai posted a 16.7% increase in domestic wholesales to 62,799 units.

"With Dhanteras and Diwali in the first half of November, October wholesales largely reflect OEMs stocking up dealers ahead of peak festive deliveries. October registrations, by contrast, are expected to decline against last year's high festive base, as a significant share of festive deliveries shifts into November," said Gaurav Vangaal, associate Director for Light Vehicle Production Forecasting at Mobility Global.

October's growth comes on a high base. In 2025, sales from mid-August to mid-September were subdued as buyers held off purchases, expecting a GST cut. After the lower rates took effect in the last week of September, demand rebounded, driving strong sales through the festive season and into October.

India's crude oil imports surge to a record high in October

Press Trust of India
feedback@livemint.com

NEW DELHI: India's crude oil imports surged to a record high of about 5.6 million barrels per day in October, with refiners stepping up purchases from the Middle East and Russia despite ongoing geopolitical tensions, according to data from energy intelligence firm Kpler.

Middle Eastern supplies accounted for about 2.3 million barrels per day, and Russian crude flows remained strong at around 2 million bpd, Kpler lead analyst Nikhil Dubey said in a post.

Higher ship-to-ship transfers helped move more crude through the Strait of Hormuz, supporting a recovery in Gulf supplies during September and October and giving Indian refiners greater flexibility in sourcing.

Russian shipments could moderate in November and December as attacks in the Black Sea push up freight rates, making those barrels less competitive on a landed-cost basis. At the same time, Gulf suppliers are offering competitive delivered prices to regain market share in India, Dubey said.

Refiners step up purchases from the Middle East and Russia despite ongoing geopolitical tension. HT

However, any renewed disruption to flows through the Strait of Hormuz could prompt Indian refiners to return to Russian crude, even if transportation costs rise.

The October 16 waiver under the Graham Act could also ease concerns among some Indian buyers about the risks associated with purchasing Russian oil, giving refiners greater flexibility in procurement, he said.

India imports nearly 90% of its crude oil requirements, making the availability and landed cost of alternative supplies critical to refinery economics. The choice between Russian and Middle Eastern barrels is therefore likely to remain driven by commercial considerations and supply security rather than geopolitics alone. Russia's invasion of Ukraine in February 2022 upended global oil trade flows, prompting Western countries to impose sanctions, an EU ban on seaborne Russian crude and a G7 price cap.

With European buyers shunning Russian oil, Moscow offered steep discounts to attract alternative markets, and India emerged as a major buyer, sharply increasing imports from negligible levels before the war to as much as 40-50% of its crude basket at their peak.

Consumer spending shows uneven growth ahead of Diwali

Soumya Gupta
soumya.gupta@livemint.com

MUMBAI: India's consumer economy is showing uneven signs of growth ahead of Diwali, with some segments reporting robust demand while others remain subdued amid high inflation, rising input costs and a shift in the festive season from the September to the December quarter.

Food and grocery recorded among the highest growth rates in July and August, at 12% year on year in the latest months for which data are available, according to consulting firm Deloitte's latest Consumer Signals report for India. Apparel growth picked up to 10% in August, while durables and electronics grew 7% during these months.

Jewellery sales growth moderated from more than 8% in August to just over 4% in September, according to data from the Retailers Association of India (RAI). The industry body said the shift in the timing of festivals from the second to the third quarter affected the numbers.

Food and grocery recorded among the highest growth rates in July and August, at 12%. HT

Rising oil and commodity prices are adding to the pressure on consumer goods companies, raising the prospect of further price increases that could weigh on demand. Brent crude above $110 a barrel remains a major headwind for India, which imports nearly 90% of its crude oil requirements. Higher interest rates may also challenge big-ticket purchases such as cars and homes.

"Rising interest rates may dampen festive-season demand for consumer durables by increasing EMI costs and making credit-dependent consumers more cautious," said Shiv Sharma, principal at Gurugram-based Kanvic Consulting. "Buyers may defer upgrades, trade down to affordable models or rely more heavily on discounts, particularly for high-ticket products. The impact depends on how quickly higher policy rates translate into retail lending rates."

Inflation has prompted consumer goods companies across categories to raise prices over the past few quarters, largely as the cost of plastic packaging and other crude-linked inputs rose amid the West Asia war.

Yet, packaged food and everyday essentials companies are reporting resilient festive-season demand. Consumers continue to spend on premium, healthier and packaged products, suggesting that demand for festive essentials is relatively inelastic. Companies are also introducing premium festive products at entry-level price points to tap seasonal demand.

Hindustan Unilever Ltd, India's largest consumer goods company, said festive-season demand remained strong for both everyday essentials and premium products despite higher inflation.

Everyday essentials tend to be less (price) elastic, Priya Nair, chief executive and managing director of HUL, told reporters at a press briefing late last month. "The focus for us is to ensure that we are more competitive and that our brands become stronger in the context of the (inflationary) environment in which we are. We are focussing on developing the market with new formats, new products, and entry into new wide spaces."

Rival consumer goods companies are also focusing on festive launches aimed at premium buyers seeking indulgent and healthier options. These include Cadbury's new chocolate mithais and PepsiCo's protein-based laddoos and chikki bites, priced at ₹10 a pack.

"Consumers are increasingly looking beyond conventional choices and exploring new flavours, formats, and combinations to make their gifts more distinctive," Vinay Subramanyam, vice-president of marketing at confectionery maker Mondelez India, told *Mint*. "We are seeing a growing appetite for experimentation, where the experience of gifting is as important as the product itself."

"This space - which is largely premium, urban pockets is largely unfamiliar to most Indians," Saakshi Verma Menon, chief marketing officer - foods at PepsiCo India, told *Mint*.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

1 Dull but done with style (8)
5 Fight for support (4)
9 Old capital of Japan rebuilt as Tokyo (5)
10 IOUs run wild could well be (7)
11 Matches may be made if three girls go abroad (12)
13 Don't miss a review (6)
14 I am in pursuit in a carriage (6)
17 Made a resounding comeback (12)
20 Chooses to make an allusion in a postscript (7)
21 Top gear selected by a duchess perhaps (5)
22 Smash strike (4)
23 She is assigned to guard military uniform (8)

DOWN

1 Apples grow on them (4)
2 I may feature a lot in his conversation (7)
3 The pick of the professions? (6,6)
4 Air force (6)
6 Be under professional examination (5)
7 Unfamiliar desert is crossed (8)
8 Happy to arrange the right deal (5-7)
12 Brave diner gets mixed up with the tip (8)
15 Repeat treat that is arranged (7)
16 Aspire to reform Iran in the past (6)
18 Surveys opinions (5)
19 Mad cricketers (4)

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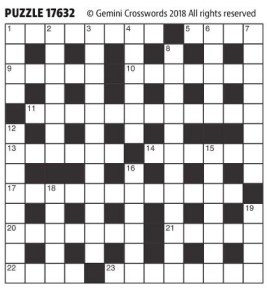

QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

1 Reaction reported from consumers (8)
5 Indonesian island (4)
9 Set of matching furniture (5)
10 A Hungarian stew (7)
11 Precedence within hierarchy (7,5)
13 Uneven in quality (6)
14 To numb (6)
17 An expression (4,2,6)
20 Weariness (7)
21 Stock laid by (5)
22 Plunder (4)
23 Wild uncontrollable emotion (8)

DOWN

1 Firmly fixed (4)
2 Urgent (7)
3 Major discovery (12)
4 Convincing (6)
6 Bestow (5)
7 Supporter of party (8)
8 Beyond hearing range (3,2,7)
12 Vindictive (8)
15 Feeling of hopelessness (7)
16 Quick (6)
18 Proportion (5)
19 Notion (4)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17631)

CRYPTIC

I	N	T	E	R	L	U	D	E	■	B	■	G	■	C
O	■	R	■	A	■	A	■	N	O	N	A	■	■	■
C	O	R	R	E	C	T	■	S	■	R	■	S	■	■
S	■	A	■	E	■	U	T	M	O	S	T	■	■	■
S	E	C	T	O	R	■	E	■	D	■	A	■	■	■
I	■	A	■	A	V	E	R	S	I	O	N	■	■	■
G	■	I	■	T	■	A	■	N	■	E	■	■	■	■
H	U	N	T	R	E	S	S	■	G	■	N	E	■	■
T	■	E	■	T	A	U	N	T	S	■	■	■	■	■
S	K	E	T	C	H	■	W	■	R	■	O	■	■	■
E	■	R	E	■	B	I	S	E	C	T	S	■	■	■
E	D	I	T	S	■	N	■	A	■	A	■	■	■	■
R	T	■	S	E	E	D	D	U	B	L	E	■	■	■

QUICK

W	A	T	E	R	S	H	E	D	■	G	■	F	■	■
■	■	L	■	E	■	R	■	I	B	E	X	■	■	■
R	A	M	P	A	N	T	■	M	■	R	■	■	■	■
R	■	A	■	T	E	■	E	S	T	A	T	E	■	■
A	M	E	N	D	S	■	■	O	■	F	■	E	■	■
I	■	D	■	T	R	A	N	S	F	E	R	■	■	■
R	E	■	E	■	R	■	E	■	A	■	■	■	■	■
W	A	N	D	E	R	E	R	■	R	■	N	■	■	■
O	■	S	■	N	■	O	P	E	N	E	D	■	■	■
R	E	L	A	T	E	■	G	■	V	■	A	■	■	■
T	■	A	■	I	■	S	A	V	I	N	G	S	■	■
H	A	V	O	C	■	■	N	■	E	■	■	■	■	■
Y	E	■	E	A	R	T	H	W	O	R	K	■	■	■

{ SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★

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		6						2
9				8				6
				3	2			
1			8		4			7
			1	7				
7				6				5
3						4		
2	5	1	7				9	

Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9X9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.

GAME ZONE: Scan the QR code for more daily puzzles and brain teasers

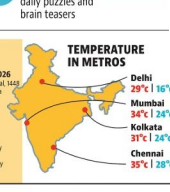
{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE ▪HIGH ▪LOW

MONDAY	TUESDAY	WEDNESDAY
Mainly clear sky	Mainly clear sky	Mainly clear sky
29°C | 16°C	29°C | 16°C	28°C | 16°C

ALMANAC
Today is
2nd November 2026
21 Jumada Al-Awwal, 1448
08, Kartika, Krishna Paksha, 08 Samvat 2083
Sunset: Monday at 05:36 p.m.
Sunrise: Tuesday at 06:33 a.m.
Moonset: Monday at 01:27 p.m.
Moonrise: Tuesday at 12:41 a.m.

TEMPERATURE IN METROS



Harman hat-trick powers India to win

JALANDHAR: Harmanpreet Singh (3rd, 33rd and 58th minute) converted two PCs and also scored from the spot while Sukhjeet Singh (43) scored a field goal to help India beat Malaysia 4-2 in the Asian Champions Trophy. Already assured of a semi-final berth, India handed Malaysia their first defeat, extending their own winning run to four matches. Malaysia's goals were scored by Akhimullah Anuar (25) and Shello Silverius (60).

SC Delhi stage stunning comeback

MUMBAI: SC Delhi beat Mumbai City FC 3-2 in their ISL match. Carlos Fortes (73'), Akshat Mehra (90+2') and Juan Pena (90+4') were on target for the visitors. Muhammad Ajsal (6') and Zothanpuia (27') scored for Mumbai City. In another match, FC Goa beat Inter Kashi 2-1, with goals from Francisco Feuillassier (35') and Christian Borrego (66') on either side of a Sumeet Passi strike (51').

Lifter Usha tops her group, Nirupama 4th

NINGBO: India lifter Usha topped her group, while Nirupama Devi finished fourth in her's at the IWF World C'ships. The 23-year-old Usha lifted a total of 212kg -- 93kg in snatch and 119kg in clean and jerk.

EB women win in AFC Champions League

NEW DELHI: East Bengal Women became the first Indian team to win multiple AFC Women's Champions League Group matches after they beat Ho Chi Minh City 2-1 in Kolkata. Fazila Ikwaput (21' pen, 34') scored for East Bengal, while Dau Anh (60') scored for the visitors.

Sindhu, Lakshya triumph to make it a rare Indian double

Sandip Sikdar
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NEW DELHI: The air inside the 5,500-capacity Saarlandhalle in Saarbrucken crackled as the 39th edition of the $500,000 Hylo Open reached a cinematic climax.

For Indian badminton enthusiasts, the last time an Indian won this Super 500 tournament was when Lakshya Sen clinched the title, then called the SaarLorLux Open, in 2019 by defeating China's Weng Hongyang.

On Sunday, Indian badminton history echoed through the hall once more as two of India's finest — Sen and PV Sindhu — stepped onto the bright blue courts chasing glory, painting a masterclass of pure dominance.

For Sindhu, Sunday felt like the culmination of a mission. Reaching a final for the second successive week, the second-seeded former world champion walked onto the court as the favourite, riding the momentum of a brilliant run that had taken her to the French Open final in Paris a week before, losing to defending champion An Se Young. Having already claimed the Japan Open crown in July, this marked Sindhu's third final of the year.

Standing across the net was Denmark's eighth seed, Line Kjaersfeldt. Though ranked No.25 to Sindhu's No. 8, and holding a lopsided 1-6 head-to-head record against the Indian, Kjaersfeldt matched stroke for stroke in the initial exchanges.

But Sindhu was simply operating on another level. Leveraging her height and reach, Sindhu quickly dismantled her opponent.

After racing to an 11-8 lead, Sindhu unleashed a breathtaking seven-point rampage from 14-12 up, sweeping up seven game points and sealing the opener 21-12 in a blistering 17 minutes.

The second game followed a similar script. Though Kjaersfeldt, coached by former Danish international Hans-Kristian Vittinghus, fought valiantly to narrow the gap to 6-7, the mounting pressure began to tell. Errors crept into the Dane's game — pushing the shuttle long or hitting it into the net — while Sindhu maintained her composure to lead 11-7.

To the delight of coach Irwansyah cheering from the sidelines, Sindhu never allowed a window of opportunity. A final net error from Kjaersfeldt sealed a comprehensive 21-12, 21-14 victory in just 38 minutes, securing Sindhu a well-earned winner's cheque of $37,500.

"It was important for me to give my 100% irrespective of who the opponent was," she said. "We've played a lot of times and for me it was important that I focus on every point. Not about the whole game, but every point mattered. I took the lead from the beginning and I didn't give her a chance."

With her second consecutive week in a final, Sindhu admitted that the journey has been a confidence booster. "I'm happy that things are going according to plan. I'm very grateful and thankful to my whole team. Everyone had worked really hard. I know there were days when you were absolutely low, but still your team is there to pump you up.

"As you keep growing it's important to get your things better and be smarter in what you choose. But at the same time, it was important for me to just stay calm. More than anything there is still room to improve."

Sen cruises to title

With Sindhu's title safely secured, all eyes turned to seventh-seeded Lakshya Sen as he stepped up to write the concluding chapter of India's campaign in the men's final. Facing Indonesian fourth seed and defending champion Jonatan Christie, Sen carried the mantle of his legacy in Germany.

Though Christie held a 4-3 edge in their head-to-head record, Sen had won their last two encounters, setting the stage for a tense battle.

Christie, eager to make amends after runner-up finishes at the India Open and Indonesia Open earlier in the year, pushed hard early on. Sen, contesting his second final of the year following his All England Open runner-up finish against Lin Chun-Yi, started brightly, taking an 8-4 lead. However, Christie fought back with five straight points to edge ahead 9-8.

What followed showcased Sen's breathtaking repertoire. Trailing 8-9, the Indian went on an extraordinary surge, pocketing 10 of the next 11 points to command a staggering 18-10 lead. Though Christie mounted a valiant counter-offensive, narrowing the gap to 17-18, Sen kept his nerve, breaking the Indonesian's momentum with three consecutive points to pocket a fiercely contested first game.

The second game was all about Sen's relentless acceleration. Establishing an early 5-2 lead, the Indian outpaced Christie, blending lightning-fast court coverage with immaculate stroke-making.

By the time Sen surged to a 16-10 lead, the resistance had drained from his opponent. Seizing the moment, Sen rattled off five unanswered points, closing out the match with authority to claim his first title of the season. It capped off an unforgettable Sunday for Indian badminton.

Arsenal's Kai Havertz celebrates after scoring vs Liverpool. REUTERS

Arsenal end Anfield hoodoo to go on top of Premier League

Agencies
sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

LIVERPOOL: Arsenal moved to the top of the Premier League with their first win away to Liverpool in 14 years as Kai Havertz's early strike secured a 1-0 victory for the Gunners. The defending champions were made to suffer after the German's 16th-minute opener but held out for what could be a telling win in their quest to retain the title.

Arsenal climbed three points clear of Man City at the top of the table. But with City expected to be hit with a severe points penalty, unless they can overturn a guilty verdict on over 100 charges of breaking Premier League rules, Arsenal dealt a huge blow to their most likely rivals for the title.

Liverpool produced arguably their spell of Andoni Iraola's early months in charge with a blistering 30 minutes after conceding, but failed to take their chances as the Spaniard suffered just his second defeat in 14 games since arriving from Bournemouth.

Mikel Arteta was stinging in his criticism of the Arsenal side that crashed out to fourth-tier Fleetwood on Tuesday in one of the biggest ever League Cup shocks.

The Arsenal boss got the response he desired in a strong start from the champions.

Havertz was one of the biggest culprits for wasting chances in midweek but made amends with a simple finish from Declan Rice's precise low cross.

The early goal lit the touchpaper for a pulsating first 45 minutes as Liverpool roared back.

Iraola and Arteta played together as boys for Basque side Antiguoko Kirol Elkartea.

Arteta's old friend gave his side one of the most uncomfortable afternoons they have experienced in recent seasons as Arsenal's rock-solid defence was left clinging on for half-time.

All of Liverpool's three £100 million-plus ($134 million) forwards started together and there are signs the relationship between Alexander Isak, Florian Wirtz and Bradley Barcola is beginning to flourish.

Isak did Arsenal a favour by not going down as he was pulled back by Jurrien Timber when just failing to connect with a wicked delivery from Barcola.

The visitors still had chances on the counter-attack as Bruno Guimaraes pulled a shot just wide before Timber inadvertently blocked Noni Madueke's ball across goal with Havertz waiting to apply the finish.

Up the other end, Wirtz curled a free-kick onto the bar from a narrow angle and Alexis Mac Allister should have buried a header into the goal rather than finding the stand behind David Raya's goal.

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CHANGE OF NAME

I, MANISH Kumar Gupta Father of Kushagra Gupta R/o Flat No. 1003, Tower-2, Omaxe The Nile, Sector-49, Sohna Road, Gurugram inform that in my minor Son's (Kushagra Gupta) school records, my name has been wrongly written as Manish Gupta, while correct name is Manish Kumar Gupta, which may be amended accordingly.

I, SUREKHA Devaraddi wife of Service No.15824663P, Rank:-L/Nk Name:- Sanjeev Siddappa Ittal residing at Near Basaveshwar Temple, Devaradderakatti, P.O. Murgund\i.Distt. Belagavi, Karnataka-591304 have changed my name to Surekha Sanjeev Ittal for all future Purposes and actual date of birth is 10.04.1994. Vide affidavit dated 23/10/2026 Notary Public New Delhi.

I KISHOR Pal S/O Mr.Ramnagina R/O Swara Nagri Gr. Noida Knowledge Park-I Dist. G B Nagar UP 201310 have changed my name from Kishore pal to Kishor Pal for all purposes.

I, JAYASHREE Mahana Acharya, R/o D803, PVSN, Sec-67, Gurugram inform that in our minor daughter's Nandini Acharya's school records my name has been wrongly spelt as Jayashree M Acharya while correct name is Jayashree Mahana Acharya which may be amended accordingly.

LOST & FOUND

I, ANJALI Ahuja Srivastava D/o Late Dev Kumar Ahuja, W/o Ramhit Nandan, R/o A48, Bathla Apartments, 43 IP Ext, Delhi - 110092, have lost the property papers of Flat No. 43 A,GH 10, Sundar Apartments, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110087, which include the original Allotment Letter, Possession Letter, Original Conveyance Deed, Relinquishment Deed, Original payment receipts, original correspondence with DDA relating to the flat, etc. An FIR for this was lodged vide FIR number LR: 763150/2026. Finder may please contact 9971949963.

COURT NOTICES

IN THE COURT OF MS. KIRAN GUPTA, DISTRICT JUDGE-02 (N/W) Room No. 317, Third Floor, Rohini Court, Delhi
SUMMONS FOR SETTLEMENT OF ISSUES
CASE No: CS DJ/6017/2026
DIAG REALTECH OPC PVT. LTD. ....Plaintiff
Versus
HDFC BANK LTD. & ORS. ....Defendant
To,
1. Smt. Bimla Devi, (Impersonator)
R/O. UNKNOWN

Whereas the plaintiff has instituted a suit against you for and you are hereby summoned to file a written statement within 30 days of the service of the present summons and to appear in this Court in person, or by a pleader duly instructed, and able to answer all material questions relating to suit, or who shall be accompanied by some person able to answer all such questions, on the 13.11.2026 at 10 o'clock in the forenoon to answer the claim; and further your are hereby directed to produce on the said day all documents in your possession or power upon which you base your defense or claim for set-off or counter-claim, and where you rely on any other document whether in your possession or power or not, as evidence in support of your defense or claim of for set-off or counter-claim you shall enter such documents in a list to be annexed to the written statement.
Take notice that, in default of your appearance on the day before mentioned, the suit will be heard and determined in your absence.
Given under my hand and the seal of the Court this 30th day of OCTOBER, 2026.
SEAL
District Judge-02 (N/W)
Room No. 317, Third Floor, Rohini Court, Delhi

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Seifert, Milne pull one back for NZ, India take series 3-2

Asked to set the target for the first time in the series, India post 191 but lose by 7 wickets in final T20I in Hamilton

Somshuvra Laha
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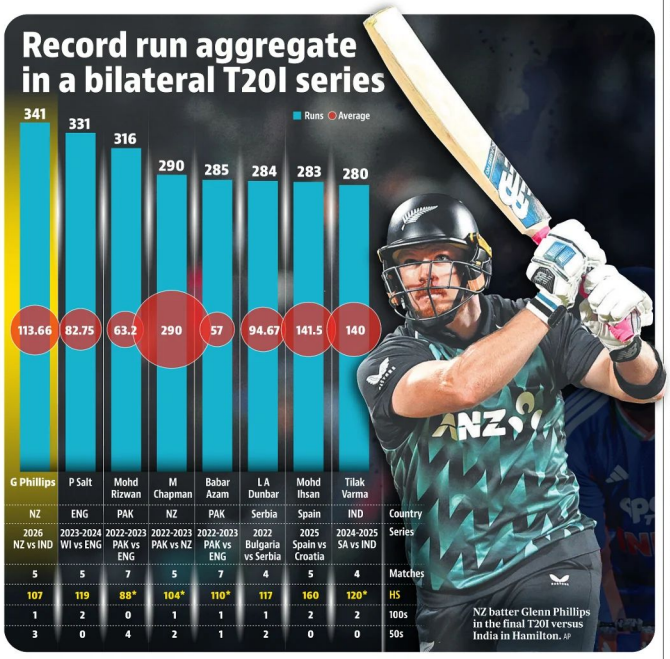
KOLKATA: After three trailblazing chases and one forgettable capitulation, say hello to India setting the target for the first time in this five-match series. Only probably because New Zealand had finally won the toss. It had a telling effect on India's scoring. Without a number to overtake, Abhishek Sharma and Sanju Samson failed to find their gears. Ishan Kishan and Shreyas Iyer eased to fifties but nothing beyond as India ended up with 191/8.

The total ideally should have been competitive on any other day. This though has been that kind of series where nothing below 200 sufficed. And it was no different for India as New Zealand chased it down for three wickets in just 18 overs in the fifth T20I at Hamilton on Sunday.

For a change, India had the bowling to make something else happen. With Bhuvneshwar Kumar and Varun Chakravarthy back in the side, New Zealand had to negotiate with more alertness than usual. That was evident in Chakravarthy's first over where he went for a review off his first delivery, followed by another half appeal that bookended a flicked six over long-on. Over before that though, Kumar went 0, 4, 6, 0, 0, 4, meaning India had been pegged back very early in their defence of a target which was beginning to feel modest by the time Tim Seifert cruised to his fifty in 34 balls.

He shouldn't have got that far though. But Naman Dhir not holding on to a low but not impossible catch at deep backward point in the fourth over allowed the hosts a comforting start. Ninety-six for two at the halfway stage, New Zealand's progress was staggered and assured, despite India trying every trick in their book, including making Abhishek roll his arm around for an over. Seifert kept his scoring approach simple — slashing, whipping, flicking and lifting anything wayward.



NZ batter Glenn Phillips in the final T20I versus India in Hamilton. AP

Straight was where Seifert was most effective — something Kumar would attest to —till on 83 when Nitish Reddy got him to slog at a short and wide delivery, inducing a thick inside edge on to his stumps. That dismissal had no bearing on the game given the clarity with which Daryl Mitchell, Glenn Phillips — he now holds the record for most runs (341) in a bilateral series — and later Bevon Jacobs were striking the ball.

Arshdeep Singh once again stuck to his guns but lacked support as Prince Yadav, Bhuvneshwar and Chakravarthy went for plenty. It was never going to be a difficult chase though, primarily because India never had the requisite runs on the board.

Abhishek was undone by a delivery just short of good length while committing to clearing his front leg and going for a big hoick. All he got though was a mistimed skier that was pouched at mid-on. Samson's dismissal was even weirder, trying to help himself towards fine leg but getting a leading edge over extra cover.

Kishan and Shreyas Iyer added 83 for the third wicket, that too off only 43 balls, thereby negating any slowdown Adam Milne — he finished with 4/19 — and the first two dismissals would have caused. But Iyer and Kishan departed in the space of 13 balls, and from there India started to lose their way.

"We could've been better considering the start we got in the middle overs," Iyer said at the post-match presentation. "From there we lost back to back wickets. It wasn't an easy wicket to bat on, was challenging off that hard length." That showed in the way Tilak Varma, Dhir and Reddy were dismissed, particularly how Varma was rushed by a good length ball that hit him high on his bat.

Stranded on 133/5, it was still creditable that India reached 191. Either Reddy or Dhir should have stayed on till the end, and that probably cost India at least 20 runs.

New Zealand fought back in the last two matches but India would gladly take this 3-2 series win considering the bowling resources used in all five matches. No Jasprit Bumrah, no Kuldeep Yadav, no Shivam Dube, Chakravarthy used for just one game— this was a deliberate attempt at trying to create a backup bench of bowlers.

It worked to a certain extent, though in the end India's batting came up short in the last two games. No harm done though, according to Iyer. "First three games steadied the rhythm for us," he said. "Last two games I feel we were in the position where we wanted to experiment and challenge ourselves."

Brief scores: India 191/8 in 20 overs (Ishan Kishan 61, Shreyas Iyer 50; Adam Milne 4/19). New Zealand 192/2 in 17.1 overs (Tim Seifert 93, Glenn Phillips 65 not out). **New Zealand won by seven wickets.**

Drained but strong enough to take pressure: Gambhir

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: India head coach Gautam Gambhir said he gets mentally drained while coaching the senior men's team across formats, but is willing to soak up the pressure.

After the T20I series win over New Zealand, the former India opener said it gets tough during the short turnaround period between formats, but he knew what he signed up for and is hence ready for the challenge.

Gambhir added that he is professional enough and hence there's no place for terms like fear and fatigue. "In my dictionary, my directory, and my ideology, there is no place for fear, and that word does not exist in my life. I think we are professionals, and I've always believed that there are no excuses," Gambhir said at the post-match press conference after the fifth and final T20I, which India lost by seven wickets at Hamilton on Sunday.

"From the workload point of view, I know it's tough. It can be very challenging as well. Especially when you are on the road and the kind of pressure you go through. Especially coaching a team like India, and people don't give you an inch. Everyone expects you to win every game, but you need to be realistic as well. I am enjoying it," he added.

When asked whether he has felt "mentally cooked" while juggling between formats, Gambhir said, "Yes, I have, to be honest, but I am strong enough to manage that. I'm strong enough to take it for as long as I can. That's how I am built, and I can take pressure; I can take the bullet. But, yes, I am a human being, there will be times when I will feel drained out, but till now I have been able to take it."

The head coach was also proud of the Shreyas Iyer-led team for winning the series 3-2. India arrived in New Zealand just a couple of days before the series opener in Christchurch, and Gambhir hailed the performance in the opening three T20Is that his team won to take an unassailable lead in the five-game series.

"First of all, it's an incredible effort because boys got only one day to prepare. Different conditions, different weather conditions, different dimensions, playing against a quality side like New Zealand in their backyard with the amount of experience they had in T20 cricket, plus most of the boys touring New Zealand for the first time," said Gambhir.

"My view is that after one practice session, after taking a 15-hour flight, if guys can deliver that kind of a performance, especially against a quality side, I think a lot of credit needs to go to this side; this is an achievement which I think we should always talk about," he added.

Gambhir added that the T20I team will continue its fearless approach and will not waver in the new identity. He also had high praise for skipper Shreyas Iyer for winning a series against a top-quality opposition despite not having a full-strength bowling attack.

India won the first three T20Is against New Zealand but lost the final two matches in Auckland and Hamilton. "Shreyas has done a fabulous job with so much inexperience in the bowling lineup because, as a captain, you're only as good as how your bowlers or your batters perform. I think he's done a phenomenal job."

Shreyas took over as the T20I captain from Suryakumar Yadav earlier this year. His captaincy stint did not get off to an ideal start as India lost the series against Ireland and England, but the team bounced back to win the Asian Games gold and the series against Zimbabwe and New Zealand. In between, the five-match series against West Indies ended on level footing.

"Shreyas took over a very successful team. A team that had won the World Cup and hadn't lost a T20I series in two years. Obviously, we had challenging opposition after the World Cup. We gave opportunities to a lot of new guys as well," said Gambhir.

India's players celebrate the five-match T20I series win over New Zealand. AFP

Especially coaching a team like India, and people don't give you an inch. Everyone expects you to win every game...I am enjoying it

GAUTAM GAMBHIR, India head coach

MATT BOYLE HITS UNBEATEN TON AS NZ A FIGHT BACK AGAINST INDIA A

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CHRISTCHURCH: New Zealand A recovered from a poor start to reach 218/3 at stumps on Day 2 of the second unofficial Test against India A on Sunday, riding on an unbeaten century by Matthew Boyle and a half-century from Dean Foxcroft.

Boyle was batting on 107 off 148 balls, having struck 14 boundaries and a six, while Foxcroft remained unbeaten on 80 off 180 deliveries, with nine fours, as the duo stitched together an unbroken 205-run partnership for the fourth wicket.

New Zealand A were in deep trouble at 13/3 after losing three wickets in the first eight overs, with Mohammed Siraj and Mukesh Kumar doing the early damage. Siraj dismissed captain Rhys Mariu (4), who was caught behind by Dhruv Jurel, while Mukesh removed Curtis Heaphy (4) and Tim Robinson (3) in quick succession.

Mukesh was the most successful Indian bowler with figures of 2/44 from 16 overs, while Siraj returned 1/49 in his 16 overs.

Earlier, India A were bowled out for 346 in their first innings, adding 55 runs to their overnight total of 291 for seven.

Captain Dhruv Jurel, who was unbeaten on 99 at the close of the opening day, completed a fine century before falling for 105. He faced 171 deliveries and struck 11 fours and three sixes.

Pant out of 3rd India A tie

Keeper-batter Rishabh Pant was ruled out of the third game between India A and New Zealand A, starting on November 7, as a precautionary measure, casting a shadow over his availability for the first Test in Wellington. The first Test begins on November 19 at the Basin Reserve.

Kalyan Chaubey. AFP

'MEMBERS STALLED PREZ CHAUBEY'S PROPOSAL TO LIQUIDATE AIFF'S FD FOR FRIENDLIES'

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NEW DELHI: A proposal by AIFF president Kalyan Chaubey to liquidate the fixed deposit of the federation to pay the deficit arising out of hosting Brazil, Uruguay and Panama for friendlies was stalled by members during its Special General Body Meeting (SGBM) on Sunday, officials who attended the event said.

Chaubey's attempt was a U-turn from his earlier reported claims that the federation would not have to bear any financial burden of the three home friendlies. "Yes, he (Chaubey) said he wants to liquidate the AIFF's FD to pay the deficit," a state unit official told PTI.

"Later, he (Chaubey) said he would arrange funds from outside sources and then pay back whatever amount withdrawn from the FD," the official said, adding the amount was not disclosed on the ground that "there is a confidentiality clause regarding financial matters in the agreement."

To this, the official said, AIFF Vice President NA Haris intervened to say that "there is a decision of the Executive Committee of the AIFF that the FD cannot be liquidated".

"Other members also said for whatever reason, the AIFF's FD cannot be touched."

When contacted, Chaubey told PTI that he would not say anything on the matter.

Back on mat, Susaki says she rediscovered love for wrestling

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NEW DELHI: Yui Susaki has a pretty one-sided relationship with numbers. 82-0 read her international win-loss record coming into the 2024 Paris Olympics where Vinesh Phogat famously ended her reign. 106-0 reads her points won versus conceded stat after the Asian Championships, Asian Games and World Championships 2026.

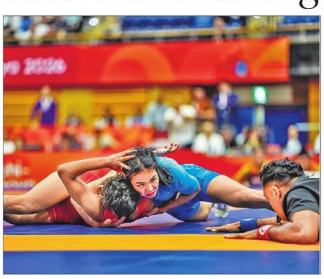
And 13-0 is her win-loss record this year culminating in a fifth World Championships title.

This is jaw-dropping domination, except one has come to associate it with Susaki. The title in Astana though comes with added glitter for the Japanese 50kg winning machine as it arrives on the back of a long hiatus. Following the shock opening round loss to Vinesh in Paris, Susaki returned to the drawing board and went for a reassessment of her game.

Just how much toll can a solitary loss inflict on an athlete who doesn't have a coping mechanism for losses? Here's the answer: "For a year and five months since the Paris Olympics, I trained as usual in Tokyo. I re-evaluated everything, from weight management and physical conditioning, to wrestling itself. I trained all day," Susaki told HT from Astana.

The 27-year-old 2021 Tokyo Olympics champion returned to international competitions at this year's Asian Championships where she won all her four matches. Her streak included an opening round win over China's Ziqi Feng, a Paris Olympics bronze medallist. Susaki pinned her after scoring two points. A 11-0 rout of Neelam followed, before Susaki beat Kazakhstan's Maral Tangirbergenova by fall and beat North Korea's Son Hyang Kim 6-0 in the final. That's 27-0 for the event.

"I wanted to compete as soon as possible, but I held back and prepared to evolve. I prepared to win no matter the situation. I prepared to outperform my opponent and score in any situation," she said.


India's Dipanshi (red) fights Yui Susaki at the Asian Games 2026. PTI

At the Asian Games, Susaki was even more dominant, breezing through her four bouts on way to an emotional triumph on home soil. Her victims included India's Dipanshi (11-0), Cambodia's Samnang Dit (10-0), Kazakhstan's Zeinep Bayanova (4-0, by fall), and North Korea's Son Hyang Kim (10-0) — 35-0 for the competition. But Susaki was only warming up.

"After the Asian Games, all I could think of was to become a five-time world champion," Susaki said. The moment arrived in Astana last week.

Unseeded in the competition and ranked 31st in the world at the time of entering the event because of her 20-month break, Susaki scythed through the field with her technical proficiency. She won all her five bouts, including a 9-0 semi-final victory over China's Feng.

It was supposed to be a bridge too far for Neelam Sirohi in the final in any case, but Susaki was out to reclaim her aura. She pinned the Indian inside the first period to win her first world title since 2023 — 44-0 in the Worlds, meaning with each competition, Susaki's attacks got more lethal.

"I'm really happy to have achieved this. It's one of my most special wins. It's come after a long wait," she said.

Coming from Susaki, the first wrestler to have achieved the Golden Grand Slam — winning all age-group world titles and the Olympics — it's as much a lesson in humility as it is a reflection of the simmering desire to regain her unbeatable self.

"I don't feel any pressure at all anymore. I am proud and happy to be living the life of Yui Susaki. My father was a wrestler. I started wrestling because of him. I have loved wrestling from the day I started until today. During my break from competitions, I sought to rediscover my love for the sport, and I am glad I could do that."

Next on Susaki's radar is the Emperor's Cup All Japan Championships in December. Japan's Olympic qualifiers will begin there, setting in motion a familiar cycle for the all-conquering wrestler. "I want to win the Emperor's Cup All Japan Championships and take a big step towards competing in the LA Olympics. I want to win that Olympic gold again. Susaki 2.0 is ready for the world."

Kajal's golden run, a silver lining and an Olympic dream

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NEW DELHI: Eight competitions, six of them ending on the podium, five of them ending in a gold medal — that's wrestler Kajal Dhochak's 2026. Still only 18, Kajal has come of age on the wrestling mat, proving her mettle across under-20, under-23, and senior divisions in the 76kg Olympic class.

Fresh from silver on her senior World Championships debut in Astana, Kazakhstan recently, the wrestler from Lath village in Haryana's Sonepat district has already trained her sights on the next big challenge.

"I will come back with a gold medal from the next World Championships," she declared on Sunday. "I have had a good look at all my top competitors in Astana and I am sure I have what it takes to finish on top."

The 2027 edition of the Worlds will be held from September 11-19 in Las Vegas. It will be the first qualification event for the Olympics. It awards four quotas per weight class (total 72) to the National Olympic Committees of the medallists (gold, silver, and 2 bronze medallists).

India's women wrestlers have a dismal record at the Olympics, with Sakshi Malik's bronze in Rio 2016 being the lone podium finish.

LA podium in her sights

Kajal is determined to change that. "Winning a Worlds medal gives me the belief that I can secure my qualification and also win an Olympic medal in 2028," she said.

A two-time under-20 world champion, Kajal carries with her the confidence that comes from a sublime junior career but is mindful of what's ahead of her. "Success at age-group level is great but for elite wrestlers, senior Worlds title is equivalent to an Olympic gold. There's a world of difference between competing in junior and senior divisions, but I think I have coped well."

Kajal's senior debut earlier this year got off to a rocky start when she lost to Turkey's Elmira Yasin 7-5 in the second round at the Tirana Ranking Series. Another early exit followed at the Senior Asian Championships in Bishkek where Kazakhstan's Gulmaral Yerkebayeva handed her a 5-3 defeat.

The turnaround began with gold at the U-23 Asian Championships, followed by her first senior-level title at the Ulaanbaatar Ranking Series. She then won the U-20 Asian Championships without conceding a point, claimed another senior title in Budapest and capped the run by defending her U-20 world crown in Bratislava.

Five gold medals on the trot, Kajal entered the senior Worlds as a medal contender. "My coaches and trainers believed in my abilities. Right from the national camp in Delhi's IG Stadium to Astana, they kept telling me that I have the potential to be the best in the world. I went into the Worlds with that mindset. Competing across weight categories meant I got enough match exposure. If you don't compete enough, no matter how good you are, you will be nervous going into a big event. That wasn't the case with me," said Kajal, who is supported by JSW.

Coming from behind

Her winning mindset was on show particularly in the semi-final against Kyrgyzstan's Aiperi Medet Kyzy, a bout in which she overturned a 1-7 deficit to win 10-7.

"I knew I could come back from that deficit," she said. "I kept telling myself there's enough time in the bout and all I need was one opening." That arrived in the second period and Kajal went on a takedown spree to seal the bout.

In the final against Ukraine's Anastasiya Alpyeyeva, Kajal had fought back to level at 4-4 and was ahead on criteria with 20 seconds remaining. But just when the gold seemed within reach, Alpyeyeva found an opening, scored twice and took an 8-4 lead. Kajal managed a late takedown but ran out of time, losing 6-8.

"I need to work on my defence while maintaining an attacking mindset. I can't give an opening to the opponent. If there's one thing I can change from that final, I'd say I'll take my chances in the final minute rather than getting into a defensive mindset."

Going easy in the closing stages cost Kajal a place in the Asian Games-bound team earlier this year where she led Priya Malik in the trial. "I could see the finish line and was already thinking of hugging my uncle (Krishan Malik, also her first coach) in delight when I lost in the final 2-3 seconds. It took me a couple of days to recover. I will channelise this World Championships defeat into something historic next year," she said.